JIN & ADAM

HARMLESS is 20

TWISTED EMOTIONS

TASK FORCE HAWAII

USA TODAY BESTSELLING AUTHOR OF THE SANTINIS SERIES

MELISSA SCHROEDER

Twisted Emotions

Task Force Hawaii

Book Six

OceanofPDF.com

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Hawaiian Terms

Aloha - Hello, goodbye, love
Bra-Bro
Bruddah- brother, term of endearment
Haole-Newcomer to the islands
Howzit - How is it going?
Kamaʻāina-Local to the islands
Mahalo-Thank you
Malasadas- A Portuguese donut without a hole which started out as a tradition for Shrove (Fat) Tuesday. They are deep fried, dipped in sugar or cinnamon and sugar. In other words, it is a decadent treat every person must try when they go to Hawai'i. If you do not try it, you fail. Do yourself a favor. Go to Leonard's and buy one. You are welcome.
Pupule - crazy
Slippahs - slippers, AKA sandals

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Dear Reader:

What a journey Task Force Hawaii has been for me. When I came up with the concept, I didn't know it would take me this long to finish it. Of course, a break for cancer treatment and the road back afterwards seemed to sideline any thoughts of writing Jin and Adam's story.

If this is the first time reading TFH, don't worry. You will not be lost in this book, but truthfully, you will get a great look at the entirety of this relationship through the other books.
If you are worried this is the last of the TFH Team, don't worry. There is a brand new team who appears in this book. Their series is coming in later this year!

Thank you to all the readers who kept encouraging me to finish this series. I didn't know if I could go back into writing romantic suspense of this sort after dealing with my cancer treatment and the loss of my mother. I hope you enjoy Jin and Adam's story.

Aloha,
Mel

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Please Read First

If this is your first book in the TFH series, know that Jin is a rape survivor. The assault took place years ago and she is in a better place thanks to a great therapist and her friends. There is no description of the act, but it is mentioned throughout the book of course. If this is a trigger for you, I completely understand if you have to return the book.

If you or someone you love has been a victim of rape, and you feel that you need help dealing with it, please contact RAINN.

Mel

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For Mom and Dad
This is my first new release without either of you here on Earth with me. You told me I could be anything I wanted to be, and I still believe without your encouragement, I would have never become a writer. You gave Sharon and me a better childhood than either of you experienced. I am who I am because you allowed me to be my own weird person, and I will always be forever grateful.
Love,
Melissa

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One

"I swear by all that is holy, I will hunt you down and kill you!"

The very feminine screech brought Adam Lee out of a deep sleep. Alarm raced through him. What the hell was happening, and why was there a banshee screaming in his house?

He blinked, trying to gain his bearings. He'd had a late night thanks to a hit-and-run with a diplomat. From the sunlight peeking through his blinds, it was after ten in the morning. He had gotten to bed after four.

That threatening voice had been from Makana, his youngest sister. She was the loudest, and that was saying something considering his sisters. He rubbed his hand over his face as another piercing cry reverberated through his tired brain. His sisters were fighting. Again. They always fought over anything and everything.

"I didn't touch your skanky mini-skirt." This came from his middle sister, Nanii. "It's at least a size too big."

Oh, damn, they were out for blood this morning.

"Take that back," Makana said, her voice lowering an octave but just as loud as her yell. That was a sure sign there might be a dead body at the end of the argument. He was trying to figure out if he cared.

"I don't see why. It's true."

This is what he got by moving back home. When his mother lost her job a few years ago, he'd moved back home to help with the bills. It was then that he realized his mother was a saint for not begging him for help with his sisters. He was ten years older than Kailani, his oldest sister, so he was out of the house before they all hit puberty. When his mother had found another

job, he had decided to stay. Being a single parent hadn't been easy on his mom, especially with the three always sniping at each other.

Nope, scratch that. Makana and Nanii were constantly at each other's throats. Kailani tended to ignore them unless they wouldn't shut up when she was studying. Since it was after eight, she was probably on rounds at the hospital already. She was in her last year of residency.

He slipped out of bed, pulled on a pair of jeans, then stepped out of his room. Yes, his sisters had decided to argue right outside his bedroom. It wasn't that their house was big, but there were other places they could have this fight.

"What the hell is going on?"

Both of his sisters turned to glare at him. They were so different from him; they were delicate, where he was broad, and beautiful, where he was a beast. Still, both of them were about to learn that waking him up after such a shitty night wasn't the smartest thing to do.

"Please explain to me why I had to wake up to a fight about a damned skirt?"

"You heard what she said," Makana said, her stubborn glare focused on their middle sister. She was trying to look fierce, but the youngest Lee sibling was so soft that it didn't come off as intense. She was two inches shorter than his other sisters, so she was tiny compared to Adam. Where both of his other sisters were more athletic, Makana wasn't. She was soft and a little more rounded than the other two. She was also sweeter.

"I did. What I don't understand is why you two had to argue outside of my door? You know I was on call last night."

Being second in command for Task Force Hawaii wasn't the easiest job in the world, especially when dealing with a drunken diplomat who thought he could drive away from the scene of an accident.

"Girls, what's going on?" his mother asked, peeking around the corner. He could see one of her reusable grocery bags hanging from her arm.

Merri Lee was a tiny woman with dark black hair now threaded with gray-blue eyes and always a ready smile. Her life had not been easy, raising four kids on her own after her husband died in the line of fire, but from what she'd said, she'd had fun.

"Akamu is being a pain," Makana said. Akamu was Hawaiian for Adam. He had been named for his father, although all his sisters insisted on using the Hawaiian form.

“Makana accused Nanii of wearing her skirt, then Nanii said that Makanna’s clothes were too big for her to wear.”

His mother shook her head. “Both of you get out of here. Adam was working late last night.”

“Working?” Nanii asked a devious glint in her greenish-blue eyes. “Is that what you call it?”

“Yes, that’s what he calls it when he has to go out and deal with some *haole* who hits another car and then runs.”

“Traffic cop?” That snide comment came from Makana.

He opened his mouth to respond, but his mother had had enough. “It is when the person in question works for the Brazilian Consulate.”

Adam raised one eyebrow, but he knew better than to question his mother’s sources. The Auntie Network, as he called it, always seemed to have their fingers on the pulse of what was happening on Oahu. TMZ had nothing on those women.

His sisters grumbled, but they headed off to get ready for work.

“You need more sleep.”

“Kind of hard to do that with two banshees standing outside my room arguing over a skirt.” He shook his head. “They’re both adults.”

“First, Makana just turned nineteen last week, and they’re sisters.” She shrugged. “It’s the way they are.”

He didn’t roll his eyes, but it was close. “I guess I’ll go in.”

She tsked. “You need more sleep.”

Adam shook his head. “You know I’m leading the office this week since Del finally took a week off.”

Typically, he would answer to the commander of Task Force Hawaii, Martin Delano. Both of them were overworked, with more time saved than the state could ever give them. When the boss hurt his back the week before, his wife Emma used it to get him to stay home.

He heard his phone go off.

“Duty calls.”

His mother shook her head as he headed back to his room.

“Lee,” he said.

“Hey, Adam, it’s Rome Carino.”

Rome was their liaison with the Honolulu Police Department.

“Hey, do you need something?”

“I understood Del was off, and you’re in charge.”

“Yeah.”

“Great. Well, not great since we have some bones up here near Waimea.”

“Bones?”

“Yeah. They’re scattered around like the boars have been after them, so we aren’t sure how old they are yet. But considering the complexity of Waimea Valley, the governor wanted TFH in charge.”

Over the years, there had been a lot of controversy about the development on and around the valley, so that made sense. “So it’s just my lucky day,” he said with a chuckle. “Give me thirty, and I’ll be there.”

“You got it. Do you want me to call Elle?”

“No. I’ll call Drew. Elle’s been sick.”

“It’s your funeral when she finds out.”

Yeah. Their ME was a hard worker, but she was also filling in for the HPD ME. He knew the area Rome was talking about. It was a tangle of vines, and she did not need to be out there looking for bones, not when Drew was trained in collecting forensic material.

“No. I would rather deal with her than her spouse. He’s a pain in the ass, and right now, I need his head in the game.”

They were down a few people. Del was off—although Adam was pretty sure his boss would end up in the office at some point—Marcus and Seth—their newest members—were busy training, and things at TFH were kind of in a tizzy. Team Bravo members would start their training process within Task Force Hawaii. Add in the fact that Elle had just entered her eighth month of pregnancy—or, as her husband Graeme called it, the crazy month—so she wasn’t always in the best physical health. Luckily, Drew was fully able to handle the autopsy if needed.

Adam texted Drew the location and got a thumbs up to both the area and that they weren’t telling Elle until they collected the bones. There would be hell to pay, but he could handle women yelling at him. It was sort of his life.

Within ten minutes, he was on his way to the site. He’d prefer his Harley, but a storm was moving in later. With Gabby Pahinui serenading him, he started to think about what the next year would entail for them at work. They were splitting up the teams. The primary team—Team Alpha—would handle most cases, while the others—Bravo and Charlie—would handle other procedures. Bravo would have more of a search and rescue

element, with at least one dog handler on the team. They would also handle any kind of regular cases on Maui and Kauai. There hadn't been many, but with the extra money allotted to them, the governor thought it was better to be safe than sorry.

Team Charlie would handle terrorism threats. All three teams could handle that, but they would specifically look out for those threats and train the other teams. They would also cover Hawai'i or the Big Island. Both teams would be trained to fill in for Alpha. That way, they could quit working overtime type of hours.

In less than ten minutes, Adam reached the edge of the scene. Tape had been put up, and there were guards. They would have a fun day keeping tourists at bay. Some of them treated Hawai'i as an amusement park and not as an actual state, with people living there full-time. The tourism industry supported their state, but it was sometimes beyond annoying to deal with.

He nodded to the two guards and slipped under the tape.

A uniformed officer smiled at him. "Lt. Lee. Howzit?"

He knew Officer Chen. He'd graduated with his oldest sister. It was the way of Oahu. If you lived on the island for any amount of time, you would know about seventy percent of the people, especially if you had siblings or a family member who had served in HPD.

"Doing okay but would be doing better if I wasn't out in this spit this morning."

"I hear ya. Carino is up over the hill, then off to the left. That's where they found the bones."

"Thanks."

He made his way up the hill, his feet slipping here and there in the mud. It was always wet here, it seemed.

When he saw Carino, he almost laughed. The detective wore his trademark dress pants, but he'd rolled up the legs so as not to get them muddy. He was wearing a pair of hiking boots. It was odd-looking, to say the least.

"Adam."

"Rome. Nice outfit."

"Suck it," he said with little heat. Rome Carino was now married to a former FBI agent turned writer. A transplant from Seattle, he had moved here for a new start in life after a bad case on the Seattle PD. TFH thought of him as one of their own and therefore gave him shit all the time.

“So, the bones?”

“Yeah. A hiker found them this morning. Why anyone would want to be out here in this crap, I have no idea. Tourist,” he muttered. He might be a *haole*—an island newcomer—but he started sounding like *kamaʻāina*.

“I feel you. I was thinking your officers were going to have a shitty day dealing with them.”

“Yeah. Even with a storm moving in, they’ll be up here complaining that they planned their day and won’t change their plans. Just like when the box jellyfish show up.”

Each month, the box jellyfish showed up to the islands. Several beaches would post warnings, but some people would refuse to heed the warnings. They paid for a vacation and refused to go to another beach to avoid getting stung.

“We’ve been collecting the bones, and...” Something caught his eye over Adam’s shoulder, and he laughed. When Adam turned around, he inwardly cursed, even if he did chuckle. Elle Middleton-McGregor was making her way up the hill with the help of her big, burly hubby, Graeme. She was dressed in her jumper for work, covering her clothes. Of course, she was hugely pregnant, so she resembled a penguin. Being a man who had grown up and still lived with women, he knew better than to make that observation out loud.

She was frowning at him when she stopped in front of him. “Seriously? I can’t walk up a muddy hill because I’m pregnant?”

“You’re the ME. Not the forensic tech.”

One eyebrow rose. “And you know that I have a police scanner, right?”

He looked at Graeme, who had a bleak look on his face. “Fine, but they already picked up most of the bones.”

She tossed him a dirty look, then turned her attention to Rome. “Male or female?”

“Not sure.”

She rolled her eyes.

“Age?”

“Definitely an adult. The bones were scattered probably because of the boar.”

“Let’s not make up what this is before we know, shall we?” Her British accent deepened over the words. Yep, she was pissed at them.

“Not even sure about the primary scene yet.”

She glanced at him, and they shared a look. Rome was a great detective, but what Rome didn't understand about Elle was that she would see this through. She was a British transplant who had dealt with the darkest side of a case, being attacked by a man they had been hunting. She'd once confessed to him that she had become even more obsessed with justice after that.

"Let's go look at the area, then we can get out of this bloody rain," Graeme muttered. The Scot was constantly grumpy. He helped his wife up the hill, and Adam turned to follow when he saw Drew and Cat making their way up.

"I saw Graeme was here," Drew said.

"Bullshit. You got a text and knew Elle was coming. Just give me a heads-up next time."

Drew nodded, and they all followed Elle and Graeme the rest of the way up the hill.

Elle was already near the scene where many techs seemed to be milling. They were looking for bones.

"This is primary over here," Elle said. "Or at least the body dump."

"I have a feeling the person was killed here," Rome said. "It would take a lot to haul a body up here. There's no way of getting a vehicle up here without raising suspicion."

"Unless they did it at night," Cat said. The TFH member was a local like him, and she had spent a lot of time hiking on the trails. "They might get away with it at night if they had help."

"But this area is closed at night," Rome said. "Of course, if you killed someone, you might not care about rules."

"Depends on the age of the bones. Was this the part of the valley added a few years ago?" Cat asked.

"Not sure, we would have to check that out."

"What are you talking about, for the *haole* in the group?" Rome asked.

"The Waimea Valley was split up at one time. In 2003, there was talk of development with restaurants," Cat explained.

"The protests stopped that," Adam said. "Thankfully."

"Agreed," Rome said. "So, you would have to check into that. Good luck with all of that."

The smirk on his face told Adam he was happy not to have that headache. He hoped the person had just died of natural causes. There were

always people who did dumb shit and got hurt. Doesn't matter how many warnings they put up on the Haiku Stairs, also known as the Stairway to Heaven, people got stuck up there. He was happy they were finally removing the structure because some people didn't have the best judgment.

"Once we get an age on the bones, we can narrow down a time and start looking through footage. Most of these places don't have surveillance. Still, the roads leading here do," Adam said, making a mental note to mention it to Charity, their forensic specialist.

"There are clothes here," Elle said. She kneeled. "They look like a man would wear them, but they might not be his. You need to bag these."

The forensic techs hurried to do her bidding. They all had mad respect for her since both she and Graeme had solved a cold case years ago. But it had more to do with the grumpy giant helping her up out of the mud.

"Now, can we leave?" he grumbled.

"Yes. According to Brett, they have already sent most everything to the lab," she said, smiling at one of the techs. The tech smiled back until he saw Graeme's face. He paled and got to work. Elle rolled her eyes.

"That's what I told you, but you insisted on coming here. And for what?"

"I found those clothes. That's what for."

They continued to bicker as they headed down the hill.

"Cat, I want you to stay with Drew and oversee the rest of the evidence. If the boars did get to the body, they could have scattered his possessions all over the place. Hell, the guy could have died from a heart attack or a drug overdose. It's a mess out here."

She nodded. "I hate to say it, but I hope it's natural or an overdose."

"Same." He didn't want it to be a murder case, but there was something niggling him. Something that told him this would not be an easy case.

"Hey, it could just be a Night Marcher," Cat said.

Adam shook his head, and Cat laughed. Night Marchers were the spirits of Hawaiian warriors that were said to haunt Hawai'i. Making eye contact there would end with the person's soul being ripped from their body and taken to the other world.

"I have serious doubts about that," Adam said. Cat opened her mouth to respond but was stopped by someone shouting about ten yards away.

"I found a skull!"

Adam turned his attention—as did everyone else—toward that person. He and Rome made their way over to the area.

“Well, fuck,” Rome said as he took the skull.

He turned it so Adam could see the back of the skull. There was no way it had been natural or an accident. Not with the small hole in the back of the head indicating he had been shot execution style.

“Well, I guess that answers that question,” Rome said. He slapped Adam on the back. “Good luck with that.”

Damn. He should have known the screaming banshee wake-up call was a bad sign.

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Two

Jin Phillips stared out the window, thinking of the way the sun had felt on her skin when she'd been working in her garden earlier. It was a beautiful day. One in a long string of them, but then Jin lived in Hawai'i, where the sun shined over three hundred days a year. There was a gentle trade wind moving the trees back and forth. The banyan tree right outside the window barely registered it. The leaves rustled, and even though she was inside, Jin was sure she could hear it.

"And your new venture, how is that going?"

Jin pulled her gaze from the scene beyond the window and focused on her therapist. The older woman had been a godsend these last few years. Not many people would have been able to help Jin after what she had been through, but Dr. Nells had.

She was a diminutive woman with dark eyes that made her look wise beyond her years. It was one of the first things that Jin noticed about her. Dr. Nells seemed to know how to help Jin, which was a phenomenal feat. Before coming in for therapy, Jin had tried to deal with her demons on her own. It had been a disaster that had left her teetering on the edge of becoming permanently agoraphobic.

"The podcast?" Dr. Nells nodded. "Well. I didn't think I would ever be able to do something in the news again, but *Beyond Murder* has been gaining subscribers and lots of revenue."

"And you think it's best you remain anonymous on it?"

"Yes."

She didn't need people with a weird fetish hunting her down. Doing the unsolved crime podcast allowed her to use the reporter skills she once

thought would shoot her to national fame. Now, she just wanted to use those skills for good. With her personal experience, she had been on the other side of the lens. It had taught her that there was a shining light on crime and another that fed into a sick need for some people. Jin had decided she wanted to still report, but in a way that did more good. It was why she still refused any interviews. She would refuse an interview with Keith Morrison, and he was the king of true crime.

As the silence lengthened, she realized Dr. Nells wanted an explanation.

“I want people to listen for the stories.”

“Your case interests people.”

This had been something they had discussed at length. As the only survivor of a couple of serial killers, Jin had a lot of requests for interviews. Most people had anonymity to an extent, but since she had been working on the story when she was abducted, it seemed to spur on her fellow reporters.

“Yes. But my case isn’t unsolved. We know who abducted me. We know what happened.”

She hated the way her voice hitched over the word *happened*. It made her feel weak, and she despised that. Of course, Dr. Nells picked up on it.

“You are not weak.”

“I know. And I know how far I’ve come since those monsters took me. It still doesn’t make it any easier that it’s the first thing people think when they see me. Most other rape survivors don’t have to deal with every person on the face of the earth knowing what happened to them.”

Her case had been one of the biggest in the history of Hawai’i. Two serial killers had traveled the world, raping and killing women. Thanks to Task Force Hawaii, they were finally caught, saving her just in time. The men usually kept the women for about a week before they killed them. It had been her luck to have the entire team looking for her, and they had saved her with less than thirty-six hours left.

“Understandable. Is that why you’re avoiding social settings?”

“No. I’m not. I’m going to a wedding shower luncheon.”

“Oh? With the Task Force Hawaii folks?”

She nodded. With them, she felt normal, or at least somewhat normal. Their commander and his now-wife were the two who ended up saving her. And Elle, their medical examiner, was a rape survivor herself and had helped Jin through the darkest times. Then there was Adam.

“But no dating?”

It’s like Dr. Nells could read her mind. Jin sighed and looked outside again. “I’m not ready. Not sure if I will ever be ready again.”

“That is understandable. The one thing I worry about is that you seem to avoid men altogether. While that’s also understandable, you need to make sure that you keep moving forward. What about Adam?”

Jin cut a look at the therapist. Well, Dr. Nells definitely didn’t come to play today. Just pulling off that bandage, scab, and all. “What about him?”

“He seems to care about you. From what you have said, you had a relationship before you were abducted.”

“Yes. But we were more on again, off again before everything.”

“And since?”

Since…he always looked at her as if he needed to save her. That was worse than being angry with her. “He sees me as a victim. I don’t want that from a man.”

“Are you sure that’s how he sees you? Or is that how you see you?”

She chuckled. “You know I hate riddles.”

“That wasn’t a riddle, and you’re avoiding the question.”

Another sigh slipped away. “I’m not sure if it’s that or I don’t trust my own judgment. I mean, I was a reporter who was stupid enough to meet with a man about a serial killer. A *male* serial killer.”

She still couldn’t get over how naive she had been. She thought she had been smart, telling people she was meeting with someone. But what good had it done since they didn’t know who she was meeting? She’d walked right into the bastard’s clutches.

“Jin, I’ve told you it wasn’t stupid. The man was a master manipulator.”

“I know that in my head,” she said, motioning to her temple. “But in my heart, I still feel stupid.”

Dr. Nells nodded. “And I have said that’s normal. Just don’t beat yourself up about it.”

The alarm went off, heralding that their time was over.

“Well, I think today was a good day.”

Jin smiled. Again, she really didn’t know how she would have gotten through these last few years without her therapist. From those first few days, she had been unable to leave her house. Dr. Nells had come to her to help her deal with everything plaguing her. Even dealing with the trauma of her screwed-up childhood.

“Yes, I think it was.”

Some days, she broke down. The tears and the anger were easier to deal with since they didn't seem to bother her as often. "I featured my first Hawaiian cold case today. You should listen."

Her therapist's eyes widened. "Don't tell me you covered the Alana Kim case?"

Since Dr. Nells had been the one to suggest it, Jin had been obsessed with the mystery. Dead Hawaiian woman, missing billionaire's son…all over a decade ago, and still no leads. Jin couldn't pass it up.

"Yes. Today we have the case itself, talking about Alana and Dylan. Their backgrounds, their relationship, then all the way up to her death. Next week, we'll cover the crime in more detail and where Dylan might be."

The fact that a billionaire's bad-boy son had gotten away with murder had angered Hawaiians. It was another sign that the system was working against them. Jin's theory was that while he was a total douche, Dylan was a harmless one. And while Dylan's father, Michael Brewer, had money that would help hide his son, Jin doubted Dylan was still alive. He was one of those people who always had to be in the spotlight. When he had a string of DUIs—one resulting in a death—he'd partied more than he ever did. In other words, he was an asshole.

"I'll listen. Have fun at the wedding shower."

Jin exhaled as she parked her car just behind a minivan. She knew it was Emma Delano's. Who would have thought the awkward genius and the growly commander would find love? But they had. In fact, they had done it while solving Jin's case. At least something good had come out of that horror.

She pushed back those thoughts. Now was a time for celebration. Grabbing the gift, she slipped out of the car. The house was massive, one of those mansions you see on TV or in the movies. She knew that Emma's brother and his lovers lived here. The signs suggested that she make her way to the back of the house.

She followed the stone path around the house and took in the view. The Kailua estate had a kick-ass view of the ocean and beach access. She would

kill for a view like this, but not many could afford it, especially a former reporter who survived, thanks to a podcast.

Still, she could dream. There was something so calming about the sound of waves. It was one of the reasons she hadn't moved immediately after she recovered from her abduction. Hawai'i had snuck into her soul and grabbed hold of it. And while she had a lovely house in Kapolei, it didn't have the fantastic views this house had.

"There you are," Elle called out. Dr. Elle Middleton MacGregor had been a friend these past few years. They both had suffered at the hands of men and in a public way. When people said they could empathize with Jin about her abduction, they really couldn't. In Elle, Jin had found someone who understood all too well. It was Elle who gave her hope. If her friend could make things work for her, Jin was sure she could do it as well.

The English transplant looked the part of the stereotypical English Rose. Long blond hair pulled back into a loose braid, light blue eyes, and a fair complexion made her look fragile. Even in her third trimester, she walked with grace. But beneath that veneer was a tough woman who had survived horrible things and came out on the other side.

"Here I am. I got stuck on Kam Highway. Wreck."

"Yeah, I heard." She waited for Jin to make the first move. Physical contact was still difficult, especially on days like today. Still, she needed that friendly warmth that Elle always seemed to exude.

With a smile, she hugged her friend, drawing in the familiar rose scent of her perfume. When Jin pulled back, she realized that Elle was misty-eyed.

"Hey, is everything okay?"

She nodded and waved her hand. "Don't mind me. I've gotten a little emotional today. I was so emotional this morning that Graeme threatened me if I cried one more teardrop."

"And you did what?"

"Got mad at him."

And from the faint blush on the doctor's face, Jin had an idea of what transpired after that. Elle had said that their fights were like foreplay for the two of them.

"Wait, you were coming from Honolulu?"

Jin nodded. "Yeah. I had an appointment with Dr. Nells."

“Ah. Good.” Jin knew that Dr. Nells was Elle’s friend. She had been the first to suggest the doctor to Jin, and she was grateful. “And I caught your episode today.”

“You did?”

She was always surprised when her friends told her they had listened to her podcast. Granted, as a reporter, her face was plastered everywhere. That was different. Only her close friends knew about her podcast. Jin kept her life very private now. Her only social media was attached to the podcast, not her name.

“Yes. I can’t wait for the second part.”

Jin nodded, not correcting her friend. There would be three parts of the story, but she hadn’t wanted to tell people that. She would throw that at them in two weeks.

“There is nonalcoholic punch over there since I know you don’t drink.”

She nodded.

“There’s also cake I might have had two pieces of already. I was starving.”

Jin smiled. “Everyone deserves cake.”

Elle linked her arm with Jin’s and guided her to the food.

“Wait, let me give this to Cat, and then we can go eat.”

She set her package down on the table. Cat smiled at her; her happiness brought up a yearning…a need she had ignored for several years. Jin missed men, missed dating…and she missed one in particular.

Adam Lee and she had dated long before her abduction, but he’d gotten under her skin. Now, he was just a friend. She wanted more, or at least she wanted to try, but he saw her as damaged. While she understood his feelings, it didn’t make it any easier being his friend.

She went to the cake table where her friend Elle was already getting herself another piece of cake.

“This cake is just so good,” Elle said as she took a bite.

Jin grabbed herself a piece of cake, and then they made their way over to the group of friends. TFH folks were peppered throughout, but there were also family members from Cat and Drew, the groom-to-be. They were both locals, so they had a lot of family.

Autumn Bradford rose and made her way over to Jin and Elle. She was tallish for a woman, with shoulder-length auburn hair and green eyes. She

was dressed in slacks as usual, making her legs look longer. She plopped down in the chair next to Jin's.

"I've been thinking about your request."

Jin glanced around. The TFH people knew she was behind *Beyond Murder*, but she was always worried someone would find out.

Autumn shook her head. "Don't worry. I understand about the anonymity thing. Do you think I like everyone knowing I was that idiot's daughter?"

Autumn's father had been the leader of the cult Joyous Wave, who had a massive shootout with the FBI and ATF over fifteen years earlier.

"So you don't want to do it?"

"I didn't say that. I thought we could work on finding some way to keep me anonymous."

She blinked. "You think people don't know who you are?"

"TFH does. You do, but you're part of our *o'hana*. What I want to make sure of is that other people don't know my name now. There are still nutjobs out there who think he's the Messiah."

It struck Jin that Autumn always discussed her father in the present tense. It was something that had intrigued her from the first time they'd talked about it.

"And I need a little bit of time before we do it. I have some loose ends to tie up. I'll let you know."

"But you will do it?"

She nodded. "People need to know what a monster they all were. I need some more cake."

Then she popped off the chair and went to the table.

"What's up with her?" Elle asked.

"I want to cover cults, and I wanted to interview her."

Elle shook her head. "I can't imagine a life like she had."

Jin nodded but said nothing else. She needed to stay present in the moment, something that had helped her recover from her trauma. And well, today was about Cat Kalakau and her happiness.

Michael Brewer sat in front of the window that overlooked the Pacific Ocean. He'd moved here years ago looking for a son, the one everybody thought was a murderer, but he couldn't find it in his heart to believe that, too. Dylan had been a troubled kid, losing his mother when he was only four, and he never really recovered.

His phone buzzed on the coffee table in front of him. He noticed the number was unknown, so he ignored it. At that moment, it stopped, then started to back up again. He picked it up this time but didn't answer it. In the years since Dylan disappeared, he had often gotten crank calls. People were always looking to make a buck off false info. Then there were the people who thought his son was a murderer. The things they said were beyond disgusting.

Again, the buzzing stopped, then started right back up. This was because of that *Beyond Murder* podcast. It had stirred people up. He should have known that this would start up again. He'd already talked to the Governor. They would announce another hike in the reward money.

When the phone started buzzing a fourth time, he grabbed it up.

"What?"

Silence. Nothing was said, as usual. Well, it's not normal. He always seemed to have two types of callers. Either they screamed that his son was a monster, or they were silent.

"Listen, coward, if you have nothing to say, stop calling."

"You need to leave the island."

It was a male voice with a Hawaiian lilt. "Excuse me?"

"You need to leave. Everything is going to get much worse."

He opened his mouth to respond but knew in the next second that the caller had hung up.

His head buzzed, and the room around him spun. How had they gotten his number? And just who the hell were they? He had expected a call from Hank, but he hadn't been prepared for that kind of call.

He drew a deep breath and looked over the pool to the Pacific Ocean. Since Dylan had disappeared, his life had changed drastically. This was weird, though. He expected drop calls or even threats. But he didn't think that was what this was. Instead, it sounded like a warning.

What the hell was that about, and why should he leave the island?

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Three

Adam walked into TFH headquarters Monday morning, somewhat rested. They'd had no midnight calls, so he had gotten over six hours of sleep, which was good for him. It was just before sunrise, so the place was quiet, although many of the team were already at work. He probably needed to have a chat with the boss about that. Dedication was a good thing, but when it was taken to the extreme, it would result in an overworked force unable to do their job.

That was one of the reasons the new team structure was going into effect in a couple of months. Granted, he noticed that Graeme wasn't in yet, so that was something. As he turned the corner, he inwardly cursed. There, in his office, sat Del, his boss. Martin Delano could be a workaholic, and the team was taking their cues from him.

He knocked on the door and then opened it.

"What are you doing in?"

Del shrugged, then winced. Yeah, his back was still not one hundred percent. "I woke up early. No matter how long I'm out of the military, I keep those hours."

Del had been Army Special Forces, although, he'd retired a few years ago to take over Task Force Hawai'i when it was first formed. He still wore his hair military short and had the same physique as a soldier in the prime of his life.

"Yeah, but all of them are here because you are."

One eyebrow rose. "Uh. They all beat me here. Hell, I think Autumn practically sleeps here."

The former DEA agent took workaholic to a new level, but Adam understood. She'd lived and breathed undercover in the DEA before she joined the TFH team. Once you live like that, it's hard to acclimate to everyday life again.

"Besides, I got a call from the Governor."

He motioned for Adam to shut the door. He did and settled in the seat in front of Del's desk.

"Not sure if you follow it, but *Beyond Murder*—you know the podcast?"

Adam nodded. Of course, he knew the podcast. He also knew that Jin was the person behind it. She kept her name secret, and he didn't blame her. After she had been abducted and kept by those two sick fucks, all anyone wanted to ask her about was her abduction. He figured that's why she'd been pulled into the TFH *o'hana*. They didn't constantly ask her to relive that horrible week.

"I figured. Anyway, Jin covered the Alana Kim murder."

He blinked. "That's the first local cold case she's covered."

Del sighed and nodded, his mouth in a grim line. Adam's "Yeah. And, of course, that caused a ruckus here."

Adam assumed she hadn't covered the case because she didn't want people to know she lived in Hawai'i, although he was sure many knew. Even with all the voice lessons she took as a reporter, she often slipped back into a cadence most Hawaiians would recognize. Covering this case would get her a lot of attention, but that wasn't always good.

"So, the Governor thinks we're his personal detective agency?" his voice came out much harsher than he planned. Del's eyebrows rose.

"Sorry, boss. It's just," he slipped his hand over his head. "It's not best for her to put herself out there."

"Not sure that's a problem. People don't know who she is."

"She's kept herself hidden for years now. If people know it's her, they'll start obsessing about everything again."

He could not bear Jin going back to the person she was in the months after the attack. She had become a shell of herself. In the last year, she seemed to find balance and happiness again.

Del didn't say anything for a few moments. Their gazes held. Adam knew Del was testing him. And he understood he was being emotional about it.

“It’s not like many people here don’t know who she is. Or at least, they think they know who it is.”

Adam sighed as he rose to walk over to look out Del’s office window. “Yeah, but this isn’t just about Alana Kim. It’s about that bastard Brewer. That will attract so many *haoles*.”

“That’s why I asked her to come in this morning.”

Adam knew that was coming, so he just nodded. If the governor was involved—especially in an election year—they would have to talk to Jin.

“And I plan on having you work with her on the case.”

His eyes widened. “Wouldn’t Graeme be a better fit? He and Elle solved that cold case a couple years ago.”

Del gave him a strange look. “He’s working with Marcus on a few things, including setting up the teams.”

Another directive from the governor. They needed teams ready to deploy to the other islands and to give the primary team time off. He was all for it when it happened. Now, he wasn’t so sure.

“Also, you know what a bear he is during the last part of Elle’s pregnancy. I would also hate for him to start working on it and then have to quit because she went into labor.”

“Well, then, what about Cat?”

“She’s working with the teams gauging who will best fit in for sniper training, and then there’s the wedding. And I assure you, she doesn’t have time for this. But, hey, if you want to tell her to add more work things to her schedule, you go right ahead.”

Out of all of them, Cat was the best long-range shooter. Yeah, as much as he loved Cat, there was a good chance she would damage him if he came at her with another request. He went through who was left. Tamilya was leaving in a couple weeks to attend a DC conference, and Autumn was… Autumn. She wasn’t great at working with others for long.

“And don’t try to come up with someone else. You’re the best fit for this. You remember the case, right?” Adam nodded. “That will go a long way. You have some memories of what was going on at the time. Besides, nothing may come of this. I reviewed the case this weekend, and the two detectives who worked on it did well. There just wasn’t enough to go on.”

Adam wanted to agree, but something in his gut told him that would not happen. People might lose their memories over time, which makes a cold case hard to deal with, but time could also shake things loose. Friends had

falling outs, lovers broke off relationships, and people ran out of money to bribe others.

“She’s here.”

He blinked, again stunned by the comment. He turned and saw Graeme talking to her. She was laughing at something he said, and envy rose up to choke him. He and Jin had been an on-and-off item until she’d broken his trust. Then those two bastards had broken her. Now, it was always awkward when they met up. People were always around the two of them these days, and he never knew what to say.

He turned as Graeme knocked on the door. The giant Scotsman opened the door. “Hey, boss. Look what the cat dragged in this morning.”

She rolled her eyes, but she was smiling. That smile always hit him straight in the chest, and this was no different. The first time he saw her, she had been smiling, her dimples in full force just as they were now, and her eyes sparkled. There had been a time that he worried she would never smile again.

“Good morning, Del,” she said, her throaty voice filling the office. He curled his fingers into his palms to keep from reaching out. “Adam.”

He nodded.

“Thanks, Graeme. Please have a seat, Jin.”

Graeme gave Del a suspicious look, which told Adam that Del hadn’t revealed the reasons for Jin’s visit with anyone but him. The other man closed the door, leaving them alone.

“Would you like anything to drink?”

Jin shook her head. “Already had too much caffeine today. Why don’t you tell me why it was important for me to haul my ass out of bed to see you this morning?”

Jin had to fight the urge to start tapping her foot. She knew many people would see it as a sign of impatience, but for her, it was a sign of nerves. When Jin got nervous, she always needed to move. Pacing was her usual choice, but she was sure Del and Adam would look at her as if she’d lost her mind if she popped out of the chair. She’d had enough of that over the years from other people.

“It’s almost seven.”

This came from the hunk of man sitting beside her. She glanced at him quickly and shrugged. “I was up late reading.”

That much was true. Of course, most of it had been reports about the Alana Kim murder. Which, knowing Adam, he would not think was a good thing for her to do. Adam always had a lot of ideas on what was good for her and what wasn’t. She often disagreed with him, but it didn’t make her want him any less. Before *that* week, she had always thought they would work out their relationship. Now, there was no chance because no man really wanted a woman as damaged as she was now.

“I feel it’s about the case I called you here to discuss.”

She forced herself to look at Del. He was a beautiful man with golden brown eyes and a quick smile. He wasn’t her type of man, though. No, her perfect man was sitting beside her, judging her for being tired.

“And what case would that be?”

Adam made a rude noise, but she didn’t look at him. Del’s gaze flicked to Adam, then back to her.

“I know you try to keep your name out of it, but we know you’re the host of *Beyond Murder*. And we have been getting all kinds of calls about it.”

She said nothing, letting the time drag out as they stared at each other. She might not be an official reporter or work for a big news agency, but she still had skills. Staring down a man was absolutely something she could do.

“Alana Kim.”

Just Del saying the name had her inwardly cringing.

“You have? Not HPD?”

“Yes, and I’m not sure. But as you know, we get called in when something becomes high profile.”

Dammit, she did know that, but she hadn’t expected it to happen like this. And definitely not this fast.

“*This* is high profile. Color me surprised.” Jin didn’t try to hide her sarcasm. There were definitely holes in the case. “I mean, it’s been sixteen years since Alana Kim was left on Pounders Beach. All of a sudden, it’s a priority?”

Del’s mouth twitched. His wife Emma had a genius-level IQ, and from everything Jin had heard and seen, his little girl favored her mother. Both of

them kept him on his toes, and from his expression, he knew she wasn't judging him.

"Did you not pay attention to the social media posts?"

She shook her head. After her rescue, she learned not to spend time on social media. Her mental health was too fragile for it. She had a PA who handled all that, and Samantha was a true gem.

"#JusticeforAlana is still trending this morning. TikTok has gone insane, along with whatever Twitter is being called today. Word on the street is that *Hawai'i News Today* is planning a feature this week."

"And that's why you got the call?"

He nodded. "The Governor—"

"The Governor?" Did her voice squeak?

He nodded. "He's a bit overwhelmed with the calls from locals, but when the father of the missing man starts calling, that's a problem."

"Of course." She couldn't keep that sarcasm out of her voice. "One of the richest men in the country calls for the investigation to stop, and the governor steps in."

Del held up his hand. "That's not what's happening. Brewer is re-upping the award. And the governor wants TFH on the job."

She tilted her head, studying him, and then slanted Adam a look. God, he was so her type. Filled with muscles, all that golden skin. Before she met him, she had never liked a man with a bald head, but he was so damned sexy. Even now, with the frown, Jin's heart skipped a couple beats.

"And you think your team has better things to do?"

"No," Adam said with a shake of his head. "That murder has haunted the islands for over a decade. If it can be solved, it needs to be solved. I don't like the idea of you being put in the spotlight again."

She sighed. Adam saw her as a broken woman who couldn't handle her life. She was definitely going to mention this to Dr. Nells. Jin really liked being right about things, but this one stung. She wished things were different and he didn't know about her past. Even if it were pretend, she wanted to spend one date with him, thinking she was whole.

"I can handle it, and remember, I remain hidden. No one knows it's me."

He rolled his eyes. They were dark, almost black, but a dark golden rim surrounded his irises.

"I bet more people know than you think."

Jin frowned and wanted to refute him, but Del didn't give her time.

"Jin," he said, waiting for her to look at him again. "We're taking up the case. You know that if it can be solved, we will solve it."

That much was true. Still, this felt like a brush-off.

"And you want me to can my episodes."

He shook his head. "The governor, mayor, and attorney general want us to help you. How many more episodes about the murder do you have planned?"

"I have two more."

"Have you recorded them?"

Jin shook her head.

"You do them every other week, right?" Del asked.

"Yes." And just how did he know that? Well, he just said he listened, and she knew Emma did. It was like all her critical thinking flew out the window the moment she saw Adam. That was nothing new.

"We all listen to your podcast, Jin," Del said, pulling her attention from Adam. Admiration filled his tone, and she sat up even straighter. "Good reporting, and you don't sensationalize the story. You show respect to the victims and their loved ones. So next week, you'll have the disappearance podcast, right?"

"Yes."

"Good, we can hit the ground running. I've assigned Adam to this. I want you to share everything you have with him."

"I'm not going to—"

He held up his hand again. "No, you're misunderstanding me. And yes, I know what you were going to say. I've had to learn to keep on my toes around smart women. Adam is going to help you in exchange for your research."

"I am?"

She didn't look at the man sitting next to her. Being shut down was one thing. Working with the man she still dreamed about regularly was terrible.

"You are. We will give you limited access—you know we have to limit what you can reveal if it is still an open case."

She nodded as her heart beat an insane rhythm.

"We'll allow you to have all the inside information on the case that we can, with the agreement that you keep it under wraps. We'll need to approve

everything you release until the case is closed. We will want to keep some things out of the public because of the case.”

She understood that. Law enforcement often held back information that could be used against the perpetrator.

“Adam is going to be in charge of all of that. You two can work together. He’ll give you daily updates.”

“I will?”

There was an edgy humor in his voice. And even though she felt as if she’d had a head-on collision with her past, she felt her lips twitch.

“You will. I have a feeling Jin has done a deep dive into the case. The original investigation was good, but I’m sure she found some things that aren’t there.”

She didn’t say anything.

“I don’t think it’s a good idea.”

She slanted Adam a look. “And why is that?”

“It could expose you.”

Before she could tell him to bugger off—her favorite UK phrase she had picked up from Elle—Del answered him.

“Hate to tell you, that ship has probably already sailed. With a trending topic on something as obscure as this cold case, people will start trying to dig into who runs *Beyond Murder*.”

Her breath froze in her chest. Damn. She hadn’t thought about that.

“I think if you’re working with her, you can get this solved faster. She can get her episodes out, and then maybe it can cool down. You can be the face of the investigation, Adam. If Jin wants to step into the spotlight, she can, but if we can give the press someone to concentrate on, she’ll have that choice.”

Tears burned the backs of her eyes, but she blinked rapidly to keep them under control. Jin didn’t like crying. Never had it, and she knew it stemmed from her childhood. Her parents didn’t appreciate displays of emotion and punished her when she showed any. It was just so kind of Del, and she knew that her friend Emma had found a prince of a man.

“Thank you.”

He nodded. “You two need to devise a working plan if that’s agreeable to both of you.”

She sensed Adam’s nod.

“Good. Now, I can get back to all the crap Emma has planned for me to do. Go away.”

She chuckled and rose. “Say hi to Emma for me.”

Adam opened the door for her. It was one of the things she loved about him. Jin was a feminist, but having a man pay attention to the little things was nice. Since she knew he grew up surrounded by women, Jin assumed they had drummed it into him.

“Let’s go to my office,” he said, motioning to his office.

Once she stepped into it, she was surrounded by pictures. There were plaques on the walls, along with photos she knew Adam had taken. They all showed his favorite places on the island. His desk and bookcase were filled with framed pictures of friends, but mostly of his family.

“How are your sisters doing?” she asked as she settled into one of the two seats in front of his desk.

He didn’t answer her until he sat down. “The same, but louder.”

Jin laughed. She hadn’t met his sisters when they were dating, but the stories about them had never failed to make her laugh. She grew up an only child, so big families always mesmerized her.

He sobered quickly. “So, this case.”

She nodded. “Yeah. I’ve been researching it for the last six months.”

“Does it normally take you that long?”

She snorted. “No. Most of the time, it takes a month. I planned on covering the case a few months ago, but I just kept turning up things.”

“Like what?”

“There’s just so many avenues. Things that the press ignored back in the day.”

“But not West and Iona?”

He would know their names right off the top of his head.

“No. Many people blamed them for the case going cold, but they just didn’t have enough evidence. They ran a good investigation, but you can do only so much without evidence or leads.”

“I haven’t listened to this week’s episode.”

Everything in her seemed to still but her heartbeat. It was pounding so loud; she was sure Adam could hear it. “You listen to my podcast?”

He looked at her like she had lost her mind. “Of course I do. Like Del said, you do thorough investigations. I take it you think that there’s more to this story than what the press covered?”

She nodded. “A lot more.”

He blew out a breath. “Okay. I assume you have all the information at your house?”

She nodded. It wasn’t the only place. She kept the hard copies at her house, but she had several places where she kept digital records.

“I want to look over the case and see if I can hunt up West and Iona.”

“West moved to Maui a few years ago and died last year. I spoke to his wife.”

“Yeah?”

“She said this case haunted him until his death.”

“Makes sense. And Iona?”

“Retired. Lives over in Waimanalo. He’s cagey and wouldn’t talk to me.”

She didn’t blame him. The press had crucified him years ago, and being *the* Hawaiian on the case, he’d been vilified. Word was that he spent most of his days drinking and fishing.

“Okay. He might talk to me. I think my dad knew him. I’ll look over the case, make some calls, and then come over to see you. Are you free this afternoon?”

She nodded. “I moved.”

“I know.”

“You do?”

He smiled, and she hated the funny feeling she got in her stomach. The man was gorgeous, a Hawaiian god…all bronze skin and muscles. There was just something about Adam that always tugged at her. “Yeah. You know you can’t keep secrets with this motley crew.”

She laughed. “True. Still have the same number?”

“Yeah.”

“I’ll text you my address. How about four this afternoon? I’m recording the disappearances episode this afternoon.”

“Sounds good.”

He saw her out of TFH and to her car. She knew it was nothing more than being a gentleman, but it was hard not to get that feeling again. Since her abduction and everything that went on with that, she rarely looked at men that way. It was hard, with the most vivid, horrible memories still crowding her thoughts. But when she was around Adam, it was difficult not to have them. He made her feel safe, but he also made her feel sexy. It

wasn't that he leered at her or said anything that made her think he was still interested in her. It was just his manner, and it had been what had attracted her to him in the first.

But that ship had sailed, and there was no going back.

Autumn Bradford watched Jin and Adam as the door closed behind them, and then she sent a group text to the rest of TFH, excluding Adam and the boss.

Autumn: *I think we have another couple to bet on.*

Graeme: *Why are you texting all of us when we are in the building?*

Autumn: *Cat was at the firing range.*

Cat: *Just walked in. What's up?*

Emma: *I can't be there. Del is on his way home. Keep me apprised.*

Autumn: *Bullpen, everyone.*

She stepped out of her office just as everyone else did.

"What did I miss?" Cat asked. The sharpshooter was dressed in a t-shirt and cargo pants. Her hair was pulled back up into a ponytail. A small woman with lethal skills. Autumn admired that about her.

"Let's wait until everyone gets here," Autumn said.

As she said it, the elevator doors opened, revealing Elle, Drew, and Charity. They rushed in. Well, Charity and Drew did. Elle waddled slowly.

"Love, you shouldn't be walking."

Elle rolled her eyes as Graeme swept her into his arms as if she weighed nothing.

"How'd shooting go?" Drew asked Cat as he kissed her cheek.

Cat gave her fiancé a toothy grin. "Fantastic. I think I have the top two candidates for Team Bravo."

The front doors opened, and they all turned, probably worrying like she did that it would be Adam or Del. Those two did not like the betting pools.

Instead, it was Tamilya, Marcus, and the newest team member, Seth Harrington. Everyone called him Harry. She called him Seth or SEAL. The former SEAL made her nervous when he looked at her with clear grey eyes.

"What's shaking?" Marcus said. His voice had that southern twang that made most women melt, but it didn't matter. The hot African American was

all in with his girlfriend, Tamilya.

“According to Autumn, there’s another couple to bet on,” Drew said as he zeroed his gaze at her. “Do you have something to tell us?”

“No. There is enough insanity around here, and I will never lose my mind over a man.”

“Not even Ian?” Charity asked with a laugh. “He spends a lot of time here.”

“Gross. No. He’s like a brother to me.” The former MI-6 agent now worked for Dillon Security. They went way back, more than most people knew. She pushed those thoughts aside. “Jin was in today. Boss assigned Adam to work with her on the Alana Kim case.” Autumn had a feeling they didn’t know everything about the case. No one did, but…again, she pushed those thoughts away. She would deal with that when she felt the time was right.

“Oh…oooooh,” Charity said. “They have a history.”

“Yeah, I always had that feeling.” Autumn joined the team about a year after Jin’s abduction, so she didn’t know the entire history.

“That would be such a sweet thing,” Elle said. She was the closest to Jin.

“Cat can’t handle the bets. She’s going to be too busy.” Charity’s phone went off with the Avengers theme from that first movie. Fitting since her husband’s first name was Thor.

“TJ wants in on whatever we’re betting.”

TJ was their FBI liaison, who had first been sent to investigate Charity and fell in love with her. She understood the attraction on both parts since TJ was a hot FBI agent with a quick smile, and Charity was so quirky and gorgeous.

“Maybe he should be in charge of the betting,” Seth said.

“Why would we do that?” she asked, still not looking straight at him. She knew it was a tell, but she couldn’t help it.

“We all have training. And when are you leaving?” Seth asked, looking at Tamilya.

“Two weeks from today.”

“TJ won’t be as caught up as us.”

“Good idea,” Cat said.

“He said he is okay with handling it,” Charity said.

“So, what’s the bet?” Graeme asked.

“How long will they hold out?” Autumn asked. When everyone agreed, she smiled. “Text TJ.”

Pulling out her phone to text, she noticed she had missed one from Ian.

Ian: *Word is one of The Circle is back on the islands.*

Her blood went cold.

“What’s wrong?”

She jumped when she realized Seth had snuck up on her. He was always doing that, too, which irritated her. She rarely let anyone sneak up on her. Growing up in her father’s cult, followed by working undercover for the DEA, had taught her how to pay attention to threats.

“Nothing. Just forgot to do something.”

She sent in her bet, then slipped her phone into her back pocket again.

“Better get your bet in, SEAL.”

His mouth quirked. “Already done. Why do you call me SEAL?”

She shrugged. “Just feel like it.”

Her phone buzzed and she pulled it out.

Ian: *Your apartment in 20.*

“Well, this has been fun, Seth.” He frowned at her, and she wanted to smile, but she didn’t. She knew he hated his first name. “I gotta see a man about a thing. Heading out, Graeme. Gotta meet an informant.”

He nodded, and she turned off her office lights and grabbed her keys. She could feel Seth’s gaze burning into her back, but she ignored it. She had to concentrate on the critical news Ian had just sent and what the hell the two of them would do about it.

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Four

It was almost one in the afternoon when Adam strode into TFH headquarters. Frustration and anger simmered in his blood. He had spent the morning and his lunchtime searching for Iona. That bastard was nowhere to be found. Adam knew he was still on the island, but the retired cop knew how to make himself scarce, that's for sure. He wondered if when Jin contacted Iona, the retired detective decided to hide out somewhere. He understood, to a point. He hadn't entirely settled behind his desk when there was a knock at the door.

He could see Autumn, so he motioned with his hand for her to come in.

"What do you need?"

She shut the door behind her, which was odd, but he waited until she sat in front of his desk. She was in her early thirties. He couldn't imagine what her childhood had been like in a cult.

Looking at Autumn, he could see why she was so good at undercover when she worked with the DEA. She looked like an innocent girl next door, but he had worked with her and knew she wasn't. People ignored the threat and looked at her wavy chin-length hair, green eyes, and freckles across the bridge of her nose. The woman could take down a man twice her size with no problem.

"I wondered if Jin was here because of the Alana Kim case."

They didn't keep things from each other, or at least not everything. The TFH thrived on the fact that they could work on a multitude of cases, and most people were kept apprised of what was happening. He nodded.

"I might have some information."

He frowned. “You were what…fifteen years old when the murder occurred?”

She nodded, then rolled her shoulders. She was one of the newest members, but he had gotten to know her well. Or at least as well as she let him. He knew that she was cagey about her past, mainly because her father had been a cult leader. He went out in a blaze of glory in a standoff with the feds. Add in that she had worked undercover, Autumn hid a lot of herself from people.

“How could you have any information?”

“First, you know that no matter what the age of the witness, we thoroughly investigate their story.” Her tone told him she had expected him to question her memories.

“Listen, it isn’t your age at the time. It’s the time that has passed. And you lived on a different island.”

She took a deep breath. “I saw Dylan and Alana at the commune.”

Adam blinked. “When was that?”

“Not sure exactly when, but I know it was before the murders. Of course, it was because they were alive,” she rolled her eyes.

“And you didn’t say anything before because?”

She rolled her eyes. “First, I had no idea Dylan disappeared. We only saw things Joseph wanted us to see. There was no access to the internet other than for the leaders of the cult. We were kept in the dark. What I mean is that I just saw him, and he was dressed differently than other people who came to visit.”

“How was he dressed?”

“Like Hawai’i threw up on him. I could tell he was a *haole*, and he spent a fortune on his clothes. Like he went to a shop on Kalakaua and asked them to outfit him like a Hawaiian, and they took him for all he had. I had no idea who he was. I just knew he was different.”

“By the way he dressed?”

“And the way my father and the elders acted. It was as if the Messiah had arrived to save them.” She shrugged. “I figured he had money. I had no idea he was a billionaire’s son.”

“Did you get many people like that at the commune?”

She shook her head. “All the elders showed up when they did come, so it was a big thing. They didn’t creep out of their hidey holes for every new

person who visited. It was odd, to say the least. I didn't realize anything had happened until I listened to Jin's podcast today."

"You listened today?"

"Yeah, during my lunch. We didn't have access to TVs there unless Joseph allowed it. I'm pretty sure he would have hidden it from us. I didn't escape until May of the next year."

And then the cult had ended up in a standoff with the feds. Both her parents had died in the siege, and she was virtually alone in the world at sixteen.

He could definitely give her a break on the issues.

"I might have you sit down with Jin, too. She's good with interviews."

Her mouth quirked.

"What?"

"Nothing. Just…when you talk about her, you get a tone in your voice."

"A tone?" He frowned. "What are you talking about?"

"Nothing. I'm going to go write up my memories for you. Also, I need a snack."

"Didn't you just get back from lunch?"

She rose from the chair and frowned at him. "Yeah. But that was about an hour or so ago."

He shook his head as she left him alone. Autumn was constantly eating. He was sure her food bill rivaled that of his entire family, but she didn't gain an ounce. She had to have some crazy metabolism.

He looked at the time and decided to make a few calls to see if he could find someone from his father's group of officers who might know where to catch up with Iona. He needed to get on the road soon. With Jin living on the North Shore these days, he knew it would take a while to get there.

He had been trying hard to ignore his response to the former reporter. She wanted nothing to do with him on a romantic level. He didn't take it personally since he was pretty sure she hadn't wanted anything like that in a long time.

It was just his cross to bear that no matter how long it had been, he still wanted her, craved her like she was a drug. No other woman sparked his interest, but one thing he learned as a kid was that life wasn't fair.

After a quick stop at her post office box, Jin headed home. She was lucky that she had spent yesterday cleaning her house. She didn't have people come over that often, so it was just luck this happened on a Monday and not a Friday. Setting the envelopes on the table, she called her PA Samantha.

"What did they want?"

She chuckled. No, hello, how are you. Just right to the point. That's why she made such a good PA. Sam had a habit of covering all the bases. It spoke to something else in her background beyond being a PA for people. She had given Jin references, including a couple of romance authors, so she knew Sam was legit. It just always felt like she was hiding something, though.

"They want to help investigate the Alana Kim murder."

She snorted. "If they had done their job to begin with, they wouldn't need your help."

"TFH wasn't around then."

"Oh?"

"No, they were formed in the last five years to help with investigations like this. Ones that get lots of press."

"But this one didn't."

"Actually, it did."

Sam could get a little overzealous when they were investigating a case. She was passionate about the victims, and that's another reason she was excellent at her job. She wouldn't have lasted this long if she had been like Brett, Jin's last PA.

"It did?"

"Yeah, I know you look at the mainland for newspaper articles, and they concentrated on Brewer, but Alana got all the attention here. A local girl who got caught up with a billionaire's son winds up dead, and he disappears. Yeah, it was huge news here. But there were no leads."

She huffed out a sigh, and Jin smiled. "If you say so."

"Did you get Friday's show prepped and loaded?"

"Just finished listening to it. Want to take a break and listen again tomorrow? Then I will load it tomorrow."

"Thanks."

"Did you see him?"

Her heart jumped at just the thought of Adam. Sam had become a good friend, and while she didn't know Adam's name, she knew that Jin had been

involved with someone at TFH at one time.

"Yeah. In fact, he's been assigned to work with me."

There was a long beat of silence, then a suspicious snort.

"No!"

"Yes. It's going to be interesting."

"That's an understatement."

Jin smiled at the sarcasm dripping off each syllable. "He's old enough to remember the murders, and he has deep ties to HPD since his father was a cop. Add in that he's an excellent investigator, and he might be a great asset."

It had been one reason she sought him out so many years ago. She had heard the second in command of TFH was a former HPD cop from a family of cops. She remembered how her entire body lit up at his smile when she met him. All the time she was with him, she had to remind herself to be objective. She failed miserably. Then and now.

She saw him on a regular basis. It was hard not to when the TFH *o'hana* had adopted her. Granted, it wasn't until this year that she felt comfortable going out so much, but they had been there, especially the women. No matter how many times she saw Adam, she had the same reaction to him. Her nipples got hard, her palms started to sweat, and her entire body craved him.

She was just too broken to do anything about it.

"Jin?"

She blinked and brought herself back into the present.

"Sorry, I was wool-gathering. I'm meeting up with him today. We can discuss anything he gives me tomorrow since you will probably be in bed by then."

A snort. "Not likely, but okay."

Sam lived on the mainland, and while she kept odd hours thanks to having clients all over the world, Jin still didn't feel right contacting her in what would be the middle of the night for her.

After getting off the phone, Jin headed to her office to review the board. This house was the opposite of her former home in Aiea. About six months ago, she had been offered an obscene amount of money for the house, and she had taken the money and run. She'd found a smallish three-bedroom at the end of a cul-de-sac in Kapolei. It had been a steal because it needed some upgrades, but with the extra cash from her house, she had gotten it

just the way she liked it. Plus, many of her neighbors were retired. It was much quieter than Aiea, and she had a sliver of an ocean view from the lanai off her bedroom.

After grabbing a half of a peanut butter sandwich, she headed off to work. She stepped into her office and turned on the light. She loved this room. It settled her soul to work on mysteries and cold cases. Her disappearances sometimes dealt with newer events, but the cold cases were usually at least two to three years old. Her desk sat in front of the window, and she walked over to turn on her computer. She didn't think she would need anything from it when Adam came over, but better to be prepared.

She had a massive corkboard on the opposite wall with the case set up. She knew she wasn't a detective, but even before she started reporting on cold cases, she did better with writing everything down old school. It allowed her to see the entire case unfiltered. She munched on her sandwich, looking over the case. The right side was filled with everyone involved with the case. The billionaire had made himself a regular fixture since his son disappeared.

She stepped closer and studied the two men. You could tell they were related. They had the same eyes, cold blue. Neither of their smiles appeared to come from a happy place. No, those smiles told you they were calculating how to use you.

Ice slid down her spine, and she shivered all over. Pulling her attention from the men, she looked at the rest of the case. She knew that she and Sam had done a good job with research. They had uncovered two of the witnesses. If they had been interviewed by the police like they said they had, the information was lost. Hopefully, it was lost and not buried by someone. She really didn't want to find bad cops. When there were bad cops, they always became the focus, not the actual victim.

Her doorbell rang, and her pulse scrambled. She pulled out her phone and saw Adam standing on her front lanai. It was five minutes past their meeting time, which was odd for Adam. He was always on time.

She made her way to the front door and opened it. He smiled at her. A whirlwind of butterflies filled her stomach like the first time she'd met him several years ago. This man had always gotten to her, even when she knew she should stay far, far away. He had been a source back in her reporter days. Never before or since had she had a problem staying objective and

professional. She'd never had that urge to sleep with a man who was a source. He was like a drug, and to this day, she found it hard to resist him.

"Jin? Did you still want to go over the case?"

She blinked, her cheeks warming. Great, she was standing there staring at him. She pushed all those illicit thoughts aside and smiled.

"Sure. I was just up early today, and after getting called into TFH, I'm a little discombobulated."

She stepped back and waved him into her house. He slipped off his shoes and set them beside hers, and she was struck by how big his feet were compared to hers. She hadn't had a man over in the three months since she bought the house. Not that she dated, *ever*, but she definitely didn't have large gatherings at her home. Which, now that she thought about it, was a shame. This house was made for entertaining.

"Lead the way," he said.

"Right."

She hesitated for just a second, enough for him to cock his head to the side while studying her. "Is everything okay?"

"Yeah, just…I don't have a lot of people over."

Understanding filled his dark eyes, and she wanted to shrink away. There had been a time when he had looked at her differently. Jin had lived for the spark of need she saw the first time she'd met him a few years ago. She even preferred that irritation after he realized she had been using him for a story. When he gave her those looks now, she felt small and useless.

And damaged. She was sick to death of people looking at her like she was a broken doll who would never recover.

"This way. I have it set up in my office."

He waited for her to step in front of him, and he followed her. She entered her office; her nerves stretched, and a weird heat filled her. It was as if every nerve ending was on fire.

It hit her then why this felt so foreign to her. She was turned on. It had been so long since having a man near her made her feel this needy.

Of course, it made sense that Adam made her feel that way. Only, he saw her as someone who needed to be saved. She did *not* need that.

He stepped into the room and then came to an abrupt stop. "Jesus."

"What?"

He glanced over at her, his dark gaze sweeping over her, admiration filling his expression.

“This is freaking fantastic.”

Her cheeks heated again. “I’ve been working on it for a few months.”

He nodded as he settled his hands on his hips and stepped closer to her board. “These are your suspects?”

“Yes.”

“I don’t see Brewer at the top.”

Internally, she sighed. She knew that most people—including HPD—thought the billionaire’s son had something to do with Alana’s murder, but Jin didn’t. Or at least, it wasn’t just him. That was why when she tried to talk to anyone in HPD, they didn’t want to have anything to do with her. It was disappointing but nothing new for her. Since she’d started her podcast, she’d found that even the smallest police departments could have egos that would not allow them to admit they were wrong.

“He’s a suspect, but he had no motive.”

“How about he’s a rich white man who always gets what he wants?”

She smiled at the venom in his voice. “Yes, but that isn’t much of a motive, is it? I mean, not for him to have stayed hidden over a decade.”

He looked over his shoulder at her, his gaze studying her. Then he turned back to the board. “You really don’t think he did it?”

She shook her head, then realized he couldn’t see her. “No, or at least, if he did, someone else took care of him.”

When he faced her, he crossed his arms over his massive chest. Adam was huge, big muscles, big heart, and a big laugh. God, she loved his laugh, the way his dimples would pop out when he smiled. Before him, there had never been a man who made her laugh in bed. Adam had done that on a regular basis.

“Explain to me why the man last seen with her isn’t the one who killed her.”

This was a different man. This was the second in command of TFH. He was ruthlessly professional, and she knew he was a crack shot.

Still, she wasn’t about to have him disrespect her research. Lifting her chin, she said, “Excuse me?”

“Prove to me your thesis of why you don’t think Dylan killed her.”

His tone grated on her nerves, and she didn’t understand why. Anger whipped through her as she tried to keep her temper under control.

“TFH came to me.”

His eyes widened as his eyebrows shot up. “Yeah, because you’re a great researcher. Your podcast has proven that.”

She made a face. “Thanks, I guess.”

Another long moment with him staring at her. She felt as if she were under a microscope. Again, this was a different man, not the one she had known a few years ago who romanced her.

“When working on theories at TFH, we always ask these kinds of questions. I didn’t mean anything by it.” He said the words carefully as if he were afraid she would bolt.

She sighed, some of her tension dissolving. “Okay.”

“So, tell me why you think he didn’t do it.”

She looked at her board and reviewed all the research she and Sam had accumulated. Then she looked at Adam.

“From the moment Alana’s body was found, there has been no sign of him anywhere.”

One eyebrow cocked. “His father is a billionaire.”

“Yes. He can make his son disappear to a point, but we—”

“We?”

“Sam, my assistant, and I.”

He frowned. “Okay, what do you and this *Sam* think?”

There was an edge to his tone when he said Sam’s name, but she didn’t understand it. Of course, her ability to pick up on social cues was kind of screwed up these days. She spent so much time alone.

“Brewer was a man accustomed to attention, from the press, from women, from everyone. And let’s be honest. Alana Kim was a local girl from a working-class family. He was messing around with her, but more than likely, he would have dumped her when he headed back to the mainland. He’d done it before. His father is a billionaire. He could have easily fought this in court. Or, with the right amount of money, made the whole thing disappear. This was before MeToo, so if you’re rich, you can glide above anything. Hell, there was that guy who killed his girlfriend and hid out in Europe for decades. He wasn’t even rich.”

“The guy who put her body in a trunk?”

She nodded. “Dylan Brewer’s father could have had him off this island in a heartbeat and sent him to Dubai. He spent a lot of time there.”

“Maybe he did that.”

“Brewer couldn’t handle not having attention heaped on him. He loved the press, loved when he was involved in some scandal. He would have popped up a long time ago. Also, according to the reports I saw, he wasn’t seen anywhere on camera. Not at the airport and, other than the night he disappeared, he was not seen on any traffic cams.”

His gaze narrowed. “He was seen that night?”

She nodded and pointed to the report pinned to the board. Adam stepped closer, and his arm brushed against her. Heat sparked, then seared through her entire body. She drew in a breath, which was a mistake because she drew in the essence of Adam. Clean, with a bit of salt air.

Blinking, she ordered her body back under control. “See there, it says that both he and Alana were picked up on the Kam Highway and Haulalani Street camera. They were headed in the direction of Pounders Beach at two in the morning.”

“So, they were headed toward the area where Alana was found. I can’t remember. Does that fit the ME’s report on the time of death?”

“Yes. The ME at the time put her death at between two and five am.”

He sighed and looked at her board again. She could almost hear the gears shifting in his head. One of the things she had always liked about Adam was that he was as bright as he was hot. He might have had a full scholarship to UH because of his football skills, but he had other scholarships as well. He’d also graduated second in his high school class. If she was attracted only to his body, she might be able to handle that. But this man was the total package. Mind, body, and soul. That soul part. That got her the most. No one she knew had as beautiful of a soul as Adam Lee.

“So, they’re seen going there, but neither of them is seen coming back? Even down H-2?”

She shook her head. “If you know where the traffic cams are, then you can avoid them to a point. But after…the way our world is with decent cameras on phones and the surveillance state of most countries, it would be hard to avoid being seen.”

“Not one sighting of him?”

“Not even on the dark web.”

“How did you get on there?”

“Sources will not be revealed.”

His mouth twitched, and then it dissolved when he looked back at the board. “It does make sense. I’m not sold, but you definitely made your

points. Where do you think he is then?”

“I think he was killed at the same time, and his body was stashed somewhere else. If they could make it seem that he disappeared, then he would be considered the killer.”

“Like in that it was planned?”

She shrugged. “I haven’t worked that out. If we knew who was involved, then it would be easy to ascertain. But without that, it makes it hard to track.”

“I have to say, I’m not sure I agree with you, but your hypothesis is valid. You’ll have to present it to the TFH.”

“Wait, what?”

Was that panic in her voice? Yes, yes, it was. Standing in front of her closest friends and presenting a case would be nerve-racking.

“I think it would be best that you do it. You know the case better than I do.” He glanced back at the board. “So, he was on Hawai’i?”

She blinked. “Yeah. He flew them over there for a couple of days.”

“Interesting.” He stepped closer. “Have you talked to Bradford about this?”

“Autumn? No, why?”

He pointed to a pic of Alana and Dylan. “This pic is interesting. I might be wrong, but that looks like Autumn’s father.”

Excitement unfurled within her. She hadn’t been able to find out what the couple did or where they had stayed while on Hawai’i. She hadn’t noticed the man in the background. How had she missed that?

“The cult leader?”

He nodded. “I could be wrong, but I think that looks like Joseph.”

Autumn’s father had a cult on Hawai’i called Joyous Wave that had a standoff with police not too long after Alana disappeared.

“Damn, it does look like him. How did I miss that?”

“Give yourself a break. That’s why I like working with a team. You can bounce ideas off each other.”

“I have been staring at these pictures for months.”

“And sometimes you get in your head too much. I’ve done the same thing.”

“You have?”

He nodded. “You need to come by and talk to the entire team about this, or as many as we can assemble.”

She smiled. “You sound like a superhero team.”

“Nah, but we will have your back no matter what. Always remember that.”

She nodded because they always did. They were the ones who saved her from hell.

“Let me talk to the team and see if I can get everyone back together tomorrow. There’re all kinds of crap happening right now, lots of different schedules.”

“Sure.”

After she saw him out, she headed back to the board. She needed to look at other pictures of the couple, together and separate. She might have missed something else.

But, before she did, she would get Sam to look into Dylan’s involvement with the Joyous Wave cult. That name had not come up at all, but he fit the profile of a person the cult would go after. There were a lot of nepo babies that got pulled in. She’d heard more than one actor or actress had to have their child deprogrammed. Joseph Watters loved to prey on those types of kids. Dylan fit that mold. Deceased mother and father who gave Dylan anything he wanted because he felt guilty or was lazy. Or both.

Jin: *Hey, did you find anything linking Dylan to the Joyous Wave?*

Sam: *The cult? No.*

Jin: *That Hawai’i pic has Joseph in the background.*

Sam: *Who the hell is Joseph?*

Jin smiled. She forgot that her friend wasn’t Hawaiian. Most Hawaiians remembered the standoff with the FBI and the lives that were lost. Many of them had been Hawaiian.

Jin: *He was the leader.*

Sam: *On it.*

Jin: *Thanks.*

She went back to looking at the board. If she was going to present her facts to TFH tomorrow, she wanted to make sure that she had everything in order.

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Five

Jin smiled as Elle made her way to the table, a harried look on her face.

Her hair was pulled back in a low ponytail, her shirt looked a little rumpled, and it looked like she hadn't had time for makeup this morning. Not that the doctor needed it. She had what people called a peaches and cream complexion, blue eyes, and high cheekbones. Long and lean… although she had filled out since having her first baby. She was still elegant at eight months pregnant. Heads turned as she approached the table, but Elle didn't pay attention.

"Did that Scotsman keep you in bed this morning?" Jin said, rising to give the woman a hug. She looked like she needed it.

"What? No," she said, sitting down. Jin opened her mouth to ask her what was wrong, but the waiter arrived for their orders. After Elle ordered without looking at the menu, he left them alone.

"Are you okay?"

She shook her head. "No. My caseload is insane at the moment. I've been filling in for Dr. Tan."

Dr. Tan was the medical examiner for HPD. "Is she okay?"

"Yes. And I don't have to do all of it, but the added work makes me crazy. I can't remember a bloody thing half the time."

Jin frowned, worry worming through her. "Try again, sista. Something is going on with you."

The waiter returned with Elle's coffee and then left them alone. Jin watched her friend pick up the coffee and bring it close enough to smell before her face turned green.

"Elle?"

She set the cup back down and grabbed her water. After taking a long sip, she looked at Jin, her eyes shimmering with tears.

“I think Graeme isn’t happy with me.”

“Did you do something? Did you have a fight? I will help you hide any evidence.”

Elle chuckled, and then a small sob broke out.

“No, it’s not that,” she said as a tear rolled down her cheek. “It’s just that I’m so old.”

“You’re in your forties. You act like you’re in your eighties.”

“It’s just that we got into a massive argument this morning. He wants me to take some more time off after this baby, and I told him no.”

That was so unlike her friend. Granted, she understood that she and Graeme argued a lot as a form of foreplay, but this was different.

“Elle, why don’t you just tell him what’s bothering you?”

“Oh, no.” She chuckled as she pulled a tissue out of her purse, wiping away her tears. “I *am* pregnant.”

Elle was trying to brush away any discussion, which was totally out of character for Jin’s friend. “Then what is it?”

“We ended up married because I got pregnant the first time.”

“No. Graeme used that to convince you to marry him.”

Elle chuckled. It was a little watery, but at least it was a laugh.

“True. I just don’t understand why he is being such a pain in the arse about this.”

“He loves you. End of story. The main problem is he’s worried about you. It is a lot to take. Two kids under the age of two.”

She sighed, happiness filling the sound, and something in Jin relaxed. She didn’t like the idea of her friend being upset over something that should bring joy. Jin had never been that good with kids, and until she played the kids from the TFH folks, she didn’t think she would want any. Lately, however, she had been thinking that in a year or two, she might reconsider the idea, at least with the right man.

Elle stared at her coffee and tried a sip. “Ugh, I allow myself one cup of coffee a day, but half the time, it tastes disgusting.”

“You could have tea.”

“At home. You Americans do *not* know how to make tea.”

Jin smiled. “True. Why don’t you get some orange juice or something? Give yourself a little kick. You need a sugar boost if you’re this tired in the

morning.”

Elle smiled. “That is an excellent idea.”

They chatted about her work—what Elle was allowed to tell her—then about some upcoming episodes for her podcast. Elle was on the schedule for an upcoming episode to talk about the case that she and Graeme had solved together. Jin was happy to see her friend dig into her omelet as Jin ate her moco loco. The Hawaiian dish was filled with a lot of calories and fat, so Jin didn’t eat it often. Rice, brown gravy, hamburger patties, a fried egg on top, and a serving of Hawaiian macaroni salad didn’t sound like something that should taste so delicious, but it did.

As they were paying for their meals, both phones went off. They pulled them out, and Jin frowned.

Charity: *Need everyone at TFH right now. Like NOW!*

“Charity?” Elle asked. Jin looked up.

“Yeah. I think she just ordered me to TFH.”

Elle chuckled. “Well, it’s a good thing you were going to drop me off anyway.”

“I’m assuming this has to do with the case.”

Elle nodded. “Yeah, or she wouldn’t have included you. Ready?”

Excitement danced through her blood as she rose. “Yes. Let’s go.”

Adam cussed as Graeme took him down with a roundhouse kick to his legs.

The giant Scotsman stepped closer and stared down at him, a stupid grin on his face, his hands on his hips.

“That’s two and oh, for me.”

“Fuck off.”

His eyes danced. “You’re so easy today. Maybe you’re just not aging as well as I am.”

They were actually three months apart in age, Adam being the older of the two of them.

“As I said, fuck off.”

He held out a hand to Adam, and he took it.

“Wanna go again?”

He shook his head. His mind was on everything he had learned the last few days. It had to be the reason he couldn't keep himself centered.

"Got lady troubles?"

He blinked and looked at Graeme. "No."

Adam almost winced at the defensiveness he heard in his voice.

"Sure."

"It's the case. There's so much in it that I can barely keep it straight."

Graeme picked up a towel to wipe his face, then grabbed a couple of water bottles, tossing one to Adam.

"She really doesn't think Brewer did it then?"

Adam shook his head, then took a long drink of water. The cool liquid felt amazing as it slid down his throat.

"What are you thinking?"

"Hard to know."

Graeme rolled his eyes. "Dude, I'm not your reporter girlfriend."

"She's not my girlfriend."

"She was at one time. I see the two of you together. You definitely have a vibe."

They had at one time. Now…

"Well, we don't."

Graeme frowned. "It isn't because of what happened, is it?"

"In a way."

There was a beat of silence. "What the fuck is wrong with you?"

He glanced up at his friend. "Excuse me?"

"You think because of what she went through, she can't have a normal relationship?" Anger and disappointment filled Graeme's voice.

"No. What I mean is that she doesn't want that anymore."

Graeme's irritation seemed to dissolve. "She said that?"

"It's the way she acts around me. She's fragile."

Graeme rolled his eyes. "Women are not fragile."

"Believe me. I live with four of them, and I know they are not the weaker sex."

"I assume you know what happened to Elle back in England?"

Adam nodded. He and Del had conferred on the new hires when TFH was first founded a few years ago, so he knew her background.

"Jin is different."

There was a beat of silence. "No. I think *you're* different."

“What do you mean?”

“You see her differently or…” his voice trailed off, and Adam fought the need to shift his weight from one foot to the other. The Scotsman could be broody, but he could see things that many people couldn’t. Adam always chalked it up to his time in the military. Graeme had been a former Special Forces for the Royal Military.

“You feel guilty.” He snapped his fingers. “That’s it.”

“No.”

“Yep. You feel guilty because it was our case, and she was abducted under our watch.”

Graeme was right about that last part. There was no doubt about that. They had been in charge of the case, and they were the first law enforcement agency to figure out that serial killers were hunting women across the world, mainly due to Emma, Del’s now wife. She saw the patterns. Still, they hadn’t been able to keep the bastards from taking Jin.

“It’s not that.”

“Partially.” Then he cocked his head and studied Adam like he was a bug. “You’re a little angry with her.”

“As I said earlier, fuck you.”

He spun away from Graeme, stalking off…away from that thought. He wasn’t angry with her. Graeme didn’t know what the hell he was talking about.

“Hey,” Graeme said, grabbing Adam by the arm to stop him. “It’s normal.”

He heaved a sigh, anger still coursing through his blood like molten lava. “I would never blame a woman for something like that happening to her.”

Graeme nodded. “I know. But you felt helpless. I remember the way you behaved that week and what you went through. I didn’t know Elle when she had been attacked, but I know I would have been tearing the world apart to find her. You aren’t blaming her for being taken, but she made you feel helpless, and men do not like the feeling.”

“I have a feeling no one likes that feeling.”

“Yeah, but society puts pressure on a man to be the protector. I’m not saying that’s right, but it’s understandable that you would feel that way.”

He opened his mouth to respond when the door to the gym opened. Charity came rushing in. “There you two are. I’ve been texting both of you,

but you weren't answering."

"It's on the schedule that we were down here," Adam said. It was required that they worked out in some way several times a week.

"I don't have time for that."

"It would have been faster than running all over the building looking for us," Graeme said with a laugh.

"Shut up. If you both weren't so pretty, I would hit you. Come on. We're all up in the common area."

"Can't you just tell us? I need a shower." Adam knew he could order her to tell them.

"No. Everyone is here. I even roped in Jin because this has to do with the Alana Kim case. Come on."

She hurried out the door. Graeme tossed Adam a smile. "Come on, boss."

"Please don't call me that."

They made their way out the door and then found the elevator door open. Charity was waiting, her finger holding the open door key. Annoyance stamped on her pretty face. Charity was a genius with everything forensic. She was a scientist and geek at heart, but she dressed however she was feeling that day. Today, she had her hair up in two space buns, and she wore a Thor T-shirt. He chuckled to himself. Her husband was actually named after the superhero, so he was sure she did it to tweak him.

Once they arrived on the main floor, they followed her off the lift and into the common area. Charity had been right. Everyone was there. Marcus and Tamilya were sitting the furthest away, their heads together, talking about something. Next to them was another couple—Cat and Drew. Then, Autumn, Elle, and finally Jin.

The moment his gaze landed on Jin, his entire body reacted. Jesus, she looked fantastic today. She was wearing a black t-shirt tucked into a pair of jeans. She'd let her hair grow a little, and he liked the way the curls bounced around her chin when she moved her head.

"There's my love," Graeme said. He strode over to his wife, snatched her out of the chair, then kissed her loudly. He set her back down in her chair, then took the one beside her. That left one chair.

Adam's gaze narrowed on the team. They were suspiciously not looking at him. Well, everyone but Autumn, who was grinning at him.

“Morning, boss.”

“Stop that.”

She laughed out loud, then turned her attention to Charity.

“Do you think you could sit down?” Charity said, her tone biting. She was vibrating with energy. He hesitated for a second or two before he made his way over to the empty chair.

Jin felt as if she were in a fishbowl. No one was looking at her, but it felt as if she were being observed. She didn’t miss the way Adam had hesitated before he made his way to the chair beside her.

“Morning, Jin. Didn’t know you were coming in today.”

She looked at him. He was sweaty. His shirt clung to his chest. God, he was so damn well put together. So many muscles. She remembered gliding her hands over them, feeling the ridges of that eight-pack beneath her fingers.

“Jin?”

“Sorry. Yeah, I wasn’t planning on it, but I was at breakfast with Elle when Charity messaged us.”

He nodded. Turning his attention to Charity, giving her the perfect profile to study. The man was so noble looking, his Hawaiian ancestry stamped on his face. She knew he had a little Chinese in his DNA, but he favored the Hawaiian side of the family.

“So, I’ve spent the last few days working with Elle on those skeletal remains found up near Waimea Falls. She has already said that the cause of death was more than likely a gunshot to the brain.”

“Yes. I would say ninety-nine-point-nine percent,” Elle said.

Charity rolled her eyes. “I said probably.”

Graeme made a grumpy sound, most likely because of Charity’s tone. It wasn’t common for her to be so short with everyone, so Jin assumed it had to do with whatever she wanted to tell them.

“Sorry, I kind of stink,” Adam said.

She glanced at him. “You know I like a manly smell.”

They shared a smile. “Yeah.”

“Hey, Adam? Jin?”

They both turned their heads. Everyone was watching them with grins. Well, everyone except Charity who looked like she was ready to lose it. “Do you mind?”

“Careful, Charity,” Adam said, the warning in his voice deadly. Charity looked unfazed. It took a lot to ruffle her feathers.

“I have news. Such big news.”

“You got the DNA results?” Elle asked.

“Yes. And I want you to know that you were right, Jin.”

“About what?”

“Dylan.”

“What do you mean?”

“Because of that skeleton, we found? That’s Dylan Brewer.”

There was a beat of silence before the entire room exploded in chatter.

Jin’s head seemed to spin at the change of subject. One minute, she was admiring Adam’s manly smell and the next, she was thrown back into the deep end of her investigation.

There was a whistle from Charity.

“Calm your tits, everyone.”

“Not appropriate,” Adam said, but he was smiling.

Charity ignored him. “So, Jin, do you mind telling us about the murders and your theories. I know that you were going to brief us, but things have been a little crazy.”

She glanced around and found everyone looking at her. There was a tickle at the back of her throat, and panic set in. Usually, she could prepare herself for something like this. But she reminded herself these were her friends. They have all been very supportive.

“Sure.” She stood and made her way to the front of the group. “As I am sure Adam told you, I never thought Dylan would kill Alana and just disappear.”

“Why did you say it like that?” Tamilya asked. She wasn’t around when Jin had been taken, but Jin had gotten to know her since Marcus and she were dating.

“Well, Dylan had a temper, and more than one ex said he never hesitated to slap them around.”

The grumbling that rose came mainly from the men. TFH guys really did not like it when men were abusive.

“So, in my mind, it was never that he wouldn’t have killed her. It was that he wouldn’t do it and then disappear. He would have fought the system, and unfortunately, with his good looks and money, he could have easily beaten the charge. That’s what he would have done, in my opinion. Instead, he disappeared.”

“Adam told us about the traffic cam footage. Was it just the two of them?” Cat asked.

“Yes, and it was his rental car, which was found somewhere, but I haven’t been able to find out where.”

“Not too far from Waimea,” Adam supplied. She knew he had finally tracked down Iona and talked to him, but he hadn’t gotten much more than she had when she spoke to the retired detective.

“Did they get any prints off it?” she asked.

He shook his head. “It had been wiped clean.”

“That is annoying,” Autumn said. “Anything else?”

She glanced at Adam, who nodded. “Yes, we have a pic of him on the Joyous Wave compound.”

Autumn nodded. “I told Adam I had hazy memories of that. All the usual idiots came around for that. They called them The Circle. They were like the board members of the cult.”

“Why hazy?” Jin asked.

“Things kind of went crazy around that time. I always figured that my mother knew things were going south, and that’s why she called an old friend to get me out of there. She wouldn’t risk getting caught if something wasn’t off. I mean, more off than a bunch of wackadoo cult members.”

“We need to nail down the timeline better,” Adam said.

“Agreed,” she said. There was a long moment where they stared at each other. Charity broke the spell.

“I think you need to sit down with Autumn. See if she can remember anything around that time. Anything at all might help.”

Jin nodded. “My PA is working on anyone else they might have been seen with, but we haven’t found anyone else other than his usual asshole friends.”

“And we need to do a notification to Dylan’s father. He lives in LA, right?” Adam said.

“No, he lives here. He moved here a couple of months after Alana was found. I think he maintains a house on the mainland, but he’s here a lot.”

“He is?”

“Yes. He’s spent a fortune trying to locate his son.”

“Okay, well, we’ll need to make sure none of this gets out before we tell him. Still, I would like some kind of cause of death.”

“The hole in his head tells us he was killed by a gunshot wound to the head,” Graeme remarked.

“Not definite, but enough. I’ll handle the notification. If this leaks out, he’ll find out, so I want to tell him first. Once we tell the Governor, it’ll become news.”

A few of the team nodded, and there were whispered curses. “Jin, do you have time to go over things with Autumn this morning?”

She nodded. “Just let me reschedule a meeting I had with Sam.”

His smile dissolved. “You do that. Graeme, wanna ride along with me?”

With a sigh, she turned to Charity, who was smiling at her. “So, is there anything else you can tell me?”

“Naw. Small caliber gun did the murdering, that’s about it.”

Everyone else started to move on, so she turned to Autumn. “Ready?”

“Yeah, give me a second. I need my mid-morning snack.”

She headed off to where the snack machines were, and Jin sighed.

“That woman eats enough to stuff a sumo wrestler but never gains an ounce,” Charity said, shaking her head. “Life isn’t fair.”

“No,” Jin mumbled as she watched Adam head off to probably go shower before heading out. Life definitely wasn’t fair.

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Six

"Wanna tell me what's up your ass before we get to Brewer's house?" Graeme asked Adam.

It was a fair question. He had been pissed off from the moment Jin had mentioned that Sam character. He didn't know why he was so angry that another man was in her life.

"No."

"Oh, this has Jin written all over it. Why did you get so pissy with her?"

"I didn't."

He chuckled as he took the next right, leading them into the Potlock area. It was an affluent area, with many homes on the beach. It figured Brewer would live there.

"You were. So, tell me what is going on with you."

He glanced at the man. Of all the team members, Graeme was the last one Adam would have thought would fall in love, especially with Elle. Hell, for the first six months, they worked together, Graeme went all highlander on her and called her Sassenach. So, maybe he knew more about love than Adam did.

"Have you met her research assistant?"

"Ah, that Sam person?"

"Yes."

"No. But she lives on the mainland."

"She?"

There was a beat of silence as Graeme parked the car. Then he looked at Adam. "You're jealous."

"No."

He laughed in Adam's face. "Yes. Yes, you are."

"No, I am not."

"This puts a whole new spin on everything, and yes, it is a woman. I've heard her refer to her as *she* when she's been talking to Elle. So, I would think that is a good bet."

Relief coursed through him and left him feeling slightly more than lightheaded.

Before Adam could ask any more questions, there was a tap on the window. A burly-looking guy stood there. He was dressed all in black. Adam wanted to roll his eyes. These security guys, the rich mainland people hired, would never blend in. They stood out, and maybe that was what they were hired to do, but it also made it easier for anyone after their employer.

He stepped out of Graeme's SUV. "We're here to see Brewer."

"Fuck off."

Graeme chuckled before Adam held up his badge. "How about you fuck off and lead the way?"

They followed him up the drive and into a spacious foyer. Adam itched to take his shoes off, but the guard gave him no time to get them off. Walking through someone's house with his shoes on was always weird. They stepped into a living area. Off to the left was a massive kitchen filled with the latest in kitchen amenities, including a gas stove. Since there was no natural gas on any of the islands, most homes had electric stoves. The air was cold—freezing, actually. He sighed. *Haoles*. They move to Hawai'i to enjoy the Hawaiian weather but close up their houses and freeze with their AC on.

It took him a second to find Brewer. He was sitting on an oversized white leather couch facing the floor-to-ceiling windows. And when he said floor to ceiling, they went up to the second floor. The view was stunning, but Adam would rather stand outside with the warm sun and cool breeze on his skin.

Brewer didn't turn, didn't acknowledge they were there.

"Mr. Brewer?"

It took a second, and he shook himself from whatever stupor he was in and turned around. His eyes narrowed as he studied him and McGregor. Adam knew they were probably a little intimidating. Both of them packed a lot of muscle in their six-foot-plus frames.

He didn’t answer Adam directly. Instead, he looked at his security. “I said I didn’t want to be bothered today.”

He remembered what an asshole Brewer was. He was in high school when the murder happened, but Brewer had been interviewed by major news outlets—never the locals—and he had always come off as a jerk.

“We’re here because of Dylan, Mr. Brewer.” He kept his voice even, not giving anything away. The older man tossed him a look of disgust.

“I have said all I’m going to say in the matter to the police. You have my statements, not that you ever did anything to find my boy.”

He bit back on his anger. The man had his points. HPD had wanted Dylan Brewer to be the bad man. He was an outsider. A rich, elite jerk who came to the islands, racking up charges for drunk and disorderly more than a couple times. So, Adam understood the man had a point. But it didn’t mean he had to put up with him being disrespectful.

One of the security guards moved toward Adam. He rested his hand on the butt of his gun.

“We’re not from HPD. We’re from TFH.”

Brewer glanced over his shoulder at them. “What do you want?”

“We regret to inform you that your son’s remains have been found.”

For a long moment, Adam wasn’t sure that Brewer had heard him. “What the hell are you talking about?”

“A hiker found the remains up near Waimea on the other side of the island.”

“I know where the fuck Waimea is.” Disdain dripped from every word.

Adam heard a rumble and realized it was Graeme growling.

“I want to see my boy.”

Maybe if he had been less of his boy and more of a man, this wouldn’t have happened. But he kept his mouth shut. Saying something like that to a man who had just found out his son was dead would make him the asshole.

“It would have to be cleared through our ME.”

“I don’t care what some dumbass local ME thinks.”

Oh, damn, wrong thing to say.

“Watch your tongue,” Graeme said.

The look of condescension on Brewer’s face almost had Adam laughing, as did the way it seemed to disappear the moment he made eye contact with the giant Scotsman.

“Sir, it’s just bones, so there won’t be anything to see,” Adam said in a neutral tone. He wanted to make sure that he could diffuse the situation before Graeme made Brewer cry.

The billionaire said nothing, but in that moment, Adam saw the pain. Brewer might be an asshole, but there was no doubt he loved his son.

“We will have someone contact you in a day or two to talk about the transfer of the bones.”

Brewer said nothing, but he nodded. He looked about twenty years older than he had when Adam and Graeme walked into the house. Adam knew what it was like to lose someone, but he assumed losing a child was something different than losing a parent.

He stepped forward and pulled out one of his cards. “Please, give me a call if you have any questions.”

Brewer took the card, staring at it for a moment before glancing up. “D-did he suffer?”

“No. Not that we can tell. I wanted to ask if there was anything that stuck out in your head about those last few weeks? Something that you might have forgotten about until now?”

“No. He’d spent the last month on the islands.”

That caught Adam’s attention. “Islands?”

“Yes. I told the other officers that he’d been on the Big Island the week before disappearing.”

“Do you know if he had any contact with the cult Joyous Wave?”

“Unless that’s a drug outfit, then no.” Adam’s surprise must have shown on his face. “I loved my son, but I knew he had addictions, mainly to women and drugs. So, unless they were selling drugs, then my son wouldn’t have been interested.”

“If you think of anything else, let us know.”

“Is this because of the podcast? I’ve been trying to figure out who the person in charge of it is but haven’t been able to.”

“No. It just happened to be a hiker who is here on vacation from the mainland.”

“Don’t worry. I will find out who the woman is behind that travesty of a podcast.”

Adam’s blood turned to ice as he studied the older man. “Did you listen to it?”

He shook his head. “I learned a long time ago not to pay attention to the press. They sensationalize everything.”

“You should listen to it. *Beyond Murder* is much different than other podcasts.”

Then, without another word, he headed out the door, Graeme and the security guard on his tail. Once they were back in Graeme’s truck, Graeme whistled. “So, you and Jin are a thing again.”

He wanted to roll his eyes, but just hearing her name had him twitching.

“We are not a thing.”

Were they *ever* a thing? He wasn’t sure if he wasn’t just a story to her or at least a source. When she couldn’t use him in that capacity, she had moved on.

Graeme started up the truck, threw it in gear, and was already out on the highway before he spoke again.

“Are you still interested in her?”

Adam didn’t say anything for a few seconds. He had spent the last few years pushing all those feelings aside. It wouldn’t do Jin any good during her recovery to know that he lusted after her on a regular basis. He would listen to her podcast on repeat, unable to help himself.

“Not going to answer? That in and of itself is an answer.”

He sighed. “Why wouldn’t I be interested?”

Graeme shrugged. “What she went through, a lot of men wouldn’t want to have anything to do with her. You said you were hesitant.”

“Those guys are assholes. I’m just not that sure she’s ready for something like a relationship or if she ever will be.”

Graeme nodded. “True, but I know a lot of people think something like Jin went through changes a person too much.”

“Of course, it changed her. Anything like that is going to do that, but it doesn’t mean that I don’t want her.”

Graeme sighed. “Don’t wait too long. She might find someone else.”

If Graeme had punched him in the gut, it would have hurt less than that one sentence. The idea that she might move on, that she would find someone else, sent a chill racing through him. He couldn’t deal with another man getting a chance with Jin. The truth was, she was strong before the abduction, but he thought she was even stronger now. She’d worked through the trauma, and while he knew it would always be there, she held herself with a new confidence. She had survived and was now thriving.

“How did you deal with it?”

Graeme turned into the TFH parking lot before answering.

“It will sound corny, but one day at a time. Elle still has her moments, things that set her off. Patience is the key.”

“I’m not sure Jin thinks of me as a romantic partner anymore.”

Graeme snorted. “Oh, she does.”

He glanced at his teammate as Graeme parked his SUV. “What?”

“She checks you out as much as you check her out. You two are dancing around each other. Ask her out, or better yet, take her something for dinner. Elle worries about Jin when she gets entrenched in her research—which she’s probably doing thanks to the new evidence.”

In truth, that was a good idea. He could give her a call and see if she had any plans, but at the mention of McGregor’s wife, Adam asked, “Is Elle doing okay? She’s seemed off the last few days.”

“Yeah.” He sighed. “We’ve been fighting a little bit.”

“No, it’s something different.”

Graeme flipped him off. “I want her to take a little time off before this next baby comes, but she refused.”

“Why?”

“I have no idea why she refused.”

“No, why do you want her to take time off?”

He tossed a snarl in Adam’s direction. “She’s over forty, having my baby, and we have one still in diapers at home. With her caseload and now handling some for the HPD, I worry about her.”

“Please tell me you said it better than that.”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean that maybe telling her she’s old isn’t the best way to go.”

“I dinna say that.”

Graeme was getting angry. His accent deepened when he was pissed off about something.

“Do you want me to talk to her?”

Graeme sighed. “No. As irritated as she is with me right now, she’ll be even angrier if she knew I talked to you about it.”

Adam made a mental note to check in with her tomorrow to see how she was doing. But that could wait. He pulled out his phone and texted Jin.

Adam: *Hey, are you busy tonight?*

Three dots appeared, then disappeared. Twice. Finally, a message came through.

Jin: *Sure. What time?*

Adam: *If I can swing it, how about sixish? I'll bring dinner.*

This time, there was no hesitation. Instead, she answered with a winky face emoji.

Jin was nervous. Was this a date? Or was he coming over just to go over the case? She had wanted to ask when he texted earlier. But she had chickened out and just agreed. If he was coming over just for the case, she was okay with that. Okay, not really. But she would be. Getting his help on the case was really going to help with the episodes. And she did want to know how it went with Brewer.

There was a tiny part of her, one that hadn't been killed off by her trauma, that was hoping he was coming over to see her just because…or rather for romantic reasons. The doorbell rang. Glancing at the mirror one last time, she headed for the front door. She double-checked her security doorbell app and saw that it was indeed Adam.

She opened the door with a smile on her face, trying her best to look cool with the idea of him bringing dinner over. They had been on a few regular dates before, but with both of their work schedules being so out of whack back in the day, they hadn't done a lot of romantic kind of things. Other than sex. Lots and lots of sex.

Her entire body seemed to heat at the same time as her nipples tightened against the cotton fabric of her bra. She hadn't had much of a libido these last few years, but her body seemed to be ready for more than a friendship with Adam.

It was about time it caught up with her heart.

Her breath caught in her throat, and she tried to move away from that thought. She wasn't in love with Adam and never had been. Right?

Not noticing her distress—thank God—he held up two plastic bags with the Zippy's logo on them. The local fast food was one of her favorite guilty pleasures and the fact that he remembered it wasn't helping with the whole nipple situation.

“You remembered.”

He smiled. Oh, life was not fair. She wanted this man more than she had wanted any other in her entire life, but he would never see past her scars. And not in a way that would irritate her. Okay, that was a lie. It was irritating. But she knew he didn’t do it out of disgust. He did it as the man who helped rescue her and saw her as a fragile, broken bird who could no longer fly.

“I got two of your favorites. I’ll take whatever you don’t want.”

That meant he had Korean chicken and fried chicken. “Be still my heart.”

She stepped aside and let him come into her house. He toed off his shoes, then waited for her to lock up so she could lead the way.

They talked over regular things, avoiding the case.

“I’ve been worried about Elle, actually,” he said as they settled at the small table she had on her lanai.

“You are?” she asked, frowning.

“Yeah, she’s been spacey and a little out of sorts the last couple of weeks.”

“Hmm.”

He looked up from his plate to study her. “You know something.”

Not a question, a statement. “I cannot reveal anything my source has told me.”

There was a beat of silence, and she wondered if he was mad at her. In their past, he had made the mistake of accusing her of using him for information. But in the next instance, he smiled.

“Can you promise me that she’s okay?”

Of course, that would be the first thing he worried about. “She’s fine.”

“Good.” After that, they didn’t talk about work for the rest of dinner. Instead, he went into great detail about some fight his sisters had over a skirt. By the time they were cleaning up their meal, her cheeks hurt from smiling.

“How did things go with Brewer?”

He sighed, and she almost opened her mouth to apologize, but he held up his hand. “No, I want to tell you. I was enjoying the conversation, even if it was about my *pupule* sisters.” *Crazy*. Yeah, they sounded crazy, but she wouldn’t know, being an only child.

“I was too.” Her admission pulled a smile from Adam. That one look, heat simmering in the depths of his dark eyes, had her heart beating so hard she was sure he heard it.

“As for Brewer, he’s still an asshole, but he’s definitely grieving.”

She nodded her head to the back outside, and he followed her. “Yeah, I understand he handed things over to his CFO—his brother—and moved here. I think he still deals with board business, but losing Dylan devastated him.”

“Yeah, the one thing I worry about is he is trying to find you.”

“Me? Why?” Then it hit her. “The podcast?”

Adam nodded. “He thinks you’re going to accuse his son of murder.”

She snorted. “Yeah, right? How can I do that? He died at the same time as Alana.”

“We don’t have the results back on the date of death. But…and you can’t tell anyone this, we found his clothes. They look like the same outfit he was wearing in that grainy picture, but I could be wrong.”

She rubbed her temples. Everything seemed to be adding up to a big fat nothing, but then she remembered their newest lead.

“Did he know anything about Joyous Wave?”

Adam shook his head. “Dylan did go to the island, Brewer knew that much, but he had no idea what his son was doing there at the time.”

“So, another dead end.” It was hard to keep the frustration out of her voice.

“No. We don’t know where it will lead. You know that sometimes things take a little time to link up. We are pursuing the idea that he did go there. I mean, Joseph was in the pic. Can you tell me where you got the picture?”

“Hmm, let me think. I can’t remember, but let’s go to the office and look. I’m sure I noted where I got it. I keep good records in case there is a question of what is going on inside an investigation.”

Once they were in her office, it only took her a few moments to find the annotation.

“A Google search? Am I reading that right?”

She shrugged. “No one was looking for Joseph Waters. They were looking at Dylan Brewer. I never know where I’ll find information when we start digging.”

“You and this Sam.”

“Why do you have a thing about Sam?”

He frowned. “I don’t. I thought he was a guy.”

It took a second to hit her. “Sam is short for Samantha.”

He rolled his shoulders and nodded. It was then that she realized how close they were to each other. “Oh.”

“Yeah, oh. Why does that matter?”

He opened his mouth to say something, but he hesitated for just a moment.

“Adam?”

He sighed and muttered something. Even as close as they were, she couldn’t make it out.

She turned to face him. “What?”

He didn’t look at her, which was very unlike the Adam she knew.

“I was jealous, okay?”

She blinked, trying to follow his comment. “What?”

“Don’t make me repeat it.” He smoothed his hand over his head. “I just…I got jealous when I thought about you working with a guy, that’s all.”

“You were jealous? Of Sam?”

She didn’t know why she felt like laughing, but suddenly, she felt lighter, as if all her worries were gone.

“Are you going to make me repeat it? It’s embarrassing.”

“So, you’re jealous of us working together, or was it the idea that I was close to a man?”

He looked away from her, settling his hands on his hips. His nostrils flared in irritation. That’s when she knew she got to him on some level.

She touched his elbow, and everything in him seemed to still. They were alone in her quiet house, but if they had been in a crowd of thousands, she wouldn’t have noticed. Hell, a bomb could go off five feet from her, and she wouldn’t have paid attention to it.

“Adam?”

He looked up, his gaze capturing hers. His dark eyes were filled with need, the same need she felt bubbling inside of her.

“I was jealous because I thought you were involved.”

“With Sam?”

He nodded once. It was as if it took all his effort to control himself.

“Why would you be jealous?”

His mouth twisted. “Why? Because I will always want you, Jin.”

She shook her head. “But the way you act…”

“What?”

“I thought you saw me as broken. Untouchable.”

He reached out, dragging the backs of his fingers across her cheek before he cupped her face. She had always loved his hands. They were callused, and the rough edges felt amazing against her skin.

“You’re not broken.”

Her soul shimmered with happiness, but she knew better. She knew that he barely paid attention to her on that level.

“Adam, you don’t have to say that. I get…” her voice trailed off as he watched her. It took all her courage to finish that sentence. “I get that before my abduction, I had hurt you.”

He nodded. “But I always thought that maybe we would work it out someday.”

Hope filled her heart as he stepped closer. “Yeah?”

“Yeah.” His gaze dropped to her mouth, waiting. Need vibrated between them. He was waiting for her to take the next step. To kiss him, surrender to him. She moved closer, their bodies brushing together, and then she lifted her face to his. He met her halfway, teasing her with butterfly kisses. Soft, tempting, and definitely not enough.

“Adam?”

“Hmm?”

“Kiss me like you mean it.”

“Anything to please the lady.”

He took her mouth then, no longer tender kisses as before. This kiss was passionate and possessive, and for the first time in a long time, Jin surrendered.

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Seven

Adam's entire body was on fire. He was lit from within because of a simple kiss with the woman he wanted most in the world. It was always like this. They could never get enough of each other.

He felt Jin's fingers slip through the belt loops of his jeans, and he shuddered. He took that as a sign that she was okay with the kiss. Tracing the seam of her lips with his tongue, he waited until she opened her mouth to take full possession. Then, he dove inside.

His cock was so hard that he was sure the imprint of his zipper would be on it. He didn't care. Nothing mattered but this kiss. It was the only thing that mattered in the entire world to him. Fuck, she tasted just as good as she always did. Sweet, tart, and everything in between.

He slipped his hands down her body, reveling in the curves. Jin had always been curvy, with hips that were perfect to hold onto. God, he wanted her in every way that was possible. That desire started to overwhelm his better judgment. So, with much regret, he pulled back from the kiss. She moaned in irritation and sucked harder on his tongue, and of course, that brought up images of her on her knees, her mouth on his dick.

Fuck.

With every ounce of control he possessed, he stepped away from her. She was frowning when she opened her eyes.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing is wrong. I just want to take it slow."

"What? Why?"

He chuckled at Jin's agitated tone. "Last time, we went fast. We couldn't keep our hands off each other. I would rather take it slower this

time.”

She nibbled on her bottom lip. “It’s not because you aren’t interested?”

He shook his head as he reached out and brushed his thumb over her bottom lip.

“I’m positive you could tell that I was interested in more than just a kiss.”

Her gaze dipped down, and her cheeks turned pink. It was so damned adorable.

“But, like I said, I want to take this slow. I want to take my time getting to know you better.”

She cocked her head to the side, studying him. “Yeah?”

He nodded. “I really do.”

The shy smile she offered him was one he hadn’t seen before. Even during her recovery, she had never been this open with him, this vulnerable.

“I better get going. I have a few meetings I have to attend in Del’s place tomorrow morning.”

She nodded and walked him to the door. “Thank you for dinner.”

“You’re very welcome.”

“And for believing in my theories.”

“Hey, you’ve done your work, and while I’m not sure how all the pieces go together yet, we have more of the puzzle pieced together thanks to you.”

Another sweet smile.

“Also, thank you for that kiss.”

He slipped his shoes on. “No. The thanks are all for you. Taking a chance on me…you’re amazing.”

Her eyes filled with tears, and panic filled him. He might understand women a little better than most men because of living in a girl house, but Jin rarely cried.

She chuckled, albeit a watery one. “No, Adam, don’t freak out. It’s just…I wasn’t sure you would ever be interested in me again. Not after everything I went through…and the way I treated you before.”

He slid one arm around her and pulled her closer. He held her like that, feeling every curve of her body, but more importantly, feeling her heartbeat against his chest. Just as she had years ago, she fit perfectly against him.

“You should never doubt that I want you, Jin.”

She raised her head and smacked his chin. “Ow.”

They shared a smile. “Thank you.”

He gave her another kiss, this one on the cheek, because Adam was sure if he touched her lips again, he would lose control.

"'Night, Jin."

"Text me when you get home."

He smiled. "Sure."

He stepped out into the night happier than he had been in a very long time.

After his second long ass meeting of the morning, Adam ran into Elle as he was returning to TFH headquarters.

"Just getting to work?" she asked.

"No, I had some meetings to go to."

"Oh, what fun the boss always has, right?"

He chuckled. This is why he didn't want to take over TFH. Everyone was thinking he would, but the plan was that he would become the head of Team Alpha. Not everyone knew about that, though.

"And you're getting to work at ten in the morning because…?"

She sighed. "I went out to the scene of a probable homicide for HPD. They've been slammed, and with Tan out for another few days, they needed my help."

"Oh, I heard about that. I thought it was an overdose."

Her eyebrow rose. "Not sure, but they are bringing the body over here for me. I wanted to have it in my lab and not theirs. It feels wrong. So, how was your date with Jin?"

"That was blunt."

"Yeah, well, she's one of my best friends, as are you."

That made him smile. "Thanks, and it went well, although I'm not sure she saw it as a date."

"She did. I talked to her this morning. You did good, Adam." They stepped into the common room of TFH. Her husband turned to both of them with a glower. "Ignore that. He's just upset because he doesn't want me at work today. He wanted me to stay home."

Worry threaded through him. Elle had seemed overworked lately, a little lethargic. "Is everything okay?"

“Everything is fine. Don’t worry. That big Scotsman, he has an issue with me working when I’m not one hundred percent.”

“Understandable.”

“Oh, so when he’s been injured and insists on coming in, that’s okay?”

He said nothing because he knew that tone. He’d heard it more than once with his mother and sisters in the past. It never ended well for him.

“Exactly,” the doctor said as she tossed her husband a nasty look. Without another word, she turned toward the elevators.

Graeme’s frown turned darker as he started towards Elle, following her into the lift. Knowing them, they would argue halfway down to her lab and then make out the rest of the way. And while he thought they were insane, Adam found himself being strangely envious. To have someone you could argue with, laugh with, love with…he wanted that.

For years, he thought he wanted that but never knew exactly what that would look like or who it would be with. Now, though, he seemed to be settled on one woman in particular. Or maybe it was because he thought she wasn’t interested before last night.

“Hey, boss,” Tamilya called out.

Adam looked behind him for Del, then realized she was talking to him. Rolling his eyes, he headed over to her.

“Don’t call me that.”

Her mouth twitched. “Sure thing. Anyway, I was searching for info on Dylan being on Hawai’i leading up to his disappearance. It’s difficult because it was over a decade ago.”

“Yeah, I thought that it might be impossible.”

She gave him a look of disdain. “Please. It was difficult but not impossible, thanks to Autumn.”

He glanced over to the woman in question. Her concentration was on their big screen. It took him a second to figure out what he was seeing.

“Are those from the cult?”

“Yeah,” she said as they walked over. “Autumn put out a call to some survivor groups for pics, and she’s been sent a lot of pics. It’s amazing how many sites there are for these people to connect.”

“There are a few on the dark web,” Autumn said as she clicked through to another screen. “But those people won’t help us. They’re still waiting for Joseph to come back.”

Disdain dripped from every word in that last sentence. He also noticed that she referred to her father by his first name once again.

“Hot damn, weirdos for the win!” Autumn danced in her seat. “There he is. And he’s wearing the same shirt as in that one pic, so that must be the same day.”

Adam’s eyes widened. “When was that?”

She started tapping on her tablet and making a few noises. “Ah, here. It was the week before Alana was found dead, and he disappeared.”

“Damn.”

“Yeah. That isn’t a good thing. That brings up a whole lot of questions,” Tamilya said. “Like, was he going to join the cult?”

“Joseph didn’t have people there all the time to join the cult. Don’t get me wrong. Joseph would have taken him for all his money if he could. Other than power, Joseph loved money—which gave him more power, so that’s probably why he loved it so much.”

“The money is important?”

“To join, yeah. You either had to buy your way in or basically sign a contract to work. It made a whole group of people indentured servants.”

“And your mother?”

“Bought in. She was loaded at one time.”

Adam nodded. “If he wasn’t joining, what other reason would bring him to the compound?”

“Drugs.”

He crossed his arms over his chest. “Drugs?”

She nodded. “The one thing that got the ATF, DEA, and FBI interested to begin with was the report of drugs. Guns followed a close second, but they knew they would have more public support for a raid if they said they had drugs.”

“I read over the reports. They never said anything about the drugs.”

“I know, but they were there. It was one thing that Joseph used to control the masses, and he would fund his stupid little cult with it.”

“But none were found.”

“Nope,” she said, popping the “p.”

“But either way, we have another confirmation that he was over there the week before.”

He nodded. “His father said he didn’t know about it. Tamilya, get working on the financials. We’ll need a search warrant to look through all

of his money. No way his father will give us access.”

“Even to find out how his son was murdered?” Tamilya asked. “I mean, I get it that normally someone like Brewer might not want to hand things over to any agency, but this was over a decade ago.”

Before he could answer, Autumn did. “Rich people hide everything, especially when dealing with their money. They definitely don’t want anyone else to find out about what they have hidden in their bank accounts.”

Autumn worked with the DEA, so she probably had a lot of experience with people hiding their money.

“Like I said, Tamilya, you keep digging into that. Get the search warrants for the bank records. Autumn, do you have more photos to go through?”

She nodded as she started clicking on her tablet again. “I have a few feelers out there to the DEA, too. They had Joyous Wave under surveillance for months, so if Dylan had made a visit before this, it would have been noted. His father had defense contracts at the time.”

“And they wouldn’t have stepped up when Alana disappeared?”

She glanced over at him. “No. I don’t know exactly who was working the cult, but they had one or two people undercover. I like to think they would have done something if they knew ahead of time, but after working with them, I’m not sure.”

“You’re kidding?”

She shook her head. “Those bastards hate to have an op screwed up. They keep everything under wraps as best as possible.”

“Sounds like they would be fun to work with.”

Autumn glanced at him out of the corner of her eye. “There’s a reason I’m with TFH now.”

He nodded. He knew an op had gone bad, and she blamed the DEA. Whatever she had been working on was still an ongoing operation, so they wouldn’t divulge the info to just anyone.

“Get on those things. I’m going to check in with Del.”

“I thought he was on vacay this week,” Tamilya said with a chuckle.

“I got a text from Emma telling me he was going a little crazy and driving them up the wall. I thought I would give her a break.”

He had just put his hand on the doorknob of his office when Autumn called him back.

“Uh, I think we have a drug sale here.”

He walked back over, his gaze zeroed in on the screen. In the pic, Dylan is standing with Alana, handing over an envelope and taking another one. “Who is that?”

“Dickson. Believe me, he lives up to his name. He was the right-hand man to Joseph. Basically, he did all the dirty work Joseph didn’t want to do.”

“Apparently, that includes selling drugs. Doesn’t that seem kind of beneath him if he was your father’s right-hand man?”

She shrugged. “Not if they were hoping for more than just one sale. They had a lot of synthetics.”

His eyebrows rose up. “Synthetic drugs?”

She turned toward him. “Yeah. Joseph has a background in chemicals and pharmaceutical development. He can build a designer drug like no one’s business.”

“I never saw that in the reports.”

He had been reading them ever since they had found out Dylan had been over to the cult compound.

“Well, it isn’t in the public records. I knew about it and did digging when I was at the DEA. They knew he was developing some kind of new drug when everything went to shit.”

“Real piece of work.”

“Tell me about it. I’m going to put out some feelers online, and then I am going to meet up with a survivor group here in Honolulu. They meet every other week, so I want to hit their meeting today.”

He nodded. “Good work.”

She smiled at him before heading off to her office. He did the same thing, wondering what the hell did all of this have to do with a sixteen-year-old murder.

In a sunny mansion, the two of them met. They were old friends, both with more skeletons in their closets than most ordinary people, but that’s what happened when you had money and power.

“They identified Dylan,” he said, disbelief threading his voice. “I thought you took care of him and made sure he wouldn’t embarrass me ever again.”

His friend’s face paled. Good. He should be scared.

“Not my fault. Some asshole tourist found the bones.”

He sighed, once again disappointed in the one man he could trust with his secrets. At least he wouldn’t have to answer questions about Dylan anymore. If the press found out and then came after him, it would be easy to dismiss. Grief was something that was easy to hide behind, and he was so good at it.

“I guess it can’t be helped.”

His friend nodded. “His body was further in…some animal must have dragged it out.”

That’s why he’d told him to dump him in the ocean. No one finds the bodies in the ocean if you do it right. But this idiot probably would have done it right off Honolulu Harbor, and the Coast Guard would have picked up Dylan’s body within twenty-four hours.

“So, what should we do now?”

He sighed and walked over to the massive window that overlooked the ocean. “We wait. They have nothing, really, other than Dylan died at the same time.”

“We do have one more person we have to worry about.”

“She won’t be a problem.”

“I’m not talking about Summer.”

That wasn’t her name anymore, but he didn’t correct his friend. Everyone who knew her before still called her by that name.

“What is it?”

“Remember that Raymond Reynolds?”

He frowned. “Photographer?”

He nodded.

“What about him?”

“He was making noise about going to the police.” He didn’t tell him that Ray had posed as a tourist and called the police.

“Was?”

“I took care of him. Made it look like an overdose.”

“It’s a miracle that *something* was done right.”

The asshole smiled and preened. He waited to roll his eyes when his friend wasn't looking. Everything seemed to be bubbling beneath the surface. He had hidden all that time just for things to start falling apart, thanks to Dylan. Again. That dumbass never did anything right in his fucking life…and now his death was causing him more issues.

He refused to fail now, and he wouldn't let anyone stand in his way.

"The podcast?"

"Still trying to find out who does it. I found out that the PA who helps run the show lives on the mainland."

"We need to find her."

"I know. We're working on it."

"I don't care what it takes. Find those women and eliminate the threat."

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Eight

The days following her date with Adam passed in a whirlwind of activity for Jin. It was true that she spent a lot of time on the script prompts for her upcoming episode dealing with the Alana Kim murder. But she didn't just have one investigation going on at a time. And she didn't just feature unsolved cold cases. Instead, she often covered half solved and half unsolved.

The one she was researching today took place in a little town in Texas. They had had a serial killer lurking in their midst and didn't know it because the women's bodies had been left in different counties. It was part of her spotlight on how police worked before the Information Age of computers and how sharing data between different jurisdictions could cause many cases to go unsolved.

As she shut down her computer, she checked her phone. She had sent a few texts to Sam, but oddly, she hadn't responded. It was strange that she didn't get back to Jin by the end of the day. Usually, she texted back within an hour. She frowned. Should she say something to Adam? It seemed like an overboard reaction until she remembered their conversation on the phone yesterday.

"I've been feeling weird lately," Sam said.

"Weird? Like you're coming down with something?"

"No. Like someone's watching me."

The fine hairs on the back of Jin's neck went up.

"You think someone's watching you?"

"Yeah, but…it might be the creep across the street. I told you about him."

Sam had. In fact, she had gone on and on about how she was convinced the guy was a spy. She loved Sam to death, but she could be paranoid. She didn't go all tin foil hat on Jin, but sometimes, she sounded like someone who dealt with conspiracy theories in a government think tank or something.

"Have you caught anything on the cameras?"

Sam was suspicious by nature, so Jin knew she had a lot of cameras around her house.

"No."

"See. You're probably just imagining it."

"Probably." She didn't sound convinced, but she changed the subject to talk about Adam. Jin had let it go.

Jin texted her again, but when she looked, she noticed that Sam had not read any of her texts. It had been over twenty-four hours since she spoke to her friend.

Taking a deep breath, Jin hit Sam's number. Straight to voicemail. *Dammit*.

Would Adam think she had lost her mind if she asked him for help? Was she getting as paranoid as Sam?

As if conjured up by her thoughts, her phone buzzed with a call from him.

"Hey," she said, trying to sound unencumbered by the insane paranoia now buzzing through her head.

"What's wrong?"

She chuckled. "Just one word and you can tell something is wrong?"

"Yeah. So, tell me."

Her heart turned over. "I don't want you to think I've lost my mind."

"I won't."

"I can't get hold of Sam."

"Your PA?"

"Yes."

"Tell me what happened."

The fact that he was taking it seriously warmed her and scared her simultaneously.

"Sam always gets back with me. If she can't do something right away, she will let me know that she at least got my message. Today, she not only didn't answer but also didn't read the messages I sent her."

“Did you call her?”

“Yes. Went straight to voicemail, which isn’t normal for her either. Normally, I might shrug it off, but yesterday, she said she felt like someone was watching her, but that’s normal for her. She’s a bit paranoid. Also, she said she saw nothing on her cameras.”

“Could be nothing. How about you come into the office, and we can get Charity to work on it?”

Her worry ramped up, but there was also relief. Having someone to help her like this was something new for her. Sam helped her, but even though they were friends, Jin also paid her for her help.

“I’ll be there in a little bit.”

“I’ll pick you up.”

“There’s no need for that. I can drive in.”

“I’m in your area.”

“You are?”

“Yeah. I had lunch with my mom over at Aiea Bowl.” The bowling alley was pretty famous for its oxtail soup. As in, national TV shows featured them.

So, he wasn’t that far away. “Okay. I’ll be ready in five minutes.”

After they hung up, she rushed around, changing her clothes, pulling her hair into a low ponytail, and slathering on some makeup. She didn’t wear much but rarely left the house without at least a little sun protection.

The doorbell rang as she turned down the hallway to the front door. Right on time. Which struck her as funny. The last time they dated, there was so much heat and insanity. The heat was still there, but the timing was off last time. Now, though, everything seemed to be lining up.

Jin shook her head at herself. She couldn’t think that far ahead, especially with her PA missing. After checking to see if it was Adam, she opened the door.

“Let me get my sandals on. Are you on the bike? I didn’t hear it.”

“No, sorry.” She had always loved going for rides on it when they dated before. “It was storming on the windward side this morning, so I brought my truck.”

She nodded and followed him out. “You’ll have to bring me back here. It’s out of the way.”

“Well, about that, Mom was wondering if you would come over for dinner.”

She stopped in her tracks, and he turned to face her. “Tonight?”

Did her voice just squeak? When had that started? She seemed to keep doing that around Adam.

“She mentioned it at lunch today.”

“That she wanted me to come over tonight?”

“No, just that she would like to meet you.”

“And why would she ask that?”

“She asked me what I had been doing, and I told her I was working with you.”

Jin’s eyes narrowed as panic hit her square in the chest. “She invites other people over you work with?”

“Yes. Everyone on the team has been over to eat dinner with us. I called her after I got off the phone with you, and she said tonight would work.”

Some of her terror receded. “Okay. So, she invited me over because we work together.”

They started walking to the truck again. Once he helped her in, he went around to the driver’s side and climbed in. That she could handle. She had never been into meeting families of her lovers—not that there had been a ton of those. Meeting Adam’s family of women was important. She wanted time to prepare, so it would be easier if they thought she was a work friend.

Adam felt bad for lying. It was true that he had had everyone over for dinner at his house more than once. Autumn said she wanted to move in, but she ate like a hobbit. The woman had at least nine meals a day.

He had told his mother that he was working with Jin, but his mother was no fool. She’d picked up on his feelings and insisted on meeting Jin. He knew that part of the panic Jin showed was because of families. She didn’t have much of one and never really met her lovers’ families. Or that’s what she had told him when they were dating before.

He held the door open for her and found most team members gathered around the big screen. “What’s going on?”

Elle turned to him with a frown. “We have another strange connection to the cult.”

“We do?” Jin asked.

“Yeah, just came up. Remember earlier this week, I had a DOA probable drug overdose? We didn’t have a name.”

“You do now?” Adam asked.

“Yes. Meet Raymond Reynolds,” she said, waving toward the screen.

The pic was of the man’s driver’s license. He looked like he was in his fifties or sixties, but his skin sagged, and he had the look of a drug addict.

“I remember him,” Autumn said. “He was a creep.”

“Creep?” Seth Harrington said as his gaze landed on Autumn.

“Yeah. He got caught doing up-skirt kind of videos more than once. Also, he hogged the few sweets we would get.”

And for Autumn, hogging food was a federal crime.

“Anything else?”

“Yeah, he was the photographer. He always had a camera, and I bet he’s the one who took some of the photos we found. They looked official. Joseph would take pictures of people like Dylan to use to recruit other people. If you’re a normal person and got the chance to brush elbows with the rich and famous?” She shrugged. “More than a few cults use that as a recruitment tool.”

He nodded, working through all these connections. He might be out of line with his thinking, but Adam was starting to think something happened with that week Dylan was at the compound.

“Autumn, do you mind taking Jin down to see Charity. She needs help finding someone, and I thought having her in the office would be faster.”

Also, safer. Joseph Watters might be gone, but there were still believers around. And some of them had done things to gain attention.

“I can see myself down there. I don’t want to bother anyone.”

“It isn’t a bother. The food machines are down there,” Autumn said.

“Also, it’s protocol. I can’t let you wander around the building.”

Her eyes dimmed, but she nodded.

He resisted the urge to kiss her forehead and apologize. It was the truth. It still didn’t make him feel any better. He watched them go.

“Don’t worry. She won’t hold that against you.”

He glanced at Elle. “Still, it isn’t fun being the taskmaster.”

Understanding lit her eyes, and she nodded.

“Let’s go to my office so you can sit down while you review things in the report.”

“I can stand,” she said, irritation filling her voice.

“I know you can, but I also know that if you get a body, you will need to stand on your feet for a long time. This way, you won’t use up all your energy. Besides, my mother wouldn’t be happy if she heard I had you standing around.”

He knew he hit the right chord when her gaze softened. “Okay.”

With a sigh, he tossed one more glance at Jin, who waved at him. Hopefully, she didn’t take it as a slight and would still want to go to dinner tonight.

“Don’t look like that,” Autumn said as they stepped on the lift.

“What?”

“He trusts you. There has been a real crackdown on things throughout the state agencies.”

“Yeah?”

She nodded. “There was some jerk who was getting in and somehow stealing social security info on all the state employees, so the Governor came up with this plan. Not bad, but Adam trusts you.”

“He’s taking me to his mother’s house for dinner.”

“Well, that’s *his* house.”

Yes. She knew he had moved back in to help a few years ago.

“You’re lucky. I would eat there every day if I could. It’s great to see normal people interact, and of course, the food.”

She cocked her head and studied the woman. They were about the same age. She was taller than Jin, with wavy auburn hair and sea-green eyes. Jin knew Autumn had been undercover for a while, and she could understand how she had been good at it. She had that girl next door look about her. From what Elle said, she could kick ass in hand-to-hand fighting. Deceptive.

“You don’t see yourself as normal?”

She snorted. “My insane mother married a cult leader, and I spent years undercover with the DEA. I left normal the moment I took my first breath.”

“Your mother got you out of there.”

“Yeah. But she let a bunch of other little girls be married off.”

Jin glanced at her, surprised at the bitterness that laced Autumn’s words.

“What? How would you feel if your mother didn’t give a shit about any young girl—some as young as twelve—being married off until it was her daughter. It doesn’t really make me feel all warm and fuzzy that mother was a sociopath.”

“You think your mother was one?”

She nodded. “I know she was a cult member and definitely brainwashed, and that is a form of abuse, especially in the bounds of marriage. But it doesn’t make it any easier knowing that my mother was like that.”

Jin understood to a point. It was hard to understand your parents being like that. Hers were narcissistic jerks, but she was pretty sure they wouldn’t join a cult and let young girls become child brides. At least, she hoped not.

The doors opened, and she stepped out, her nerves popping. The fact that Sam was missing was more than a little worrisome. Charity was waiting for her just inside her lab.

“Need anything from the machines?” Autumn asked.

Both she and Charity said no, so Autumn made her way down the hall.

“Come on in. I’ve been working on finding your Sam since Adam texted me. I found a few things.”

She followed the woman through her lab. It was filled with equipment, some of which Jin knew about, and other stuff she had no idea about.

“So, I was looking into Sam and discovered that apart from working for you and her rental in San Antonio, there is no Sam Charles. Well, not a real one. She’s a ghost.”

“What?”

“Sam Charles is an alias and a good one. I mean, there are layers to her, but the only real things she has in her past are you and that house.”

“That’s…disturbing.”

Her mind flipped back through the last few months. They seemed to have clicked from the moment they first talked to each other. She had been friends with Sam or thought she was. What the hell was happening?

Charity tapped on a few more keys, looking over things. “Oh, shit.”

“What?” Worried, Jin moved closer to look at her screen.

“I need the boss down here..”

She typed a text to Adam.

Jin saw 911.

“Emergency?”

“Yeah, this…I need him down here.”

The worry in Charity’s voice sent ice cascading down Jin’s spine. She had always thought that Charity was unflappable. Jin apparently was wrong. The nerves she saw in the other woman’s eyes sent shards of ice spiraling through her blood.

It didn’t take long before Adam strode off the lift with Graeme following him. Autumn finally rejoined them, munching on a chocolate bar of some sort.

“What’s up?” she asked.

“We might have a really big problem. This alias—”

“What alias?” Adam asked.

“Sam. She’s not a real person, or that isn’t her real name. It is a well-crafted legend.”

“No way,” Autumn said, stepping closer. “Let me see.”

Jin stepped aside, confused. “Legend?” She had heard the term used before in her research. It was a backstory for spies, a constructed life that only existed on paper. “Like…she works for the CIA.”

“SHHH! Do not say those letters around here,” Autumn said.

Jin glanced at Adam, who rolled his eyes. “She doesn’t like what she calls the Alphabet People.”

“Alphabet People?”

Adam grinned. “She calls all the FEDs by that name.”

Jin turned to Autumn. “Didn’t you work for one of those groups?”

“Yeah. Why do you think I don’t like them? This is *definitely* a ding-dong legend. Which means if we don’t work carefully, we’ll have the worst of the Alphabet People down here sticking their noses into our business.”

She pulled out her phone.

“Who are you texting?” Adam asked.

“Ian. He’s our best bet to finding out just what the hell Sam was up to.”

Adam looked at Jin. She was sure she looked shell-shocked.

“You okay?”

“I’m not sure, to tell you the truth. This woman is my friend. Or I thought she was.”

“You had no idea?”

She shook her head once again. Maybe if she kept shaking it, she would wake up from a bizarre dream.

“Okay, Ian can come over. He’ll be here in twenty.”

“That fast?”

Autumn nodded. “He was in the office today doing reports. Dillon Security is only about five minutes from here.”

Her eyebrows went up. This Ian must have connections. Dillon Security was considered one of the best firms on Oahu, if not the whole Pacific Rim.

Everyone started shuffling out, but Adam stopped Jin in the hallway. “We’ll be up in a minute, guys.”

Once the elevator doors closed, she waited for the recriminations.

“How are you?”

She blinked. “What?”

“How are you doing with this information?”

She drew in a massive breath, then released it. “I-I’m not sure. I just… How could I have been so stupid?”

She started pacing. Embarrassment and…hurt. She was hurt that she thought this woman was her friend and she had used her.

“Come here.”

She stopped pacing and looked at Adam. “What?”

He reached out and pulled her into his arms. “You weren’t stupid. She was using a CIA-level legend. Those things are hard to detect.”

“Charity found it in less than an hour.”

“Charity is not a real human. She’s like a witch. She also has some good connections and access to things you can’t get into.”

She chuckled, some of her worry slipping away. “Does she know you think she’s a witch?”

“No. So don’t tell her, or she might put a hex on me.”

She pulled back just far enough to look up at him. He was such a good man. She didn’t know how she got this lucky. “Thank you.”

“Anytime. And I don’t think that she was pretending to be your friend.”

“Why do you say that?”

“Just a hunch. You’re good at pulling people into your orbit.”

“Not in the last few years.”

“Wrong. TFH considers you *o’hana*. There is no escaping us now.” He kissed her forehead. “Ready?”

Another deep breath in, she nodded. “Yeah.”

He stepped back but kept hold of her hand. Jin punched the button for the elevator.

“You know that no matter what, I’m always here for you.”

Tears burned the backs of her eyes. Never in all her life had there been one constant. Shipped back and forth between her parents, losing most of her friends after her abduction, but Adam was right. He had been the one constant in her life, the one person she could count on.

She blinked away the tears and squeezed his hand. “Same.”

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Nine

Adam's heart was still in his throat when they stepped off the elevator. He stopped when he saw everyone, including Del. His boss looked at him, then down to Jin and his hands. His mouth twitched.

"We're waiting on Ian," Autumn said.

"Charity was bringing everyone up to speed," Del said.

"Including you?"

"Yeah."

No explanation, but from the smile on Elle's face, he knew that Emma must have texted her what was going on. Adam figured he would find out soon enough what was up.

Ian Smith came striding through the doors. "Hullo, everyone."

He eyed the Brit with curiosity. They had crossed paths once or twice because of his work. He tended to deal with security for foreign dignitaries or celebrities. For some reason, those types always seemed to like an English accent. On top of that, he always dressed like a reject from a BBC police drama.

"About damned time. What were you doing?" Autumn asked.

For his part, Ian didn't look offended. Of course, he was probably used to her if they were good friends. "I was driving over here."

It had been less than twenty minutes. The two of them made an odd pair. He knew they weren't dating. At least, he didn't think so. Adam didn't get a romantic vibe from the two of them. It was more like…they knew each other well. If he didn't know better, he would think they were related, but he knew Autumn had no surviving family with both her parents gone.

"What do you have for me?" Ian asked Charity.

For a second, she said nothing. Her mouth hung open. Adam looked at the Englishman. He was tall, with dark hair and steel blue eyes.

“Good God, don’t look at her. You make most women lose a good deal of their brain cells around you,” Autumn said. “Besides, her FBI husband will shoot you and hide your body if you don’t stop.”

At the mention of her husband, Charity shook herself out of her stupor.

“Sorry, folks. He’s just so pretty. We found out the woman working as Jin’s PA was using an alias.”

“Sorry, but why would you need my help with that? I understood that you were the best of the best.”

Charity smiled. “Thank you. No, this has the feel of a true legend.”

“Ah, and Autumn was worried that the Alphabet People would know you were looking for someone in their ranks?”

She nodded.

“The name?”

“Samantha Charles.”

His smile dissolved. “The fuck? Do you have any ID?”

“No.”

“That tracks,” he muttered.

“Don’t tell me this is the one.” Autumn was shaking her head. “This is his *white whale*.”

“Barracuda, not a whale.”

“Why does that sound familiar?” Charity asked, lost in her own thoughts.

Adam looked between Ian and Autumn. “Someone needs to explain.”

Autumn glanced at her friend, and when he kept staring at the screen with the name on it, she shrugged.

“So, back in Ian’s previous life for a British Alphabet Group, he had a rival.”

A snort. “She wishes.”

“See, even allies have their own arguments. This Samantha and Ian had issues.”

“Issues?”

“She got to someone and used him as an informant. Well, I guess it happened a few times, didn’t it?”

Ian snarled at her, which made Autumn giggle. “Also, her name isn’t the Barracuda. It’s just what he calls her.”

“Oh, damn, I have so many questions,” Charity said.

“I bet I have all the answers. And just so you know, Charles is *his* middle name.”

“Shut it,” Ian said.

Autumn didn’t even spare him a glance. “Spies. They’re all a bunch of bitchy little babies.”

“This is all highly amusing, but I need her real name,” Adam said.

A sigh from Ian. “I don’t know her real name, and I have only seen her once. Lord knows she probably can change her appearance. But she is a genius at computer stuff.” He looked at Charity. “That’s probably why you couldn’t find anything on her. I’m surprised you found that much.”

“So we don’t have a real name.” Adam sighed. “I hate to do it, but we’ll have to contact the CIA.”

“Jesus, don’t say it a third time,” Autumn groused.

“They aren’t Beetlejuice,” Ian said. “Also, they won’t tell you anything.”

“Why is that? If they had an active op, they would want us to stay out of it. I can ask in a way that makes it sound like we’re trying to be nice about it.”

One eyebrow went up as Ian crossed his arms across his chest. “First, they would be suspicious if you try to be nice. Everyone in Alphabet City knows you, so your being nice would set off all the alarms. Second, she was burned about eighteen months ago.”

“They do that?” Jin asked. “Like in *Burn Notice*?”

Ian glanced at Jin. The slow smile grated on Adam’s nerves. “I have not had the pleasure.”

“And you never will,” Adam said.

There was a cough that sounded like Del. Adam was sure his boss was trying to cover up a laugh.

“Jin Phillips.”

Ian nodded in her direction and gave Adam a look of understanding.

“And yes, they do. I have no idea what she got into, seeing that she was more of a white hat hacker than an agent.”

“Wait…shit, I might know her. I mean, I have heard of her,” Charity said. “About eighteen months ago, someone came online, digging around a lot of the darker parts of the internet, someone who posted to boards.”

“That could be her. I’ll give credit where it is due, that woman can hack into anything, including some of the most secure agencies in the world.”

“I bet it’s her. She goes by the name Barracuda.”

He blinked. “She does what?”

“She uses that handle. That’s why it sounded so familiar.”

“But I never called her that.”

Autumn shook her head. “You go on and on about her all the time and the woman is a hacker. I hope you know better than having AI in your house.”

“Of course not.”

“We know that she’s former CIA, is interested in the case we’re working on, and has disappeared. She might have gone missing because of her old life, not what she was doing for Jin,” Charity mused.

“True, but I doubt it. She might have gone under, but I have a feeling it was because someone triggered a warning,” Ian said.

“Yeah, I would agree,” Autumn said, turning toward Jin. “She probably had some kind of warning system just in case anyone started looking for her electronically.”

“That’s worrisome,” Jin said.

“No, what I don’t understand is why she would use one of her old aliases.” Ian glanced at her. “You have no connections to any spy agencies?”

She shook her head. “I just host a podcast.”

“Wait, you do that *Beyond Murder*? I love the show. Everyone in the office does, in fact.”

She could feel her cheeks heat. “Thank you.”

“Then it has to do with what you’re working on. What does this have to do with the Alana Kim murder?”

Adam glanced at his boss, who nodded. “And we’ve found Dylan Brewer, too.”

“Where was he?”

“On a trail near Waimea Falls.”

“He’s dead?” Ian whistled. “That is damned weird, right? That you start investigating, and he is found?”

Adam frowned. He was right. “That is really odd. We need to check out the tourist who found him.”

“With your permission, I’ll call an associate about the Barracuda and see if I can find out what she was burned for.”

Adam nodded, and Ian stepped away to make the call.

“Did Sam suggest this investigation?” Adam asked Jin.

“No. In fact, it was Dr. Nells who mentioned it to me. Why?”

“I’m trying to figure out why Samantha applied to work for you. I wanted to make sure that she wasn’t involved in the killing.”

“She would probably be too young for that.”

“True.”

“But I had only picked up a few books before I hired her.”

“Did you buy them online?” Autumn asked.

“No,” Charity said, interrupting before Jin could answer. “That would have been insane. Trying to keep up with who bought the books or checked them out would definitely be too big of a job. I have a feeling there is something more behind this.”

“Okay, thanks, mate,” Ian said as he walked back toward their group. “I’m not sure it means anything to you, but she was on the trail of a serial killer, one the CIA would rather not talk about. That might be why she found you.”

“Me? What would I have to do with a serial killer?”

“I think she assumed she could hide. If she were researching unsolved cases, no one would suspect it was her.”

“But if she’s as good as you say she is, she wouldn’t need that,” Jin said.

“No, it’s smart. Hiding in plain sight. If there’s a public face, your podcast, to the investigation, there’s a good chance that the CIA or whoever didn’t want her digging into things wouldn’t find her.”

“You keep saying the letters,” Autumn said.

Ian continued to ignore her.

“But I’m still not getting it.”

“From my experience with her, she has a need for revenge. If this is tied to why she was burned, then I would think that she did it for that reason alone. Truthfully, I would hate to be the person who got her burned because she won’t stop gunning for that person until they are fried to a crisp. I’ll keep sniffing around through my back channels.”

He motioned with his head, and Autumn rolled her eyes. She followed him out.

“That was weird.”

“Weird?”

“Did you hear the way he talked about her?”

“Yeah. Someone has a crush,” Tamilya said.

Jin glanced over at the other woman. “Ya think? It’s like the ultimate love/hate relationship but the spy version.”

“I think we need to work some theories out about the new information. Plus, we need to find the name of the witness who found the body.”

“Oh, I have that,” Charity said. “The name is Raymond Reynolds.”

“What?”

“I was talking to Bea over at HPD, and she gave me the name. She can’t understand why they didn’t have it attached to the file.”

“Are you sure it was Raymond Reynolds?” Elle asked.

“Yeah, why?”

“I just identified a body this morning as Raymond Reynolds.”

“And this guy had connections to Joyous Wave?” Adam asked.

“Damn, I do not like the way this is stacking up,” Jin said.

“Why?” Adam asked, caught by her tone. He knew her well enough that when things started to come together in a story, she would get excited. This was different.

“True believers of cults do not ever give up. That’s why so many of them commit suicide together or fight off authorities until the very end. If this does have some connection to Joyous Wave, there could be a few people involved. All of them would be impossible to trace.”

“Pfft,” Charity said. “I will hunt them all down.”

“First, though, make sure you work with Ian to find Sam. I’m more than a little worried that she’s missing. It could be that she wanted to disappear, or her old life came knocking. If the Joyous Wave members are tangled up in this, they could be after her.”

Charity nodded. “No problem.”

Autumn had returned just as he mentioned Joyous Wave. “Those nut jobs are insane. Make sure you’re careful.”

“Raymond Reynolds was the witness who found the body,” Adam said.

“Knowing that creep, he helped kill him. Or at the very least helped dispose of the body. Good riddance.”

“I want you to work as a liaison between us and Ian, Autumn. That way, we might keep the Alphabet People out of this.”

“Knowing them, they already have a bead on her. They wouldn’t hurt her, though. They would have never burned her if they really didn’t want her around.”

“Really?” Jin asked.

“Oh, yeah. Why do you think I don’t like invoking their name? Freaking Alphabet People.”

“Let’s take five and then meet back here to work on theories,” Adam said. Everyone murmured their agreement. He took Jin by the hand and led her into his office.

“Are you okay?”

She nodded. “It’s a lot to take in.”

“And you’re still worried about Sam.”

She sighed and nodded again. “I am. I just never got the ghosting vibe off her.”

Without saying anything, knowing that both of them needed it, he pulled her into his arms. He could feel her heart beating against his chest as he held her.

“We’ll figure it all out, and we’ll do everything within our power to find your friend.”

She leaned back and studied him. “I know. Even in those darker moments, when I was fearful of what would happen to me after I physically healed, I knew you would be there.”

Tears filled her eyes, and he felt as if he had been stabbed in the chest.

“Don’t cry.”

“No, I want to say that there were a few things that kept me going, but knowing you would be there, that you would check on me, it kept me going. You are a good man.”

Then she snuggled against him. Adam tightened his arms around her, silently vowing to himself that he would do everything he could to make sure that he never let her down.

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Ten

Jin was so lost in her thoughts she didn't realize that Adam had turned towards Pali Highway until they were already on the road.

"Wait, where are we going?"

He slanted her a look. "Dinner. My mom can't wait to meet you."

His tone told her that he thought she had lost her mind.

She blinked. "Shouldn't we keep working?"

He shook his head, and she opened her mouth to respond, but he stopped her.

"Let your brain take a moment. Let it reassess the situation later."

"But this is important."

"So is good mental health. And I will let you know that sometimes, taking a break makes you sharper. Things need to marinate. Plus, I'm starving."

As if on cue, her stomach gurgled. Her face heated in embarrassment as he chuckled. "Okay, I'm hungry as well."

"Makes sense. We were stuck there working theories for a while."

"Hmm."

"What do you think of Ian?"

She blinked at him again. They were about to go into the tunnel, and she realized that they had been driving for a while.

"Sorry," she said. "Sometimes my brain goes off."

"No worries. So, this Ian?"

"What about him?"

"Do you think Autumn and he are dating?"

She shook her head. “I get like a total platonic feel about the two of them. They do not find each other attractive. Also, he worked for the dreaded Alphabet People.”

He nodded. “It’s almost like they’re related in some way, but I know she has no family left.”

He took the exit that she assumed led to his house. She had never been there.

“None at all?”

“Nope. It would have popped up in her background check. A family took her in after she escaped the cult, but I don’t know of any other close relationships.”

“Isn’t that odd? Or a warning sign?”

“I guess, but when you work undercover like she did, having close relationships is hard to maintain. I know a lot of marriages don’t last. You definitely can’t date long-term without explaining why you disappear for long periods. Protocol says you can’t reveal yourself to someone without a background check. Plus, you put them at risk just by knowing you.”

“True. A lot of the kids who survived got adopted into families.”

He nodded. “I know a lot of them moved off the island. Not many of them are in the public eye these days.”

She thought about Autumn. The woman was an odd duck that wouldn’t fit into any organization, but she seemed to fit with Task Force Hawaii. That is probably why she had done so well at undercover work.

As he turned down a street, she knew they were getting close to the house. Her nerves started popping, and there was a weird tickle in the back of her throat. She wasn’t the take-home-to-your-mama type of woman. Never had been, but especially now. The idea of sitting at dinner, trying to ignore the weird stares, made her skin crawl.

“Stop worrying.”

She blinked and looked over at him. “What?”

“You’re freaking out. Don’t.”

“Easy for you to say. You’re not going to my mother’s house.”

“I’d do it in a heartbeat if you wanted me to.”

He drew to a stop, but her attention was on him and not anything else. She studied him for a long moment, those deep, soulful dark brown eyes, the way he patiently waited for her to say something.

“She lives on the mainland now. I think.”

The sad thing is she wouldn't know until Christmas came around. For the most part, her parents had their second marriages and didn't like the reminder of their screwed-up marriage. She was easier to forget than to deal with.

He reached out and cupped her face. The calluses on his hands felt like heaven against her skin.

"You are not your family, and fuck them if they don't see what an amazing person you are."

She blinked. "I…You don't cuss that often."

"I don't. Mainly because I was so much older than my sisters, and I wanted to set a good example for them."

He was such a good man. She could see him as a teenager, being the man of the house, trying to show his younger sisters how to behave. He was too good for her.

"Nope, no negative thoughts."

She frowned. "Are you a mind reader?"

He shook his head. "I just know you inside and out."

She sighed. "Listen, I get it. I'm not my family, but you have this amazing family of women who support you. You also have a lot of friends."

"As you do. Whether you like it or not, TFH is your *o'hana*. They love you, and you're kind of stuck with them."

She wanted to ask about his feelings…if he loved her. It was insane to even be thinking about it with everything going on. Still, this felt so different than last time they were involved. Also, she was a coward. She couldn't take him telling her that he wasn't in love with her. Worse, the idea that he might be in love with her scared her. Plus, she was about to go into the lion's den of his family.

Before she could sort out those feelings, there was a tap on the window. She glanced over her shoulder and saw a young woman in her late twenties with long dark hair and the same soulful eyes that Adam had. Except there were dark circles beneath hers. Adam wound down the window.

"Hey," he said. "Kailani, meet Jin Phillips. This is my favorite sister."

An eye roll. "He says that to all of us when we're alone with him. He thinks he has us fooled."

"Lies. Don't trust her," Adam said.

Jin looked at him. "You just said she was your favorite sister."

He shrugged. "I expect free healthcare someday."

“Forget it, bruddah.”

Jin looked back at Kailani and realized she was wearing scrubs. “Oh, that’s right. You’re in residency.”

She nodded. “And I have three days off, thank God. I heard we were having company tonight.” She leaned closer. “Mom is trying to impress you.”

“Me?”

She nodded. “Adam never brings a woman here. I need to wash the day off. Nice to meet you, Jin.”

As she walked off, Jin turned back around to face Adam. “Why would your mom try to impress me?”

“You’re a celebrity.”

She sighed, but he took her hands.

“Yes, they know what happened, but they are more fans of your podcast. They figured out who you were because I was listening to it, so I’m sorry about that. They don’t tell anyone, but I can promise you every woman in the Lee family is in love with your podcast. They are excited to meet you because of that and because they know you’re important to me.”

“I am?”

“I would show you how important it is right now to prove my point, but half my neighbors are watching us. Plus, my mother would get upset with the things I would want to do to you.”

Heat flared low in her belly, then raced through her blood. “Ah…”

He laughed. “Don’t worry. I can be patient as long as you’re still interested in me. I’m cool with that. Now, we had better get in the house, or one of the neighbors could show up to talk. It’s bad enough the Auntie Network is probably going full force.”

She nodded and opened her door. By the time she slid out of the SUV, Adam was there. He was so damned fast.

“I could have helped you out.”

“And I can get myself out, don’t worry.”

He leaned down. “My mother will say something about me not opening the door for you.”

“Really?”

He nodded, and while she didn’t roll her eyes or argue, she doubted that his mother would be upset. She was proven wrong the moment they walked in the door.

“Adam, didn’t I teach you better manners? You open the door for your date.”

Jin opened her mouth to say it wasn’t a date, but she wasn’t given a chance. Mrs. Lee smiled at her and pulled her into her arms. “I’m so happy to meet you, Jin. Come, let’s get something to drink.”

It was after ten that night when he drove Jin home. They’d had a great dinner. All of his sisters had ganged up on him, as he expected. They also took to Jin right away. He knew they would.

“I like your family.”

He glanced over at her. “I do, too.”

“You’re all so close.”

“Yeah, in close quarters and all that. We were raised in that house. And I had to help out after my father died.”

“Your mother never thought of remarrying?”

He shrugged. “Makana just graduated high school last year, so she finally has time on her hands, but I’m not sure.”

“She’s an attractive woman. I would think she would find any number of suitors.”

He slanted her a look. “I don’t want to think about that.”

“No matter what her age, she has needs.”

“Okay, listen, I get that. I’m not an ageist, and I understand my mother is a woman and not just my mom. But…I don’t *want* to think about it.”

She laughed as he turned onto her street. It was a full belly laugh that left his heart lighter. In the next instant, the laughter dissolved.

There were police lights flashing on the street, and the entire area seemed to be in an uproar. They’d roped the area off and stopped Adam.

“Hey, Lee,” the cop said.

“What’s going on?”

“There was a break-in.”

“Mrs. Fong?” Jin asked. When he looked at her, he noticed that her gaze was settled on the house to the right of hers.

“And you would be?”

“Jin Phillips. I live next door. Is Mrs. Fong okay?”

He nodded. “Yeah. The EMTs are checking her out, but she’s just shaken up. It’s weird because this is such a quiet neighborhood.”

“Can you tell me what happened?”

He glanced over at Adam.

“She’s fine. Promise. She’s helping TFH with a case.”

“Oh, okay. Well, she said he kept asking her about a murder.”

A young female officer walked up. “No. He kept asking her about *Beyond Murder.* Mrs. Fong had no idea what he was talking about because she didn’t know about the podcast.”

Adam sensed a stillness from Jin. Shit. This wasn’t good.

“Anyway, can we get to her house?”

“Sure,” the cop said.

He moved the tape to let them by. “Seems like overkill.”

“Mrs. Fong is related to Chief Kelly.”

He blinked and looked at her. “The Chief of Detectives?”

She nodded. “This is bad. And it’s my fault.”

He didn’t want to discuss it sitting in the truck, so he got out and then jogged around to get her out of her side. Taking her keys from her, he unlocked the door. She roused herself to punch in the security code.

“This is bad,” she repeated.

“It isn’t your fault.”

“Yes, it is. I’m the one digging up the past, and it came to her doorstep.”

He grabbed her by her shoulders. “No. You are not the reason. And it might have nothing to do with the case. I need to call Del. You can pack a bag.”

She blinked at him, her eyes coming into focus. “What? Why?”

“You need to stay at a safe house.”

“I will not run away from my house.”

He’d known she was going to argue with him. What he wasn’t prepared for was the anger that swept through him. She was putting herself in danger. Again.

“Your personal assistant is missing. There’s a break-in at your neighbor’s house, and I promise you, whoever did it now knows about you. Or they have a safe bet of who does the podcast. They are going to come back to finish the job. I’m not about to let that happen. Or maybe you would rather wait until someone else is hurt by these assholes?”

Her face paled under his onslaught of words, and he instantly regretted them. Scaring her had been his objective, but Adam didn't like doing it. She still had to understand what was going on.

"Fine," she said, her voice smaller than it was before this had happened, and it irritated him, but there was nothing he could do about it.

She left him standing in the foyer. He wanted to go after her, but he had to concentrate on getting her safe. He called Del.

"What's up?"

"We have a problem."

He explained to Del what happened and precisely who Mrs. Fong was.

"Fuck."

"That sums it up."

"So, what do you want to do?"

He watched as a solemn Jin came toward him with a bag. "We need to move her to a safe house, but I want to come in first. I'm worried there might be eyes on the place."

"You think he might be watching right now?" Jin asked him.

He didn't break eye contact as he nodded. She drew in a deep breath, and then he watched as she straightened her spine.

"Yeah, call the team. We need to discuss this because they know that Jin is the host, and they want to know what she knows."

"Got it."

He hung up.

"I feel horrible about Mrs. Fong."

"Hey, she wasn't hurt. And we can see if they will let you see her before we go. That way, you will feel better."

She nodded. When they stepped outside of her house, there was still a lot of commotion. Adam figured it was because, most of the time, this street was quiet. This kind of activity probably brought everyone within a mile radius to see what was going on. Jin and Adam walked over to the ambulance. A tiny Asian woman sat inside. She was wearing a pink Mumu with purple flowers on it, and her short hair was in disarray.

"Mrs. Fong."

"Oh, Jin. How are you?"

Jin shook her head. "Don't worry about me. What about you? Are you okay?"

She nodded. “Just a little shaken up, so they wanted to check me out. It made no sense at all.”

Jin looked like she wanted to say something, but Adam shook his head. It was then that Mrs. Fong turned her gaze toward him.

“Why don’t you introduce me to your date?”

“Mrs. Fong, this is Adam Lee.”

“Adam Lee? You have your father’s name? He was a cop, yeah?”

He nodded.

“I knew both him and your mother. How is she doing?”

“Fine. We just had dinner with her.”

And, in the way of Oahu, she talked about my sisters as if she knew them. Reno might call themselves the Biggest Little City. Still, most of Oahu was either blood-related or knew each other in some other capacity.

At least ten minutes later, they were finally on their way into TFH headquarters.

“I have a feeling everyone is going to figure out who does *Beyond Murder*,” Jin said, looking out the window. He knew she was still irritated with him, but she held his hand.

“True, but you always thought that was possible, right?”

She nodded her gaze still out the window. They didn’t talk much as they drove through the streets of Honolulu. There was always some kind of traffic, but there wasn't much since it was after eleven. By the time they were walking into TFH Headquarters, almost everyone was there. At least, everyone but Elle, who wasn’t needed for something like this.

“I’m so sorry to disrupt your night,” Jin said to all of them.

Tamilya waved it away. She was sitting next to Marcus. “It’s part of the job, Jin. No worries.”

“I was still here,” Autumn said.

“You need to get a life, girl,” Tamilya said. “Seriously.”

“I talked to Chief Kelly. He’s okay with keeping this under wraps for now. They’re going to step up patrols, and Mrs. Fong’s son, who works for Dillon Security, is going to stay with her for a while.”

“That’s good,” Jin said. “Better would be catching this asshole.”

Everyone was nodding.

“So, I want to put her in a safe house.”

“With you?” Tamilya said with a smile.

“Of course. We’ll need surveillance, but we don’t need to be overt about it.”

“I agree,” Del said. “Let’s look over what houses we have and pick one. Then, you need to take one of the TFH SUVs. That way, if you’re being watched, they might miss you, and they all have pretty good tracking systems on them.”

Adam gave Jin an apologetic look, but she nodded. She understood there was no way around this. He wanted her safe, then he wanted this fucker taken down. The sooner he could do that, the sooner they could get on with their lives.

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Eleven

By the time they got to the safe house, Jin's nerves were a mess. She was trying her best not to freak out, but someone finding her address, even if they seemed to have been off by one number, appeared to be a bad sign. Had she been fooling herself? Giving herself a false sense of security all this time?

She wandered around the bedroom. They were in Monoa, up in the hills. The neighborhoods were filled with historic homes and were unique. Adam explained that this house was bought because it had an actual panic room at the bottom, built into the mountain. The original owner had been someone worried the Japanese would overrun Hawai'i during World War II. Then, with the Cold War and fears of a nuclear explosion, the man had added to it. Adam had said they kept a full kitchen down there with canned foods, and now, an entire security setup is needed.

They gave her the master bedroom at the back of the house. Koa wood floors creaked beneath her bare feet as she paced. If the situation was different, she would be in heaven. Historical homes on Oahu—especially those that survived December 7th—were so beautiful. Jin had thought it would be bare bones, seeing that it was just for keeping people safe. Houses like this were more about that and not the creature comforts.

Adam explained they had bought the house with antique furniture, and a lot of it was Hawaiian-designed and manufactured. The massive canopy bed was romantic…and comfy. She had tested it out. All dark wood until you stepped into the ensuite bathroom. The tile floor was all art deco with geometric patterns in black and white. The clawfoot tub was a dream. It would be a dream getaway if she wasn't here for her protection.

Still, it was refreshing not to worry about it, but this was the first time she'd had to worry about anything like this. Well, in a long time. TFH had taken over all the arrangements. Granted, she didn't have access to safe houses, but she could have rented a massive suite at some hotel or even a home with security for a few days.

Had she not learned from her mistakes a few years ago? Her audacity and stupidity got her abducted, tortured…and worse. The truth was, if TFH had not found her when they did, she would have been dead. And here they were saving her again because, apparently, she was a hot mess.

Anger and fear twisted her gut. Whoever this bastard was, he seemed intent on going after her. For what reason? The murder was almost two decades old, and if they find anything on Dylan's body that helps them, she had nothing to do with that. Why would they think she did? She found out it was Dylan when everyone else did, so it wasn't like she was ahead of the game.

She massaged her temple. She was getting a headache for the first time in a long time. A rager that would leave her stuck in bed. She had so much to worry about. Where was Sam? Was that someone from her past, or was it this investigation? If digging into this murder brought danger to Sam, she would never forgive herself.

A soft knock at the door broke into her dark thoughts.

"Yes?"

The door creaked open, and Adam stuck his head through the opening. "How are you doing?"

She pulled in a deep breath and then released it slowly. Worst thing about this situation? She wanted to jump Adam's bones. It had surprised her how fast and furious her need had risen. It had been years since she had wanted a man to touch her in that way. And now that she discovered those feelings again, she was stuck in a safe house with the one man she wanted. No. Wrong. Not just wanted. It was almost as if she *needed* him. Her body craved his attention, his touch…

What the hell was going on with her? Was she a danger junkie? She needed to talk to someone about this because it didn't seem right.

His smile faded as he opened the door wider. Dark eyes studied her, and she could almost hear his thoughts. Everyone assumed she would freak out. Granted, when she'd been in recovery after her abduction, she hadn't wanted anyone touching her.

“Jin, are you okay?”

She nodded, not able to speak. Truthfully, she was afraid he would know how much she wanted him if she did. She wasn’t sure that there wasn’t some sort of video surveillance in this room.

“You’re scaring me.” He walked to her on soft feet. For such a big man, he had always been this way. Quiet, reserved…careful. She never felt as if she had to be on guard with him, and that was before *and* after the incident.

With gentle hands, he took her by the arms. It was hard to hold herself back from him. She wanted to jump on and climb him like a tree. Jin had wondered if she would ever have a libido again after what had happened. Still, of course, she decided she wanted Adam. Worst timing in the world.

His thumbs caressed her upper arms. “Talk to me.”

It wasn’t a demand. No, there was a plea in his voice that struck at her heart. God, he was killing her.

“I’m fine,” she said, although she said it from behind clenched teeth.

“You don’t sound like you are.”

She huffed out a breath. It was taking all of her control not to wrench herself away from him—or jump on him. Jesus, she needed help.

“Well, I might have some nut job after me because I investigated an old murder.”

“It might have nothing to do with you.”

She narrowed her eyes. Really? He was going to lie.

“So, they asked about my podcast, for what reason?”

He nodded. “This might have to do with Sam.”

She couldn’t be this close to him, feel his body heat. His earthy scent tickled her senses. With measured movements, she pulled away. He frowned but didn’t grab her. He understood her boundaries.

“Talk to me, Jin.”

Those words. He used them a lot during her recovery. When she lost a lot of her friends, Adam stayed. He had fought through her fears and patiently waited until she was ready to engage in friendships again. All of Task Force Hawaii, but Adam had checked on her daily. If not in person, then by text.

“Do you think her past has come back to get her?”

He nodded. “Could be. You’re the one contact she’s maintained these last few months, so they might think you could help them find her.”

That made sense, but her instinct, the one that had made her such a good reporter, told her it had to do with the Alana Kim murder.

“So, tell me, how long will we be stuck here?”

He looked wary now. Jin didn’t blame him. There was a bite to her tone, one that she didn’t use that often. It left her words sharp even though there wasn’t anything antagonistic to her words. There was a time when she could leave a person cold with just a sentence. Not anymore. Trauma had softened her edges. She didn’t feel the need to use her words to wound anymore, thanks to Dr. Nells.

But, Jesus, what was she supposed to do? He was standing there, his fantastic body tempting her, his smoldering gaze stealing any kind of rational thought. It was like her brain was melting. She should be concentrating on the case or maybe where Sam might be. All she cared about now was how touching Adam’s impressive chest would feel.

“Not sure. Hopefully not long. That Ian is already getting some information back on Sam, as is Autumn.”

She nodded and turned away. Her fingers were itching to touch him. Adam hadn’t even been flirting with her, and her nipples were hard.

“I’m sorry, Jin. I wish I had a better answer.”

Dammit. Now, he thought she was mad about the situation. “I’m not angry with you.”

“It feels like you are.”

“Don’t.”

“Don’t what?”

“Don’t tell me how I feel.”

There was silence from him. Great, now she probably pissed him off. When she turned around to face him, she felt the impact of his attention. This man was the only one who could make her feel like she was the only woman in the world. She wasn’t a virgin when she’d slept with him, but never in her life had a man made her feel the way he did. It was like the world dissolved, and all that mattered was the two of them.

“I’m not. I promise. It’s just…” she waved her hand in his direction.

“What?”

Any other man, she would think he was putting on an act, but Adam really didn’t know how hot he was. Or if he did, it didn’t matter to him.

“Adam, I’m trying very hard to do everything within my power *not* to seduce you.”

His gaze flared, darkened, and she could feel it all the way to her soul. God, this man. He was tempting her in so many ways, just like when they first met over five years ago. But now…it was different somehow. Deeper…on a different level than just physical.

She licked her lips. But she wanted him on a physical level. She knew it was not a good idea. The situation was terrible, and with someone after her, it was stupid, but she'd been losing the battle of why she shouldn't touch him.

"Why are you?"

She blinked. Had she missed part of the conversation? "What?"

"Why are you trying not to seduce me?"

There were about twenty feet between them, and he closed the space with just a few steps. Adam didn't touch her. Instead, he gazed down at her, need filling his dark eyes. The air around them seemed to heat. Her skin felt itchy and tight.

"I…" she licked her lips again, and his gaze followed the action. Heat spiraled through her. "I thought that doing something like that was against the rules."

His full, sensuous mouth twitched. God, she wanted his lips on her. His tongue, his hands. His…everything. She was so turned on…even if there was a little fear. She hadn't let a man touch her since her ordeal, but this was the first time that she really did want it. What if she couldn't do it? What if she freaked out on him?

"What rules would those be?" he asked, drawing her out of her spiraling anxiety.

"I don't know. That's what they say in movies."

One eyebrow rose up, and she bit her lower lip. She was in a lot of trouble if that one motion left her panties wet.

"They do?"

She nodded. "In the last Jakob Wulf movie, he rescued Monique Alba from the terrorists, and they said it there."

"Jin?"

"Yes?"

"This isn't a movie." He slipped his hand around her waist. "This is real life, and we make the rules."

She stepped closer, pressing her body against his. He moaned and muttered something under his breath that she didn't quite catch. Steadying

herself by placing her hands on his chest, she rose to her tiptoes and leaned closer so she could whisper.

"Are there cameras in here?"

She felt, rather than saw him swallow. "No."

"Good," she said before taking his earlobe between her teeth.

He pulled her closer, her entire body now pressed against his. When she felt his mouth against her throat, she closed her eyes and just felt. He kissed a path up her neck. Jin pulled back and offered her mouth up to him. At first, the kisses were gentle, almost sweet. But in the next moment, they turned carnal, his tongue sweeping into her mouth. She could taste minty toothpaste…and Adam. The intoxicating flavor of the one man she would always want.

Before she was ready, he pulled back. She moaned in irritation and tried to urge his mouth back down to hers, but he stopped her. Her eyes flickered open.

"Are you sure?"

"Yes."

"Jin. Tell me this isn't about the situation. That you aren't having a reaction to being in danger."

God, this idiot. She wanted to scream, but she knew it was *this* man. She had seen him with his sisters and his mother. There was a bone-deep love there but so much respect. He had waited patiently for her. She knew he probably dated these past few years but didn't care. Much.

"I'm sure. I was going to ask you to stay the night tonight before all this happened."

He blinked, and then a slow smile curved his lips. God, that mouth.

"Yeah?"

She nodded, then rose to her tiptoes again. "I don't know how to be clearer about this. I. Want. You."

By the time she finished the sentence, he had her in his arms, bridal style. He carried her over to the bed, gently setting her down on the mattress.

"If at any moment you want to stop, you tell me. I will do it."

She crooked her finger at him until he bent lower. Cupping his face in both of her hands, she kissed him. Long…wet…amazing. Then she pulled back.

“I promise,” she whispered. She knew without that vow, he would never touch her. It went against his DNA.

“I think we should go slow.”

“You’re backing out?”

“God, no. Just, we should make sure we take this slowly tonight.”

Tears burned the backs of her eyes as she closed them. She didn’t deserve this man. He was so understanding. When she opened her eyes, he looked down at her with a frown.

“Tell me why you’re crying.”

“I’m not crying.”

He cupped her face with one of his massive hands, his thumb caressing her cheek. “You are.”

“I don’t deserve you,” she blurted out. “I was so horrible to you when we dated—”

He set his fingers over her mouth, stopping her confession.

“We each made mistakes.”

She shook her head.

“We did. I wasn’t truthful with you.”

“About what?” she asked, his fingers still against her mouth.

“I was falling in love with you, Jin.”

She felt her eyes widen as he dropped his hand.

“I was afraid of scaring you off, so I never said anything.”

She opened her mouth to respond, to tell him how she felt, but he shook his head. “I don’t expect a responding answer. I just want you to know those feelings haven’t changed. I don’t want you freaking out about it. My feelings have nothing to do with you.”

A chuckle bubbled up. “I think it has a little bit to do with me.”

His mouth curved up into a lopsided smile. “Yeah, but what I mean is that I’m okay with this just being us right now. That someday, you will say the words back to me. I can wait.”

She nodded.

“Now, up on the bed. I want to do some smooching.”

She giggled and turned to get up to her hands and knees. “You have one of the best asses God has ever created.”

By the time they settled against the massive number of pillows, Adam had already lost his shirt. He settled next to her, and Jin couldn’t stop

herself. She touched his chest. He was so big, his pectoral muscles so well-defined. He had various tattoos on his body, primarily Hawaiian.

He bent his head as he pulled her closer and started to kiss her. All the worries she had had, her fears, dissolved under his sensual onslaught.

At that moment, Jin released all of that and just let herself feel it. His hands roamed her body, possessed her. This was a different feel than all those years ago. This was definitely physical, but she felt something else, something on a level she hadn't felt before.

With slow moves, he eased her shirt up and off her, then shuddered when he saw she was braless. She smiled, then gasped as he bent his head and took a tight, hard nipple into his mouth. A graze of teeth, then the swipe of his tongue sent liquid heat to her pussy. This man had always been so talented with his mouth.

When he pulled back, he blew on her wet nipple. After giving her other nipple the same attention, he moved his way down her body. Soon, she was naked and needy. It had been years since she had even wanted a man, and now that she was having her dream man once again, she didn't think she could be happier.

Adam settled between her legs and looked up at her body.

"Still okay?"

"Yes."

She was the most okay she had been in years.

After slipping his hands beneath her bottom, he pulled her up closer to his mouth. He licked her slit and teased her clit with his tongue. Molding her hands to the back of his head, she urged him on, allowing the sensations to roll through her and push her to the edge. She needed a release, this release. Jin was sure she would die if she didn't get a release in the next few seconds.

When she was sure she would lose her mind, all the fantastic tension exploded. As her eyes slid closed, Jin saw a kaleidoscope of colors.

Several moments later, she lay boneless, her entire body seemingly relaxed. Adam slipped from the bed, and she opened her eyes.

"Are you leaving?"

His hands were on his pants, the outline of his erection easy to see.

"Not unless you tell me to." Then he rolled his eyes. "Dammit, I don't have condoms."

The fact that he was unprepared inwardly made her smile. Also, the fact that he didn't carry them on his person made her think that maybe he hadn't been that active. It might make her a horrible person, but the fact that perhaps he hadn't been dating anyone recently made her happy.

"Are you clean?"

He nodded.

"I take the birth control shot, and I'm clean."

"Thank God."

He tore off his pants, tossing them behind him, his cock curved up against his belly. He was the perfect sculpted man, an eight-pack, those thick thighs, and of course…damn. She licked her mouth. There was a drop of pre-cum on the head.

"Nope," he said as he joined her on the bed. He covered her body, then rolled them until she was straddling him.

"I wanted you in my mouth."

He shook his head. "I need inside that tight, wet pussy."

She cocked her head, realizing that he was leaving it up to her. Once again, he was letting her set the pace of their relationship. This man…he was killing her. There was no way she couldn't fall in love with him.

She wanted to tell him, but knowing he wouldn't believe her right now, she did the next best thing and decided to give him as much pleasure as he had always given her.

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Twelve

Adam could still taste her on his tongue. He would never get tired of that, but at the moment, his control was hanging on by a thread. Heat coursed through him. His heart was beating out an insane beat that would surely kill him. Everything in him urged him to take, to conquer.

He couldn't do that. Instead, he bit back the need to tell her to hurry. Jin needed to control the pace of their lovemaking. Everything in this act was about her, showing her how much he loved her. He cherished her. She needed to understand that he would always be there, no matter what. And this was like the first time. They were both different from who they were years ago.

Worse, this was going to be the first time he took a woman bare. His cock jerked. On top of that, it had been a very long time since he'd had sex. Just thinking about her wet heat surrounding his shaft had him almost coming.

Jin leaned down, her nipples brushing against his chest. Taking his earlobe between her teeth, she bit down.

He groaned, and she hummed against his flesh. The vibrations filtered through his body, rushing through his nerve endings, setting them on fire.

She scooted down his legs, kissing a path down his throat, chest, and stomach, nipping at his flesh every few kisses. When he thought she would ignore his warning and take his cock in her mouth, she bypassed it so she could wrap her fingers around the shaft. She stroked him, long, leisurely… and he barely kept it together. Jesus, her hands were weapons he would

gladly die to have on him. With each measured stroke, she slipped her finger over the head.

He groaned and did everything he could to keep from coming all over her hand. He had no problem with that…later, but he wanted to fill her up the first time together again.

“Jin, I want in you,” he said, his voice deeper than before.

She hesitated for a long moment, causing him to have doubts. He needed to know that she was okay with this. Worry had his brows lowering. He knew this might leave him unsatisfied, but he needed her to be alright. He didn’t need her to prove herself to him.

“You don’t have to do this, Jin. We don’t have to do this.”

Defiance glittered in her gaze as she looked up at him.

“You think I can’t.” There was enough hurt in her voice that told him she was equally committed to finishing and fearful of her reaction.

He shook his head. “I think you can, but I only want you to do what you feel comfortable doing.”

Her lips curved, power flowing off her in waves. This woman…she was amazing. Just that one look of triumph almost had him coming. He watched as she bent her head to lick down one side of his cock, then up the other, swirling her tongue around the head before taking him in her wet, warm mouth.

He closed his eyes and clawed at the sheets. Otherwise, he would slip his fingers through her hair and take control. This had to be her decision and at her pace. He understood that, but it was hard to control himself.

As she continued to take him in and out of her mouth, she slid her fingers down to his sac, teasing him to the point where he almost lost it.

“Jin.”

She kept sucking him as she looked up at him. Fuck, it was one of the most erotic things he had ever seen in his life.

“I want to be inside of you this first time I come tonight.”

She released his cock with a pop. “You’ll let me take that all the way some other time?”

She sounded like she didn’t believe him.

“If you think I’m going to say no, you have lost your damned mind. Just this time…our first…I want to be inside of you.”

“Adam, we’ve had sex before.”

“This is our first time this time around.” And she would be his last if he had anything to say about it.

She still looked confused.

“This time…this is love for sure.”

He could almost feel her pulling back from him, but he didn’t want that. He would fall to pieces if she did that. Maybe not the most masculine thing to admit, but it is what it is. He could wait for her to be ready no matter how long it took. She was his life.

“You don’t have to say it to me.” *Yet.* “But I do love you, Jin. I never thought I would get you back, even before everything that happened. I waited, didn’t know if it would happen, but now that I have you back, I will do everything I can to prove to you that we were meant to be. So, this time…this first time…I want to be connected to you.”

Her gaze softened as he went on about his feelings.

“Now, take pity on me and climb up here.”

She smiled, full-on seduction. His heart jerked at her confidence. She was so damned beautiful all the time, but he loved her like this. This power was his kryptonite. He pitied men who didn’t understand how sexy a woman could be when a woman was confident in the bedroom.

“There’s nothing pitiful about you, Adam Lee,” she said, her voice curling around him as she rose over him. Taking his cock in her hand, she centered herself over it, then slowly sank onto him.

Her tight heat surrounded him. Jin didn’t hurry. Instead, she took her time, slowly sliding all the way down onto his cock. When he was finally seated in her completely, she pivoted her hips, causing them both to groan.

Adam slipped his hands around to take hold of her ass. Then, she started to ride him. The rhythm was slow and steady to start. And she knew she was pushing him closer to the edge. The triumph in her expression almost made him laugh. He couldn’t because he was in too much pain. She was keeping him on the edge, teasing him with a release. And damn, she knew it.

Well, two could play this game. He skimmed one hand around to her clit. He held her gaze as he pressed against it before pinching it. She jerked, then moaned. Adam continued to press her clit as he leaned up and took one nipple into his mouth.

Just that little move had her movements increasing. Her tits were bouncing with her movements as she lost all control. He was so fucking

close. He would surely lose it if he couldn't get her to come again.

He pinched the tiny bundle of nerves once more, and that was all it took. She exploded, slamming down onto his cock.

"Adam."

"That's it. Fuck, you are so beautiful when you come."

Her muscles squeezed him, pulling him deeper into her tight core. He did take over then, holding her hips so he could thrust up into her once… twice…and he came on the third thrust.

It was so powerful his eyes rolled back in his head at the pleasure that coursed through him.

She collapsed on top of him, and they fell back onto the bed. Their harsh breathing was the only sound filling the air. Fuck, how did it get so much better than the last time they were together. But it was. Every second would be seared on his brain until the end of time.

"I'll get up in a minute," she said, her words slurred.

He chuckled. "No rush, *ku'u lei.*"

Soon, her breathing evened out, and he wrapped his arms around her and followed her into sleep.

Several hours later, Jin roused herself and found the bed beside her empty. Reaching out, she slid her hand against the sheets. It was still warm. She heard water in the bathroom, and she slipped out of bed. The moment she stood, she winced. Her muscles were exhausted, but she hadn't felt this alive in years. Probably since the last time she and Adam were together. Grabbing his t-shirt, she slipped it on over her head. It smelled of Adam—all woodsy and manly and Adam. His scent always reminded her of the air at night in Hawai'i. Just a little sweet but filled with earthy goodness.

With careful steps—she was damned sore!—she walked to the bathroom. Adam was standing in all of his naked glory, filling the tub. She smelled lilacs, and she smiled. They were one of her favorite scents. She wasn't sure if he remembered her telling him that, but knowing Adam, she had. It had been when they first started dating. She must have moved because he looked up at her. His gaze zeroed in on the shirt she was wearing.

“Hope you don’t mind.” She didn’t know what else to say because the look he was giving her was… weird. In fact, she wasn’t sure if he was mad or not.

“No…I just…” he swallowed. “I like seeing you wear my shirt.”

The possessive tone had her entire body reacting. While heat spiraled through her, her nipples tightened. She smiled.

“I thought you would like a bath.”

“I would as long as you will join me.”

His toothy grin had her heart dancing. “Of course. I was going to insist.”

She pulled his shirt up and off her, tossing it on the floor behind her. He stepped into the tub and sat down before helping her in so she could sit in front of him.

“Lean back,” he said, urging her to rest against him.

Then, she remembered the marks on the back, the scars she refused to have removed.

“Relax, *ku’u lei*.”

My beloved. She blinked, suddenly feeling like she might cry. Why had she been reacting that way to everything for the last week? Not only with Adam but also with all the support the TFH continued to show her. She swallowed those questions for the one that she needed to know right now.

“You aren’t going to ask?”

“About your scars?”

She nodded jerkily.

“If you want to tell me, you will. If you don’t want to, that’s fine too.”

She closed her eyes, willing the tears not to fall, but they did, coursing down her cheeks. It wasn’t from sadness or terror. It was acceptance. From the moment she’d met him years ago, Adam had always accepted her. He never pried into what she was investigating like a lot of other cops did. It was probably why she went so far with him. It was as if she was all he cared about, not the information she could give him.

“*Ku’u lei*, what’s wrong?”

She sniffed and brushed away the tears. Of course, her hands were damp, so she left her cheeks even wetter.

“You’re scaring me.”

With a shuddering sigh, she screwed up the courage. “You’ve always just liked me for me.”

“Like?”

He sounded skeptical, but he didn’t give her a chance to ask about that.

“There’s a lot to like about you, Jin.”

“Name one thing that has nothing to do with my appearance because I know that’s what men think of first.”

He tsked. “That is not when I was first attracted to you.”

“It’s not?”

He urged her forward as he soaped up a washcloth. With gentle strokes, he washed her back. The mesmerizing movement of his hands had her relaxing even more. The man really was good with his hands.

“No. I met you several days after I *heard* you.”

She frowned. “Heard me?”

His chuckle sent need spiraling through her again. Apparently, her dormant sexual appetite was ravenous.

“Yeah. You had been in HPD bugging Josh Miller.”

Ah, yes. Josh Miller, who had conversations with her breasts. “What a douche.”

His snort was so loud that she laughed. “Yeah. He is. Well, I heard you laugh. At first, it wasn’t real. It’s that one you use when you’re trying to get information from a stupid man.”

“Hey!”

“I’m just being honest.” She could hear the smile in his voice. “And I’m not judging you. It was your job.”

He started to rinse off her back, but she said nothing. Right then, she wasn’t sure she could.

“But then, Mary Stephens and you were talking.” One of the most powerful admins who worked in HPD Headquarters. “And you laughed. Like a real laugh. I wasn’t facing you, hadn’t seen your face, just the back of your head at first. I didn’t know your name. I just heard that laugh. I was a goner.”

Heat that had only a little to do with lust swirled in her belly.

“I don’t want to pretty up my past.” She sensed that he stilled behind her. “My entire adult life has been marred with people who took me at face value. And at first, I was okay with that. I was always the ‘exotic one’ in a high school of mainly white people. And not in a good way, in a ‘you don’t fit in with us’ way. When I got to college, it changed. You know what that’s

like, right? Well, not really, since you went here and probably knew half your class.”

He chuckled, then urged her back against him. “Yeah, mostly.”

“But in college, being different was good. Standing out as special and smart was finally attractive to others. It went to my head, but I learned to use it to my advantage.”

Jin waited, her entire body tense. Most people would be judgmental of her actions. When he said nothing, she filed that away to deal with later.

“When I started out as a beat reporter, I knew I was smart, but I also knew that being on the crime beat would have me in contact with mostly men. Even in this day and age, police work is dominated by men. So, I would smile and giggle to get information from the guys. But then, I met you.”

He had been trailing his hand up and down her arm, but his hand momentarily paused, then started back up.

“You didn’t talk to my boobs. You smiled at me, looked me in the eye, and then asked me on a date.”

“I remember.” He was still smiling, and it made her heart light.

“We went to dinner, and you made me laugh while talking about your family of women. It was obvious you loved and respected them.” That was the straightforward story. Now came the dark part. “In those moments after…when I was recovering, all through the months.” Years really. “When I thought I would lose it when the darkness started to close in on me, I thought about that date. The way you would smile at me, the way you held the door for me and put your hand on the small of my back. All those little things helped me out of the dark hole.”

“Jin.”

He was trying to urge her up and around, and if she had to see him face to face, she would never get everything out, and she knew it was important to tell him. To say it out loud to someone other than her therapist.

“I’m not all light and sunshine. I never have been, not with my upbringing. And I wanted to remember that. I also wanted anyone who could get this close to know I had gone through something that was so damned dark that it’s hard to think about it, even now. I wanted to end it all more than once, but then…that memory. The way you would laugh, the smile…and all the times you would contact me. It was like you knew exactly what I needed.”

Finally ready to look at him, she turned and climbed on his lap, ignoring how the water sloshed over the side of the tub. She tried to ignore his cock pulsing against her core, but it was definitely difficult. Cupping his face in both of her hands, she said, “I don’t know where we are going, and I don’t want any kind of declaration from you. What I want is exactly what you are, Adam. You are what I want. What I need.”

She kissed him then, pressing her mouth against his, keeping her gaze locked on his. Part of her wanted him to demand a declaration from her. She knew he wanted to give her one, but he held it back for her sake. Instead, he urged her out of the tub and then joined her. With a fluffy towel, he dried her off with smooth, slow strokes. By the time he carried her to bed, she was shivering with need and something else she wasn’t ready to face.

He set her on the mattress, then covered her body with his. This time, he took his time as if trying to convey his feelings through his actions. Slowly, methodically…he undid her with his hands, his mouth. Her worries dissolved under his careful lovemaking. He entered her in one hard thrust while she was still shivering from the orgasm he had given her. As they crested together, she screamed his name, giving herself over to pleasure. At that moment, she knew she would never love another man like Adam Lee.

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Thirteen

As he made his way down the stairs, Adam wasn't thrilled. Well, he was happy, but not with the situation. When he stepped into the living area, he got a shit-eating grin from Graeme.

"Shut up," Adam said with little heat.

He chuckled. "No judgment from me, mate. Even though I lost some money—"

"Dammit, Del told you guys to stop making bets on our sex lives."

He continued on as if Adam hadn't spoken. "And Autumn is going to be insufferable about this. Still, I'm glad you finally got her back."

"I'm not sure if I have her back."

His smile dissolved. "What do you mean by that?"

"She doesn't want any declarations. At least not right now."

"Ah, the rational side of her. That makes sense. You all are in an intense situation. Remember *Speed*?"

"We are not in a Keanu Reeves movie. This is real life."

"I understand that, mate. But women like big declarations."

"So, you're wise to women now?"

Graeme snorts. "Well, I have mine, right? So maybe I can give you some advice."

Adam wanted to tell his friend to mind his own damned business, but Graeme had a point. The man did get Elle to marry him.

Adam sighed. "I don't have any problems with my feelings. I've loved her for years."

There was a beat of silence. He knew it put a little too much emotion in the declaration, but it was hard to keep it under wraps.

“But it’s about what she’s ready to hear?”

Adam nodded once. “I told her how I feel and said I would wait.”

“Just don’t leave it too long, mate. Don’t be pushy because that’s not the right thing to do.”

“Waiting is going to be a pain in the ass.”

His friend barked out a laugh. “She cares for you. You just have to prove to her that her feelings are right and just.”

Another nod, but before he could ask another question, their walkies went off.

“On my way up with information,” Autumn said.

“What do you think the story is about her and Ian?”

Adam glanced at him. “Not sure. They seem to be close, but platonically.”

“Yeah. There were grumblings.”

“Stop betting.”

The way the Scotsman’s eyes danced told Adam that Graeme wasn’t about to stop. None of them were…the buttheads. Adam would have to deal with it when he was team leader, but right now, he didn’t care. He wanted this case over so he could prove to Jin it wasn’t the situation.

The door blew open, revealing Charity, followed by her husband TJ, and finally Autumn.

“Hey, there,” Graeme stood. “What’s up?”

“Well, I wanted to text about it, but Autumn insisted that I come here to talk to you,” Charity said with a frown.

“Listen, I don’t trust Hank. He was always good at all things science, including electronics. There’s always a chance that he’s been monitoring us.”

“And you came here?” Graeme asked.

“She made us turn our phones off,” TJ said.

Autumn rolled her eyes. “Listen, Alphabet Man, I have very little patience for this right now. I told you to stay back at TFH, but you went all macho asshole and insisted on bringing us here. Like I can’t protect Charity.”

“I offered to drive so you could eat,” TJ said, laughing.

“Okay, so what do you have?” Adam said. He didn’t want to chitchat about things. He wanted answers more so than before he’d ended up here.

“Calm down, boss. I would think you would be more settled.”

They heard someone coming down the stairs. The only person up there was Jin.

“Do not embarrass her. It’s an order.”

Autumn’s eyes widened at his vicious tone.

“Never, boss.”

“And stop calling me that.”

“What’s going on?” Jin interrupted whatever Autumn had her mouth open to respond with.

“We might have discovered who is doing all the shenanigans on the island.”

“Yeah?”

Adam looked at her. She was wearing a pair of yoga pants and a massive UH shirt. Damn, she was so fucking beautiful.

“She was just about to tell us.”

Jin nodded, and they turned toward the newcomers.

“We were looking at some payments from Brewer,” Charity began. “TJ and I were going through all the transactions, and this one popped up.” She pulled up the document on her tablet. “I turned the GPS off before you say anything. Anyway, when we saw this, we went back years. There are payments every three months or so for 100 K.”

Adam looked over the documentation. “What is this HankSea?”

“That’s where I come in,” Autumn said. “HankSea is Harold Seymour Andrews.”

“You don’t know that for sure.”

“I do. That was my father’s nickname for him.”

Excitement filled Adam. He didn’t want to get his hopes up, but damn if this didn’t feel like an excellent lead.

“But wasn’t he killed in the fire?”

Autumn rolled her eyes, irritation turning down the corners of her mouth. She crossed her arms over her chest. “No. That was what the stupid FBI and ATF said.”

“Hey,” TJ said with a laugh. Adam got the idea that this was a long-standing argument between the two of them.

“Anyway, I have always said that Harold would have survived. That bastard was good at looking squeaky clean,” Autumn grumbled.

“On paper, until you dig under all the BS,” Charity said. “He left his money—and there were millions— to this HankSea. On paper, it looks like

some kind of wildlife rescue. But the money gets filtered out of there and into other accounts, most in places like Switzerland and the Caymans.”

Both places would make it hard to trace. Autumn wasn’t wrong. If this Andrews was still alive, that was the smartest thing to do.

“If we could track them down now, it would do no good,” TJ said. He was a liaison with TFH, but his bread and butter were cybercrimes.

“Too long?”

TJ nodded. “Fifteen years is a long time to clean that money, and I’m sure he has.”

“Why was Brewer giving him money?” Jin asked. “I get that he might be into saving wildlife, but to offer up that much is suspicious. And it started after Dylan disappeared?”

Charity nodded. “And the next payment was due a day ago, according to the pattern. It was almost always every ninety days. It looks like Brewer decided to cancel it.”

“Because they found Dylan? Do you think that he thought he was paying to keep his son safe and out of the way?”

“That’s a great question,” Adam said. “I think we need to wake the bastard up.”

They all agreed with it, except Jin. She was studying them all as if they had lost their minds.

“What?”

“It might be dangerous.”

He chuckled, and then he realized she was serious. He sobered, realizing that she was worried about them. “Hey, we’ll be fine. This is what we’re trained for. He had some goons around him.”

“Which makes me think of something,” Graeme said. “They seemed kind of wrong, you know what I mean?”

Adam thought back to the men they had encountered. The men they encountered reminded him of muscle that someone making a statement would want. Big, not that bright, but they told people to leave him alone. Celebrities wishing to make a splash usually hired those types. Billionaires tended to hire a different sort. “Yeah. I just thought it was normal when we were there, but now, it seems odd. Billionaires like him who hide out and don’t want attention would normally hire someone like Dillon Security.”

Autumn was already texting, probably to Ian. He would know if they were with Dillon.

“What were they like?” Jin asked.

“They were more mob-looking, or at least more brutish. Not like Ian,” Adam said. “Almost like something you would see in a movie.”

Autumn snorted. “He’s going to check with their admin. And just so you know, Dillon has some muscle types, but most of them are smarter than Ian. And you can tell him I said that. Marcus is going to meet us there. Tamilya is with him.”

Adam nodded. Autumn was a strange duck, but she was good at her job.

“I want you to stay here with her,” he told the three newcomers. Autumn opened her mouth, but Adam said, “You know Andrews. It’s been over fifteen years, but you saw him up close and personal for several years.”

She straightened her spine, and the militant look faded from her eyes. “Yes. You’re right.”

“I take it you’re okay with being here,” he said to TJ, who nodded. “You can use the computer set up in the panic room. It still has all the bells and whistles you put on it.”

“Yes,” Charity said, excitement filling her voice. In fact, the whole room felt like it was buzzing. As if they all knew this was it. They were finally on the trail of what the hell was going on. He thought of everyone but one person as he glanced at Jin.

“The guards will stay,” Adam said.

Then, he grabbed Jin by the hand and tugged her into the kitchen for privacy. She was deathly pale and frowning at him. Worry darkened her eyes. “Tell me.”

She sighed. “Can’t you wait until it’s light? It would be safer, yes?”

He set his hands on her hips, then leaned against the counter, pulling her into the vee between his legs.

“It might be a little safer, but the truth is, I’m worried about Sam. If they haven’t killed her, they would have left her somewhere.”

“You think she’s still okay?”

He nodded, then grimaced. “I won’t lie. They might try to gain information from her. Or they did, but they might need more. Anyway, they got lucky with Dylan. He was left up on a trail. The report said there’s a good chance he was just tossed off the side of the trail. The only reason we didn’t find him earlier was that animals got after him.”

“And Alana was left on the beach.”

He didn’t want to voice his opinions on that part just yet. The two murders were linked. He was sure of that. The timing proved that. But they were different murders. One was passionate and up close. The other was shot in the back of the head, impersonal.

“So, they aren’t that smart, and Sam is amazing based on everything you told me about her. There’s every chance that she escaped them and is hiding out.”

She nodded. He could hear her mind turning over the situation, and she would drive herself crazy, so he decided to throw a bomb in the middle of everything.

“I hate that this was our way back to each other.”

She blinked, her unfocused gaze finally centering on him. Every time she did that, he felt on top of the world. There was always something about Jin’s focus. She could be intense at times, and when she turned that attention on him, his brain melted—but in a good way.

“Does it matter?”

“Yes, getting back together matters.”

She shook her head, and he opened his mouth to argue with her, even though he knew he didn’t have the time. She stopped him with one question.

“Does it matter how, or even why?”

The insinuation was that being together was the important bit. Adam shook his head, again opening his mouth to tell her how he felt, but Graeme called out.

“You need to go. We can talk about this when everything is done.”

He didn’t like leaving openings like that. At an early age, he learned that cops didn’t always get to have those conversations if they put them off. But he knew it wasn’t the right time for declarations. At least big ones like ‘please take pity on me and marry me.’

So, he said the one thing he could that he knew would make her understand his feelings.

“You matter to me, *ku’u lei*.”

Her gaze softened, and she rose to her tiptoes to brush her mouth against his. Once, twice…, and then they were interrupted again. Graeme was annoying AF.

“You matter to me, too, Adam.”

Just that one little sentence sent his heart soaring, and while he didn't want to leave, he wanted this over. The faster they figured out what the hell was going on and who was after her, the quicker they could sort themselves out.

"Be safe," she said.

He nodded, then walked out of the kitchen, and for the first time, he knew he had left his heart and part of his soul with her, but Adam knew he would be back for it.

It had been forty-five minutes since Adam left, and Jin was on pins and needles. Every nerve in her body seemed to be electrified. She paced her room, tossing looks at the bed that had been destroyed. She wanted that back. She wanted to go back about two hours and tell him she was in love with him.

But now she couldn't, and there was a worry that he wouldn't return. She would never forgive herself if that happened. Or him. She would be pissed at him if he got hurt.

The wind had picked up, and tree branches scratched against her window. It added to her irritation. Nothing seemed to be going right. They should have stayed up in this room and never come out.

Sure, Jin. That's realistic.

She rolled her eyes and sat down on the end of the bed. It had taken years to recover, but now that she had found her way back to Adam, she wanted more. She wasn't sure what it was, but she knew it was more than just lovers.

Truthfully, she didn't know what he wanted. Right now, she had her shit together, but she still had bad days. She would fall into those dark memories of her abduction and torture. They didn't happen that often now, but they still appeared out of nowhere. Triggers could be a scent, a song, or even some idiot on H-1 who might think he could tailgate her to get her to move faster.

Not everyone would want to deal with that. It was a lot. *She* was a lot. But she was okay with that, and she accepted who she was. It took her years of rehabilitation to realize that her problems had gone deeper than just what

happened to her a few years ago. A family who never accepted her, parents who hated each other, and when they divorced, they acted as if she were a problem—an outsider to their new lives.

Their lacking as parents was not about her. And thankfully, she believed that most of the time. Still, her issues would probably always be with her. Her PTSD was managed but not completely gone.

There was a scratch at the window again, and she frowned. This one sounded louder. She knew no one could get close to them without the FBI and HPD noticing, but it bothered her.

When she pushed the curtain aside, she swallowed a scream at the face staring back at her. A woman was sitting on a massive tree branch. She opened the window.

“I thought you would never catch on,” she said as she slipped through the opening. Jin knew that voice. She had never seen Sam up close, but her voice…she knew that well.

“Sam?”

She nodded and smiled, although it looked a little tired around the edges. Jin took her in, this woman she thought was her friend. Dark red hair was tied in a messy bun on her head. She wore a T-shirt and jeans that looked too big for her. There was a bruise on her face, and she had dark circles under her eyes, which were two different colors. One was more hazel, while the other was greener.

“I finally got a vacay to Hawai’i and didn’t even have to pay for it.”

Yeah, she was definitely Sam. “How did you get here?”

“Remember that asshole down the street?”

She nodded.

“Well, he *was* watching me. They abducted me, then brought me here. Why, I have no idea. I know what they wanted, but bringing me was a mistake. Who the hell flies someone on a private plane to Hawai'i? I guess they didn’t know about my life before.”

When Jin said nothing, Sam nodded. “I expected you would find out with that former DEA in on the case. Anyway, we need to go.”

Jin shook her head.

“What? Don’t you want to see this through?”

“I’m safe here.”

“No, you aren’t. This runs deep, and you can bet Hank has people in HPD and the FBI on his payroll. How do you think they found me?”

“I thought I led them to you.”

“In a way, but not actually finding me. I figured Hank paid top dollar to some jerk I knew a lifetime ago.”

Something clicked. “You’re not talking about Ian, are you?”

She rolled her eyes. “No. Mr. MI-6 is straight as an arrow. Or as good as you can be when you’re a spy. We can discuss this later after I get you to safety.”

Jin crossed her arms, and Sam frowned.

“I never knew you would be difficult about this.”

Before she could say anything to that, Sam stepped forward and pricked her with a needle. Everything around her seemed to go hazy. “I just need you hidden so they can’t use you against TFH.”

Her world turned upside down, and she realized Sam had picked her up fireman style. “Oof, you’re solid for such a tiny thing.”

She wanted to tell her to get bent, but she couldn’t form the words as her world darkened and faded completely black.

When they arrived at Brewer’s home, Adam knew something was off. Rich people always seemed to have some kind of lights on, showing their house off to anyone who might be driving by. It was a tool that many burglars loved, especially since so many people didn’t live there full-time. It made their houses easy targets.

Tonight, Brewer’s entire house was dark. Even the security lights didn’t come on as they approached. And from Marcus, they knew that the security system was down.

Dressed in night gear, they kept to the natural shadows. Even though the exterior lights were off, there was a full moon. It lit up the yard, so they all kept to the sides of the house the best they could.

They all had night vision goggles, and Tamilya was checking for heat signatures.

“There’s no movement inside, well…he’s sitting in the living room by himself,” she said over their comms.

“No security?” Marcus asked.

“No.”

“Let’s still go in undercover,” Adam said. “I don’t want to risk any of us getting hit.”

It took another five minutes to clear the front door, which was left unlocked. From what they could see with their night vision, the place was a mess. There had been a fight, that’s for sure. Glass crunched under their feet.

“He’s on the couch,” Tamilya said over comms.

They all walked to the area and found him. Marcus leaned over and felt for a pulse. He shook his head.

“Let’s clear the house,” Adam ordered.

While it was a multimillion-dollar mansion, it wasn’t that big. It took them a few minutes to go through each room and the closets to make sure there wasn’t some surprise waiting for them. Within ten minutes, with the entire house cleared, they called in the death.

“Take off the night vision, folks. And let’s check this place out.”

They all did as he instructed, and someone hit the lights. There had indeed been some kind of struggle. There was a gun in Brewer’s hand, but what dumbass left a place looking like this when they wanted to make it look like a suicide? They definitely weren’t smart.

“These guys are dumbasses,” Marcus muttered, voicing Adam’s thoughts.

Seth Harrington made a noise. He had come along for the ride since he would start as head of Team Bravo next month.

“This almost feels like something Russians would do, right? Like, all those oligarchs who die of heart attacks on the way out of a fifth-floor window?” Harrington asked.

There were nods all around as they carefully looked around. It was their scene, but with Charity tied up at the safe house, HPD gave them a hand tonight.

“This just doesn’t make sense,” Tamilya said, joining them.

“It does if he was a loose end,” Adam said.

“But for whom?” Tamilya rolled her shoulders. “I mean, there are a lot of moving parts, but why would they kill him right now.”

“It has to do with his son being found,” Adam said, connecting the dots. “Why was he paying Hank Andrews all these years?”

Before he could make out what it all meant, there was a call from Charity.

“What have you got?”

“Nothing, but we have a problem.”

The tone in her voice sent a shiver of panic racing through him.

“What?”

But he knew, even before she said anything. Before she said the words, his heart sank.

“Jin’s missing.”

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Fourteen

By the time they met at TFH headquarters, Adam was coming out of his skin. The idea that Jin had been abducted again set his whole world into chaos. Whoever had the nerve to abduct her would be missing limbs by the time he got done with them.

Del was there with a baby on his shoulder and a little girl running around. His wife was on her computer. Autumn looked up at him. Sadness and regret filled her entire expression.

"I'm sorry."

He wanted to rage at her but knew it would do no good. Not with Jin missing and every second counting. "No. I should have left more people, and I shouldn't have trusted people outside of TFH. We have a new team training. I should have called them in. And let's face it. She was pulled out of there by someone who could thwart all of the protections we had."

And that's what was scaring the fuck out of him. It was the same feeling he had when those monsters had her before, but this time…he knew who his enemy was. It still didn't make it any easier to deal with.

"Still, I should have made sure that she was downstairs."

"She was in her room?"

She nodded.

"Which means they went through the window." He blew out a breath, trying to calm his nerves. Del patted him on the back.

"We'll get her back."

Yeah, but what would this do to her PTSD? And how hard will she have to fight to regain her life? He refused to lose her again. He would make sure to stand by her side through it all.

“I think I have a hit. These smarmy bastards,” Emma, the boss’ wife, said. A diminutive woman, he knew her mother had been Thai and her father English. She was a genius who was paid millions to test out games, talk to others about game theory in general, and even consulted with the CIA on a few things. She contracted with TFH. Although, he was pretty sure she was here as a favor to him, and he would have to thank her later. Right now, all he cared about was getting Jin back.

“What are schmarmy bastards, Mommy?” Her four-year-old asked. Del rolled his eyes. Their daughter was every bit of the genius her mom was.

“Bad guys we are going to catch.”

“Good. Bad guys should rot.”

The smiles shared around the room had Del rolling his eyes again. Those two had to give him headaches.

“Yeah, they went to this house up in Kailua. What is it with these idiots? Don’t they know to hide out? If it were me, I would have hidden in an obscure house.”

Which is just what she was doing when Del and she met. He’d gone to seek her out as a favor to her brother, and she had hit Del in the face with a two-by-four.

“Okay, I think we need to go.” Adam wasn’t waiting for the go-ahead.

“Hey,” Del said. “I’ll go.”

“No,” Adam said. “My op and you need to get on the horn and find out who let those idiots near the house.”

Understanding lit in Del’s eyes. They had a rat somewhere in HPD or the FBI. He and Emma could probably figure it out pretty quick. He nodded.

As they headed out the door, he came to a halt at the site before him. The newest TFH team, Team Bravo, was walking in the door. Right now, they were a four-member team.

Ryan Morrison was a former cop from LA. He was lean like a swimmer with artfully messy blond hair and blue eyes. He always reminded Adam of a volleyball player. He was usually accompanied by his search and rescue dog, Maya, but she wasn’t with him for this job.

Next to him stood Nikki Kekoa, a local woman who did a stint in the Coast Guard. She was short and athletic, with short black hair and dark brown eyes.

Robbie Ramirez was a military brat who spent years in the military himself. Another SEAL for that team. He was of average height with dark hair he kept cropped like he was still in the military and hazel eyes that seemed to hold a world of bad memories.

The last of the team, Kapone Hanson, better known as Kap. The former NCIS agent was African American. He had short black hair and dark green eyes.

"Thought we might need some backup," Harrington murmured.

Adam glanced at the man and nodded his thanks. He would take all the help he could get.

As he walked out the door to the parking area, Adam sent up one thought. It was the only thing he could think of right now.

Stay safe, Jin. I'm coming, *ku'u lei*.

Jin woke a short time later. She was in a bed, and as she blinked herself awake, she realized she was in some kind of opulent room. Was she in a resort?

She moved her head, then groaned.

"Hey, be careful. Those drugs can make your stomach upset."

Sam.

She looked in the direction of the voice and found Sam sitting at the end of the bed in a chair.

"That wouldn't be a problem if you wouldn't have drugged me."

She sighed. "Sorry. I just…seriously, I never thought you'd argue with me. And I don't trust these bastards."

With care, Jin sat up. Sam offered her a glass of water, and Jin gave it a dirty look. Sam sighed and took a sip.

Jin took it and slowly sipped at the water.

"Why did you do that? You can trust TFH."

"Oh, I know I can. Well, everyone but that Autumn."

"You can trust her. She thinks you are a goddess of some sort."

The snort was loud in the room.

"Where are we?"

"Promise not to yell."

“I didn’t yell when you were abducting me from the safe house.”

“You were going to.”

“I wasn’t. I would have convinced you that you could trust TFH.”

She crossed her arms beneath her breasts and stared at Jin. Jin could see how Sam had made her way through the CIA. Only about 5’4”, she seemed bigger than her actual size. It was the way she held herself, the way she stared down an opponent. Jin could just imagine her against some super evil terrorists.

“Did you work in the field?”

“I’m not doing an interview.”

“I wasn’t…” Jin realized that she was in a way. “Sorry. It’s a habit of mine.”

She shrugged.

“I do have some questions about the investigation.”

Her shoulders relaxed. “Those I will answer.”

“Did you apply for the job because you were hunting someone?”

“No. What I told you was the truth. I’d been listening to your podcast for months. I really admire your ability to weave a story for the reader. Plus, you aren’t someone who exploits the victims.”

Being one. She didn’t say it, but Jin knew Sam understood her reasons.

“Have you discovered anything about this case you haven’t told me?”

She hesitated, then nodded. “I didn’t keep it from you. I just found things out after Hank Andrews had people abduct me.”

“People?”

She settled back in the chair and tossed Jin a look. The haughtiness almost made Jin laugh.

“Do you think someone as stupid as Andrews would get the drop on me by himself?”

Jin snorted. “We figured out he was involved, so I don’t know much about him.”

“He’s not smart. There’s a reason he was always Joseph’s right-hand man. He was a yes man, someone who rarely had an original thought, except when it came to electronics.”

“Then who’s in control of him now?”

“I thought Brewer. There was something between the two of them.”

“What?”

Sam looked pensive. “I think Brewer paid him to cover up the murder of Alana Kim.”

“You think Dylan killed her?”

She nodded. “I haven’t pieced it all together, but I was going to talk to you about it before I was abducted.”

That made sense. “Brewer was paying him a lot of money over the last fifteen years. It was close to half a million dollars a year.”

“Hmm. Do you think he thought his son was alive?”

Jin thought about it. While Brewer had never consented to an interview with her, he did a lot of interviews right after Dylan disappeared. He was adamant that if his son was alive, he would come forward. She had always assumed he was convinced his son was dead. But looking at it now with the evidence altered her theories.

“Yeah. And I think that maybe Brewer was paying Andrew’s money to keep him safe. If he thought he was dead, why would he pay?”

“Do we think all these men are that stupid?”

“Yes.”

Laughing, Jin said, “I’m serious.”

“I know men. Or at least, I know them on paper. Maybe Brewer wasn’t stupid, but he was arrogant.”

“Was?”

She sighed. “Yeah, that’s how I escaped. Brewer and Andrews got into a massive argument. The knuckle draggers he hired for security were more interested in the possible fight than me. They forgot to lock the door to the room where they were holding me. And yes, they took me to Brewer’s mansion. He was unhappy about that, and I don’t blame him.”

“Then how did you escape?”

“Well, since they left the door unlocked, I slipped out. Running at that point was a waste of time. I knew I was in Hawai’i, but I had no idea where I was and had no phone. So, when I heard the shouts, I went up on the roof. They ran around looking for me, and I heard them talking about making it look like a suicide.”

“Are you telling me you climbed up on the roof and those idiots couldn’t find you?”

“I told you Andrews was stupid. He seemed like he was always on something.”

“Like drugs?”

She nodded. “The cult got brought down because of drugs, right?”

“And underage girls being married off as well as illegal weapons.”

Sam made a sound of disgust. “Men.”

“So, what are we supposed to do? Just sit here?”

“No.”

“But?”

“Andrews is looking for you. He had a hard-on for taking you down because people are now asking questions about the murders.”

“I was in a safe house.”

“And I told you not to trust the FBI or the HPD.”

“But I can trust Task Force Hawaii.”

She hesitated, then nodded. “Especially Adam. That man is definitely dedicated to you.”

“What do you mean?”

Sam said nothing for a long time, and Jin slid off the bed and stood in front of her. “Tell me.”

“You know he hasn’t dated since you were abducted, right?”

She blinked. “What?”

“That man has been waiting for you. Like forever. That’s some dedication ‘cause he is definitely hot. You know he had opportunities.”

Her mouth opened and closed twice, and she sat down with a thud. “He never said anything.”

“Men are not into sharing that type of stuff, believe me. Please tell me you are going to put him out of his misery.”

Jin’s face heated. Sam clapped her hands.

“Hot damn, that’s why your bed was a mess when I got you to leave that house.”

“Got me to leave? You abducted me.”

“Still.”

“And you noticed that?”

“I notice a lot of things. Like how you avoid talking about Adam.”

“I’m not avoiding talking about Adam. I need to make sure that we stay on task.” When the other woman said nothing, just stared at her with her two different eyes, Jin gave in. “I would like to have a life with Adam, but I need to see if I’m capable.”

“Of being with someone forever. You think you can’t because of your past?”

Jin nodded.

“Naw, you got this. You’re not broken like the rest of us.” Before Jin could ask more questions, Sam jumped out of her chair and grabbed a computer.

“You know, that house had an amazing setup, right? Charity was working on it.”

She glanced out of the corner of her eye at Jin. “Really?”

“There was a panic room built by the original owner.”

“Damn, I should have stayed so her Fed boyfriend could hand me over to the CIA.”

Jin wanted to say that wouldn’t happen, but she didn’t know TJ that well. “Can I ask what the CIA has on you?”

“It’s what they *think* they have on me that matters to them. Me, I’m just trying not to be killed. I sort of like breathing.”

Before she could say anything, the laptop brought up what looked like surveillance. “What’s that?”

“Cameras around Honolulu and there is TFH headquarters.”

“Is that illegal?”

“Not really.”

Jin sighed but decided that she needed Sam right now.

“Oh, look there.”

She zeroed in on activity. It was Adam leading a contingent of men and women. There were a few she didn’t recognize.

“Who are those people? They aren’t part of TFH,” Sam commented.

“They might be part of the newer team. Team Bravo. They are in training, but I could see that this would be an all-hands-on-deck deal. We need to go in. We need to tell them I’m okay.”

“Hold on.”

For the next few minutes, Jin paced the length of the room. It was definitely at a resort, but she wasn’t sure which one. It felt like the Hilton Hawaiian Village, but she wasn’t sure. And she was sure she could escape but didn’t want to. She wanted Sam’s help because Jin thought they needed the former CIA specialist.

“They’re heading up on Pali,” she said with a relieved sigh. “They found that bastard.”

“Andrews?”

She nodded.

“Can we go into TFH?”

Sam frowned her concentration still on the screen. “We can try it, but we must go incognito.”

Jin rolled her eyes. “They’re ten minutes from here.”

“So, you know where we are?”

“I think we’re at the Hilton.”

“Close. I tapped into Dillon Security and found one of their safe houses.”

For a second, Jin’s brain sputtered. “What?”

“It wasn’t that hard. They need help with their security.”

She said it in a tone that made Jin think she thought she was being reasonable.

“You can’t just do that.”

Sam shut the laptop and tossed a careless smile at Jin. “I think I did. But while their security is sad compared to my skills, I know it won’t take them long to figure out where we’re at. Let’s get changed and get out of here.”

She headed off in the direction of the bedroom. “They have all kinds of cool stuff to wear.”

Jin sighed, then followed her. The faster they got to TFH, the sooner they could tell them what was happening.

Adam’s nerves were strung tight as they moved on the house in Kailua. These idiots living large when they were trying to hide. But he couldn’t get sidetracked by the stupidity of criminals. All that mattered was that Jin would be okay. It was the one thing that he held onto as TFH fanned out around the house.

“There are four bodies inside. They all look like males.”

He bit back his irritation. “Are there any other spaces we can’t see?”

“A wine cellar.”

That wasn’t that common in Hawai’i, but if they couldn’t see in there, they had no idea where Jin was. She could be there. She could be somewhere else. And that pushed him further to the edge. It was like the nightmare was starting all over again.

“Hey, boss,” Tamilya said.

“Yeah?”

“I got a call from TFH. Jin is there and safe with Sam.”

He closed his eyes, trying to center all his thoughts on what needed to be done. Now, he had no worries about Jin’s safety. He took a deep breath, letting the knowledge of her being safe and sound at headquarters filter through his senses. It was almost as if the icy fingers clinging to his heart had loosened their hold.

“Did you hear me?”

“Yeah, I did. Alpha, you go in first, then Bravo will back us up. Morrison, let us know when you can cut the electricity.”

Once he had everyone’s acknowledgment, they made their way into the house.

The first thing he noticed was the stench. God, he hated heroin. It always had this vinegary scent that seemed to permeate the surroundings. Adam took the lead, ready to go after these assholes, but he wanted Andrews alive. They needed answers about Alana and Dylan’s murders.

He held up a fist to hold his team behind him.

“You let her get away,” Andrews was whining. There was an edge to his voice. Fear and probably more than a bit of heroin had Andrews losing control. Good. That way, he wouldn’t make good choices if he ever did. But it could make him dangerous, too.

Adam signaled to Marcus to take the lead. All they were waiting on was Morrison. About ten seconds later, the lights cut out, which had all four of the men in the house freaking the hell out. Next, Marcus moved forward and tossed a couple flash bombs into the room.

“What the fuck!” Andrews screeched.

“Who is after us?” another man screamed.

The way they panicked almost had Adam smiling, but he didn’t want to count his blessings too early. Untrained people tended to get other people hurt when they panicked.

As they moved in formation into the room, Adam kept his gun trained on Andrews. With his night vision, he could see him easily. They overpowered the muscle and had them zip-tied and on the ground within a couple of minutes, but somehow, Andrews was backing away from them.

“Give over, Andrews. You lost,” Adam said. “Sam is at headquarters, and more than likely, our tech is tearing your life apart.”

“I will never give up.”

God, this was stupid. The man wasn't going to survive this. It was then that Adam saw him lift the gun to his own head.

Andrews meant he would never give up to them. He would go out his way, but Adam couldn't let that happen. Rushing him was the only option, so Adam started toward him. Just as Adam jumped over the couch to tackle the other man, the lights blinked back on. Andrews let out a scream as they fell to the floor.

They both grunted as they fell against the hard floor. Adam's head hit the tiles. Pain splintered out from the back of his head. *Fuck, that hurt.* He blinked, trying to regain some control. Andrews landed on top of him, and for some reason, he thought it gave him an advantage. He was so high he probably thought he was a ninja. Still, the bastard had a gun. They fought over the gun, rolling over the floor. Then, in one blinding instant, the gun went off. He felt the burn of the bullet in his shoulder. The metallic scent of blood filled Adam's senses.

"Did anyone get shot?" Tamilya said over comms. He wasn't sure if anyone answered because he was too pissed to even listen to anyone right now.

Angry with the entire situation, he pulled back from Andrews and used his good hand to cold cock the bastard. The gun clattered to the floor as Andrews passed out.

Drawing a deep breath, Adam blinked a few times before standing. He wasn't steady, but he knew he could at least walk.

"Tell me everyone is okay! RIGHT NOW!" Tamilya was screaming in their ears.

"Everyone's fine," he said, swallowing to keep his stomach from revolting on him. "All four are detained."

"Okay. Good. Do you want me to call on HPD again, boss?"

"Yeah. Their techs should take over the scene as we investigate."

"Ten-four."

He blinked, trying to focus on what was going on around him.

"We need an ambulance," Marcus said over comms.

"What? Adam said everyone was fine."

"Everyone is fine. Harrington is here. He has paramedic training," Adam said.

"You were shot. I can clean it, but you need to have a doctor look it over," Harrington said as he eased around Autumn and made his way over

to where Adam stood. “You need to sit down.”

“No. I’m fine.”

Yeah, he was being a petulant little baby.

“I can’t get a good look at your wound.”

They stared at each other for a long moment. As acting commander, Adam could tell him to go to hell, but it would go faster if he did as requested. The moment his ass hit the buttery leather sofa, his vision seemed to blur again.

“Fuck, he’s passing out,” Harrington ground out.

There was a lot of noise surrounding him like people hurrying over. Adam opened his mouth to respond, but his entire world turned to black.

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Fifteen

With her heart in her throat, Jin strode through the ER doors of Tripler Army Medical Center, Sam on her heels. The rest of TFH who had been at headquarters were on her heels.

"Where is he?" she demanded.

"He's in surgery," Seth Harrington said. He walked towards her, blood on his clothes. She didn't know how she knew, but she knew it was Adam's blood. The edges of her vision seemed to dim, and her head spun. He took her by the arms. His touch was gentle.

"Don't worry," he said. "I know the surgeon. Adam lost a little blood, but otherwise, he's good."

She drew in a deep breath and let it loose. Her nerves still didn't calm, but she was steadier. She knew nothing would calm her until she saw him in person.

An arm wrapped around her, and she realized it was Sam. "Come on. Looks like your *o'hana* is over there."

She glanced at the corner where everyone was standing or sitting. They walked over. She noticed that Graeme and Marcus weren't there.

When she asked about them, she was told they were at the scene, overseeing the investigation.

"And Andrews? He was the one in charge?"

Del shrugged. "We aren't sure yet. We need to interrogate him and find out what this was all about. He was pretty whacked out on something—they have no idea what drug. They are sending him to detox. At least a day or two before we can interrogate him."

"I have a feeling he was getting paid to hide Dylan Brewer," Sam said.

Everyone turned and looked at her, suspicion on all their faces.

“What? I said I was sorry. I was trying to keep Jin safe.”

“You still think he lied all these years, and Brewer was that stupid?” Jin asked.

“Rich men are arrogant. They think they know everything, and the truth is, it was easier that Dylan wasn’t around.”

“Why do you say that?” Tamilya asked.

Sam didn’t say anything, but she didn’t have to. Jin knew enough about the story to put most of the pieces together.

“Dylan was a problem child who grew into an angry, entitled man. He felt that he should have whatever he wanted. Women, drugs, fast cars. His mother died of cancer when Dylan was only eight. Because of that, Michael Brewer indulged him. He saved him from jail so many times. But that night, I think something changed. From the moment I took this case, I knew he wasn’t alive anymore, or at least thought he wasn’t. A man like him is so damned full of himself, he could only stay hidden so long.”

“So, you thought he was the one who killed Alana,” Jin said. “Brewer wanted Dylan out of sight and out of mind. So, he paid for it and hoped he never had to see his son again.”

Before anyone could respond, Adam’s mother, Merri, rushed through the door, followed by Makana and Nanii. They hurried over to the group but stopped in front of Jin. His mother pulled her into her arms.

“Have you heard anything?”

Her warm embrace steadied Jin even more. Years ago, Adam told Jin his mother gave the best hugs, and he was right. Jin hugged the woman back before letting her go.

“He’s in surgery. Seth took care of him on the scene.” She motioned toward Seth, who still hadn’t changed. Her gaze took in his clothes, and her spine straightened.

“Is that my son’s blood?”

“Some. I’m sorry.”

“No worries,” she said, letting go of Jin to hug him. “Mahalo for taking care of my boy.”

Jin wrapped an arm around each girl and urged them to sit. She knew they were in for a wait.

It was over ninety minutes later before the surgeon came out. He paused when he realized how many people were waiting.

“I take it that everyone in this area is here for Lt. Commander Lee?”

“Yes,” Jin said, stepping forward. “This is his *o’hana*.”

His gaze moved over all the people there. “Okay. I need his *blood* relatives.”

“I’m his mother,” Merri said. His sisters stepped up behind her. “And this is his fiancé.”

For a second, Jin didn’t register the comment until she realized Merri was talking about her. When she glanced at the woman, Merri winked.

“Well, for the record, he’ll be fine. Thanks to Harrington, his blood loss was minimal, but we had to extract the bullet. It took a little bit, but he’s strong. We also think he has a slight concussion, which, with the slight blood loss, is the reason he passed out. He’s in recovery, but he will get a room in about half an hour if his vitals stay steady. The nurse will come to get you.”

“Mahalo,” his mother said. The surgeon nodded and then left them alone.

Jin stepped closer to Adam’s mother. “Merri, we aren’t engaged.”

“Oh, I know, but they’ll let you up to his room faster if they think you are.”

“What the hell is going on?” Ian said, striding into the ER. Jin blinked and looked around. Sam had excused herself a few minutes ago to go to the bathroom, but she hadn’t returned.

“You’re so loud. There was a firefight, and then Adam was shot, but he will be fine,” Autumn said.

“No. I mean, one of our safe houses was broken into, and the video showed Jin there with another woman.”

Oh, shit. Yeah, Jin had forgotten all about that. So much had happened since then. Sam’s getup was insane, with long dark hair and sunglasses in the dead of night. Jin understood to an extent. With her different colored eyes, she would be memorable. She also made Jin sit in a wheelchair she had procured from somewhere.

“Do you not care about Adam?” Autumn asked.

Jin looked at the other woman. Her tone suggested that she was up to something, and apparently, Ian had fallen for it.

“No. I mean, yes, I do.”

Autumn sniffed. “Doesn’t sound like it.”

Jin knew she had to apologize. “Ian, I’m really sorry. Sam thought I was in trouble, so she took me to one of your safe houses.”

His blue eyes narrowed on Jin. The cold sent icy fingers trailing down her spine. Oh, damn, he was scary. “She was here?”

Jin nodded.

“And she drugged Jin, so don’t start playing spymaster with her,” Autumn said. “She was just here.”

He opened his mouth as Tamilya returned from the bathroom.

“Tamilya, was Sam in the bathroom?”

She shook her head. “I was the only one in there.”

Jin sighed, but Autumn laughed.

“The Barracuda has thwarted you once more.”

Ian tossed her a nasty look, but he didn’t respond to the taunt. “So, Adam is going to be okay?”

Autumn nodded as she took his arm to lead him away.

“Lee family?”

There was a nurse in green scrubs. She watched as Merri and his sisters turned to go, but they all stopped.

“Jin,” his mother said, holding out her hand. Jin only hesitated for a second. When she slipped her hand into the other woman’s, Jin felt everything in her click. TFH was her *o’hana*, and so were the Lees. She might have just met them, but because of Adam, they would accept her.

As they started to follow the nurse back, the doors opened again, and Kailana flew into the room. From everything she had known about the woman, she was unflappable. The look of terror on her face, the panic in her dark eyes, spoke to Jin.

When she saw her mother and sisters, she ran over.

“Is he okay?”

“Yes, he’s fine. He lost a little too much blood, and they had to extract the bullet,” Jin explained. She knew that with Kailana’s background, she would do better with facts first.

“Are you sure?”

She nodded. “They are taking us up to see Adam.”

Within minutes, they were being led back to a room. It was the middle of the night, so it was quiet except for the sound of TVs playing in rooms and the murmured voices from the staff and patients. For a second, she panicked. This is where they brought her after they’d found her beaten and

almost dead. The smell of antiseptic still sent waves of fear crashing through her. She hated it.

Drawing in a deep breath, she used the techniques she'd learned through the last few years to deal with these feelings. She stood still, closed her eyes, and counted down. She had more intricate methods to try if this didn't work, but she felt her nerves calming.

"Jin?"

She opened her eyes. Kailani was observing her.

"I'm fine. I just don't like hospitals."

She nodded, and Jin knew she understood. She stepped closer to Adam's sister.

"Do you mind a hug?" the younger woman asked.

Tears filled her eyes. His family was amazing. "I would love a hug."

Kailani wrapped her arms around Jin. "I'm so happy you two are back together."

More tears filled her eyes and dripped down her cheeks. "Me too."

"Girls," Merri said. "Come on."

Jin stepped back and wiped her cheeks as Kailani did the same. They shared a secret smile with each other. This family. They accepted her at face value. They all showed more empathy than she would ever get from her own family. Adam had no idea just how lucky he was.

Jin planned to hang back to let his mother and sisters—his blood family—deal with the scene. But the moment she stepped into his room, all those thoughts went out the window. She bit back a gasp as she hurried forward. He was sleeping, but he was unbelievably pale. He had a bruise on his gorgeous face. She curled her fingers into her palms. If they hadn't arrested Andrews, she would hunt that bastard down and beat him up.

"From the look on your face, you would happily defend his honor," Merri said with a chuckle. Jin glanced at Adam's mother. "I expected nothing less. Adam comes from a long line of warrior women."

"I'm not a warrior."

Merri shook her head, then her smile faded as she turned her attention to her son. "He's pale."

Jin nodded. His sisters stood on the other side of the bed. Makana and Nanii were silently crying. Without a second thought, she made her way around the bed to them and wrapped an arm around each of them.

"He's going to be fine. You heard the doctor."

“I feel guilty. We’ve been so mean to him,” Makana said.

“I didn’t grow up with siblings, but I think that’s normal. You can apologize when he wakes up. He loves his house of women, I promise.”

“He does? I always thought we drove him pupule.” *Crazy*.

“You do, but he loves all of you. I knew each of you so well because he always talked about you. He’s proud of all of you.”

The girls nodded.

“Why don’t you girls get something to drink from the vending machine down the hall?” Merri suggested.

Kailani took over and herded the girls out of the room, leaving Merri and Jin alone.

“You’re very good with them. You don’t have any siblings?”

Jin sighed, not wanting to think about her family. “I have some half-siblings back on the mainland. When my parents divorced, I was in my junior year of high school. I was sent away to an all-girls school, and they went on with their lives.”

There was a beat of silence. Jin was always embarrassed about her family, especially compared to Adam’s.

“Being a cop’s wife isn’t the easiest job on the planet.”

Jin turned to look at Merri. “We haven’t talked of marriage.”

Merri shrugged. “I know my son. He adores you. I just wanted you to know that it isn’t for the faint-hearted. Also, I know you are up for the job.”

She knew Merri spoke from experience. She’d lost her husband to the job.

“I would love to think I am.” She drew in a breath. Vulnerability was something she hid from most people. She hated being seen as less than and, yes, she knew it had to do with her childhood.

Releasing the breath, she said, “I had a moment in the hall.”

Merri cocked her head. “A moment?”

“The sounds and the smell of antiseptic…it always takes me back.”

“Ah. Yes. I could see that. Scent is just one of those things that draws you back. The first time I met Adam’s father, he had been drinking beer. Not drunk because that man didn’t ever get drunk. But anytime I smell beer, I think of him. It makes me happy and sad at the same time. It’s strange, but we can’t control our first responses to stimuli. It’s how you deal with those memories that’s important.” She looked at her son. “But this man, he’s like his father. He’s in it for the long haul.”

“That was a small reaction. Sometimes…” She shook her head. “It’s just bad.”

Understanding filled Merri’s expression. “He’ll understand.”

Jin nodded because she knew that Merri was right. Her son would understand, and for the first time since her abduction, she was ready to trust someone. Jin wanted to let him see the ugly that came from her experience.

Merri came around the bed and pulled a chair closer. “Here, you sit. He’ll want to see you when he wakes up.

“Thank you. For everything.”

“Anytime, Jin. Whether you like it or not, you’re *o’hana* now.”

She looked Adam’s mother in the eye. “I like it very much.”

The smile she gave Jin warmed her heart. With a sigh, she sat in the chair and took Adam’s hand in hers to wait.

Adam came awake slowly. He knew he was in a hospital room of some sort, probably Tripler, as they were the closest to where they had been when he was shot. He’d come awake briefly in the ambulance, but it was all hazy.

His eyes were closed, but he took in his surroundings with his other senses. Drawing in a deep breath, he smelled the antiseptic. Machines beeped. Someone held his hand.

With considerable effort, he opened his eyes, looking around. His mother was sitting by a window, looking out on the night. He knew his sisters were somewhere around because he had registered their voices a little while ago.

His mother must have sensed that he was awake. She glanced over at him with a smile. Then, her attention went to the person holding his hand. He looked and found Jin, her hand in his, her head resting on the mattress.

God, she was beautiful, his angel. He would never understand what she saw in him, but he couldn’t voice that opinion out loud. Her soft hand felt like a lifeline, the one thing he needed to get him through all the bad days.

There was a noise in the hallway, and his mother stood shaking her head. With another smile, she went out in the hallway, leaving him alone with Jin.

The door shutting seemed to break through to Jin, who stirred. Blinking awake, she took a second to rouse herself to look at him. When their gazes met, her mouth curved, but tears filled her eyes.

“Hey, I’m okay.”

She stood and finally let his hand go to hug him. “I was so worried. I know they told me you were safe, but I wouldn’t believe it until you woke up. And it’s my fault.”

“No. It’s no one’s fault except Andrews. That bastard was so freaking high he thought taking on a highly trained team of enforcement officers was the way to go. This is part of the job. Plus, I would rather be the person taking him down. He would have hurt more civilians if we hadn’t.”

“But I’m the one who started digging into this. If I hadn’t, you would be okay.”

“And no one would have known about all of this. Alana’s family will finally know what happened to her. That’s a good thing. It also brought us back together.”

“That’s the best thing. So you got to talk to Andrews?”

“In a way. I guess everyone told you he was high as a kite?”

She nodded.

“Hopefully, we can get something out of him. I can’t believe Andrews hid all these years.”

She sniffed as she stood up. “Wait until you find out how Sam escaped.”

He frowned because he did not want to talk to the woman. She had kidnapped Jin.

“Don’t look like that. Sam was worried that I wasn’t protected once you left the house. She trusts you.”

There was a murmur of voices in the hallway as she settled on his bed. “Everyone is still here. They’re driving the staff crazy, and a lot of the female staff keeps finding reasons to wander by.”

He chuckled, then winced. His head was still killing him.

“You have a slight concussion. That’s why you passed out. I have something to tell you.”

Dammit, from the serious look on her face, it couldn’t be good.

“I had a moment in the hall when I smelled the antiseptic, and I think that if we are going to make this work, I need to come clean with you.”

“Okay.”

“I have nightmares sometimes. I also still have issues with agoraphobia. It isn’t as bad as before, but…I have bad days.”

She sounded as if she were confessing some great crime. He wouldn’t make light of it. Her PTSD was something she would have to deal with her entire life.

He took her hand in his and pulled it up to press his mouth against her knuckles. “I know. And I’m here for them. I want all the good, the bad, and everything in between. You have more issues than some people, but it doesn’t make me love you any less, *ku’u lei*.”

Again, tears filled her eyes.

“Don’t cry.”

“Tears of happiness. I promise.” She took a deep breath. “I love you.”

Adam’s heart turned over in his chest. “I love you, *ku’u lei*.”

She leaned down carefully and brushed her mouth over his. He was ready to deepen the kiss, but the door burst open.

“Oh, God, my virgin eyes!” Makana said.

Jin pulled back from him, but she was smiling.

“*Akamu*,” Nanii said, running toward his bed. She was followed by Kailani and what appeared to be the entire TFH team—including Bravo.

“They’ve been waiting to see you,” Jin whispered only loud enough for Adam to hear.

He had his blood *o’hana* and his extended *o’hana*. The best thing was the woman sitting beside his bed, holding his hand, and wiping away tears of happiness. She was safe and sound, and that was all that mattered. Worries about what had happened could wait.

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Sixteen

Hank Andrews walked around the prison yard, trying his best to take in the one thirty-minute break he would get today. The air was sweet—but he was in Hawai'i, so that was a given.

From the moment he'd recovered from his wounds, they'd kept him out of the general population. He had no idea why. The one man who wanted to kill him—or at least, the one he thought might want to kill him since he failed at his mission—didn't have ties to this prison. He frowned. At least, he didn't think so.

Ever since the death of Alana, things had been fucked. He should have just taken what money he had and disappeared, but no. He had to believe that asshole. Also, Michael Brewer had been such a dumbass. Giving them half a million a year with no proof of life? Stupid. It was why Hank had always thought Brewer knew his son had been dead. He didn't want to deal with it or the monster he had raised. Or, Hank thought, *hadn't* raised. Kids needed a firm hand, and leaving the raising to strangers was never a good idea.

He heard steps behind him and knew his time was ending. Back in the dark hole. He sighed. He told his attorney that he would deal with TFH if they could get him a deal with Witness Protection.

"Five more minutes, guys, please."

He expected them to agree. Most of the guards here were decent, but he didn't get an answer. Instead, a hand clamped onto his shoulder, and he knew who it was. The one person he feared more than anything else in the world. His breath was hot against Hank's ear as he leaned into him.

“You should have never told them you would talk. Joseph sends his regards.”

Hank closed his eyes and waited. He expected pain, but he didn’t get it. Not right away. Instead, gloved fingers slipped over his flesh. A tingle over his skin hit first, followed by a rage of fires. He was convinced he could hear his skin sizzling.

His stomach roiled, and it felt like spiders crawled over his skin. He fell to the hard ground as his throat filled with frothy phlegm. His eyes rolled back into his head, his brain stuck on one thought…on a meeting. That meeting had led him down that dirty path, but he knew, in that one moment, he had no one to blame but himself.

Adam stared out the window and tried to concentrate on something… anything. He wasn’t good at sitting around, and he’d been stuck here for long enough. He wanted updates on the case, and he wanted to go home.

Granted, it had been less than seventy-two hours since he’d been shot, but he was fine. He’d walked since that first day, and seriously, he was ready to tear the face off the next person who told him he needed to rest.

Jin had left earlier today to go home for a shower and a change of clothes. He wondered when she would return. She had done the same thing yesterday, but Tripler had been excellent about letting his “fiancé” stay with him.

He didn’t tell her, but he liked the sound of that. He was pretty sure she would freak the fuck out, but every time he heard someone call her that, his heart did a little dance. He had to keep reminding himself to take it slowly.

The door swung open, his heart jumping at the idea that it could be Jin. Excitement fizzled the moment he saw Del. His boss chuckled.

“Damn, nothing like being a disappointment.”

“Sorry. I thought the doctors were going to let me out.”

“First, that’s not even a good lie. Second, I’d let you out in a second because you’re like me. Sitting around isn’t good for us.”

He threw his arms up, then winced at the pain in his shoulder. “Right? I thought they always wanted to immediately kick people out of the hospital.”

Del nodded and took the seat beside Adam's bed. "First, you're in Tripler. Military hospitals are different. Second, your sister has been all up in your business."

He frowned. "Kailani?"

Del nodded, and that confused Adam. "She's my most levelheaded sister."

"Yeah, well, she knows what went on during your surgery, so maybe that's why she freaked. Also, there was talk that you would go home tomorrow since she had a few days off."

Adam made a face. His sisters and mother were going to drive him bonkers. He just knew it. He loved them, but he didn't need them hovering. His sisters tended to ignore him, but they treated him like a baby whenever they visited.

Del laughed, then he sobered. "So, the case. Ready to talk about it?"

"Yeah. I heard Andrews was ready to cut a deal?"

Del frowned. "We have a problem with that."

"Don't tell me they won't deal. Andrews killed a billionaire. An asshole, but I thought rich men garnered more attention."

Del sighed, the sound of it heavy with regret. "Andrews is dead."

Adam blinked. "Suicide?"

Del shook his head. "Poisoned."

"Fuck."

"Yeah, it's a problem. They're investigating, but it's going to be hard. There were a lot of people who wanted him dead. From locals who see him as part of the reason Alana Kim is dead to Russians."

"Russians?"

"Yeah, he owed a few oligarchs some money."

Adam rolled his eyes. "How did they get away with all that crap when they seem so stupid?"

"Not seem, bra. They're dumb as shit, or the drugs made them that way. They're still trying to figure out what drugs they were on."

"Smelled like heroin to me."

Del nodded. "It's some kind of designer drug. There were things added to it. The lab is still trying to figure it out."

Adam sighed. "We'll never know exactly what went on."

"Oh, we do. Charity found a whole report written up in the search of Andrews' digital files. Like I said, dumb as shit. Dylan did kill Alana, so to

save Joseph trouble, he ordered Andrews to have him killed.”

“And the idiot wrote it down?”

“Well, typed it. I guess when you’re the right-hand man of a vicious cult leader, you think that there might be a day when he turns on you.”

Adam shook his head. “Insane to live like that.”

Del nodded. “Hank ordered Reynolds to kill Dylan.”

“And we think he killed Reynolds?”

“He did, or the person who killed Andrews did. And I’m sure you’ll appreciate that Autumn is handling the paperwork on this one. She still feels guilty about Jin being abducted.”

He had yet to meet Sam. She’d apparently made herself scarce just before Ian had appeared, but something told him Jin knew where she was.

“Damn, I will have to owe her. I don’t blame her at all.” Paperwork was every cop’s hated necessity. This one would be a headache.

“You are not allowed back to work until the first of the month.”

He blinked. “That’s in two weeks.”

“The doctors wanted you to take six weeks off. I convinced them you could return to work, desk duty only. Also, you’ll have all that PT.”

Yeah, his shoulder would need work. He already knew that.

“At least, that’s something.”

“Just so you know, you’re all over the news here.”

“Yeah. Mom said the calls had gotten really bad.”

He nodded. “I tried to get her to move to a safe house for a few days, but apparently, a bunch of your aunties are out in full force. She said she didn’t need a safe house.”

Adam chuckled. “Yeah, they’ll definitely keep an eye on Mom.”

The door opened, and it was Jin. His heart jumped at the sight of her. The fact that she was safe and that nothing had happened to her at all made everything worth it. He could have gone to a very dark place if she had been traumatized again. He still wanted to have a long chat with Sam, but she had disappeared. Jin claimed she didn’t know where the woman was.

She wore a red blouse that brought out the gold in her eyes and a pair of skinny jeans. Damn, she was pretty.

“Hey, Del,” she said as she walked around his bed. Her gaze settled on Adam. “What would you say about getting out of here?”

“Yes.”

She chuckled. “You didn’t hear the caveats. You have to have someone take care of you.”

“Yes.”

“And you have to rest.”

“Yes.”

“I guess you’ve made up your mind then? I’ll go tell your doctor.”

She didn’t touch him. She had held his hand, but other than that hug when he woke, she had kept her distance.

“Wait, did you know about Andrews?”

She nodded. “I just got a text from Elle. I’ll be right back.”

As soon as she left, Adam looked over at Del.

“Give her a little bit of time.”

Frustration left him almost breathless. He had protected her and solved the case, but it felt like he was still at fault for losing Jin.

“Listen, I can see the look in your eyes, and you want to scream at the situation. But you didn’t see how freaked out Jin was when we got the call. It almost pushed her over the edge. Believe me, that woman cares. You know how tough this life is on our families. Just make sure you give her time.”

He would do anything to keep her in his life. He would wait forever, but he would do it by her side.

Jin parked her car and looked over at Adam. His color was good, but there were dark circles beneath his eyes. She knew that getting deep sleep in a hospital is sometimes impossible. It was why she had fought to get him released. If she had not gotten him to agree to rest for the next couple of weeks, she was sure they would have kept him at Tripler longer.

She picked up her phone to text his mother that they had arrived at her house. Adam had assumed he was going to his mother’s house for rest, but she knew what that place was like. She had been there only once, but the activity left her dizzy. While she knew his sisters loved him, they had lives too. The comings and goings might wear him out.

She smiled at the response and at the woman there to help her.

Sam was getting ready to return to hiding, but she had been hanging out at Jin's. Elle had texted Jin about Andrews' murder, but she had already known about it. Sam had gotten notice of his poisoning about an hour before Elle had texted. Apparently, it was all over the Dark Web.

"Hey, Adam."

His eyes flickered. He was smiling before his gaze connected with hers. "Hey, yourself."

"Ready to go in?"

He nodded, then looked around. "This isn't my house."

"I told your mother that I would take care of you."

"And she let you?"

"Yes." When Jin told her she was taking Adam to her house, Merri practically clapped.

With careful movements, she undid his seatbelt. His door opened, and he squinted at Sam.

"Sam?"

"At your service. Well, Jin's. I told her I would help get you settled, then be on my way."

"Is that a fact?" His voice was measured. Jin knew he was still pissed that Sam had abducted her, but it was hard to care. She hurried to his side and slipped his hand arm over her shoulder.

"I can walk by myself."

She sighed. "I know you can, but if you fall, then it's back into the hospital for you. I have a feeling you wouldn't like that."

He grumbled but allowed her to help him into the house. Sam followed them, ready to back her up if needed.

Once Jin got him into bed, she sighed. Everything inside of her seemed to settle. He was here and safe from all the bad guys. He looked even more tired now, and she wondered if she had pushed to get him out of the hospital too soon. She moved to leave him, and he encircled her wrist with his fingers.

"Where are you going?

"I need to lock up, then I'll be right back."

He sighed but nodded. His breathing had evened out before Jin reached the doorway, telling her Adam was already resting easier than he had in the hospital.

"I take it he's okay?" Sam asked as she slipped on her backpack.

Jin nodded. “You don’t have to go.”

“I do. Mr. MI-6 will find me, and on top of that, I have people who want me dead.”

“Better to stay here and be safe.”

She offered Jin a sad smile. “I could bring bad things to your doorstep, and I won’t do that.”

Another person showing her compassion and protecting her. “I hate to think you’ll be out on your own.”

The other woman shrugged. The action almost made Jin cry. When they were at TFH, she might have been surrounded by team members, but Sam seemed so solitary as if she were not part of this world.

“I’m used to it.”

That made her even sadder. She wanted to insist that Sam stay with her and that TFH would keep her safe. Sam’s expression told Jin she would never agree to it.

“Keep in contact.”

Sam cocked her head. “Are you firing me?”

“Absolutely not.”

“Good. I’ll contact you when I find a place to land.”

Sam hesitated, then stepped forward and wrapped her arms around Jin. Then she pulled away and left Jin. It happened so fast that Jin thought she might have imagined it.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket. She pulled it out.

Sam: *Stay safe, or I’ll blame your hunky cop.*

Jin: *You stay safe, too.*

With a smile, she walked back to the bedroom. Adam was sleeping soundly, so she got undressed, pulled on a sleep shirt, and slipped into bed beside him.

“You know, we’re going to have to have a talk about Sam.”

“Shut it, Lee, and get some rest.”

He chuckled as he pulled her against him. Content and finally at peace, she drifted off into sleep.

She woke some hours later with his hands on her. She knew those callused fingers. They were easing down her panties. He was behind her, his breath on her ear, the feel of his muscular chest against her back.

“Shouldn’t you rest? I thought Dr. Faulks said you shouldn’t do anything strenuous.”

“Hmm,” was all he said. Sleep deepened his voice, sending a rush of shivers over her flesh and across her nerve endings.

“Adam, I don’t want you to hurt yourself.”

“Don’t worry, *ku’u lei*. I’ll go slow.” He teased her earlobe.

Once he tossed her panties somewhere, he slid his fingers to her sex, teasing her.

“Hmm, already soaking wet. What a naughty woman. Is this all for me?”

God. “Always,” she moaned.

He slipped two fingers inside of her, pressing a thumb against her clit. She jerked, the intensity leaving her breathless. He had hardly touched her, and she was ready to come.

Before she could come, though, he removed his fingers.

“Roll forward,” he said, positioning one leg up so he could enter her from behind. He eased in, but once he was inside of her, he started to thrust. Her eyes crossed at the deep penetration, thanks to their position.

“Touch yourself.”

She didn’t hesitate. Deeper and deeper, he thrust, the bed smacked hard against the wall. Soon, she was coming, her entire body convulsing as pleasure rolled through her.

“Yeah, like that,” he said. Soon, he groaned her name and poured himself inside of her.

He collapsed a few moments later on the bed beside her. She looked over her shoulder at him. They were both breathing heavily.

“I don’t think that’s taking it easy,” she said.

He looked at her. “If you had any idea what I wanted to do to you, you would think it was taking it easy.”

She smiled, then it faded when she looked at his bandage.

“Hey,” he said, waiting for her to look at him, then urged her to turn to face him. “I’m okay.”

“Sam said you didn’t date much these last few years.”

He was quiet as he studied her. “Yeah, well, every time I tried to date, I was thinking of you. I didn’t think it was fair to the other women or you.”

A lump rose in her throat. “Adam, you didn’t have to wait.”

“No. I didn’t. But I wanted to. Believe me, there were many times I wanted to give up, but I couldn’t.” He took her hand and laid it on his chest above his heart. She could feel it beating. “You’ve owned me since I first heard you laugh. I do not regret waiting. I’ll admit I was angry too.”

“Angry?”

“You made me feel vulnerable when you were abducted. I…I didn’t like that.”

She knew he wasn’t talking about when Sam took her. This was about what happened to her before.

“I’m sorry.”

He shook his head. “No. It isn’t either of our faults. While lying around in bed doing nothing, I had a lot of time to think. I was angry with myself, which morphed into being mad at you, too. Once I accepted that things were out of our hands, I could let it go.”

“Really?” Her tone was definitely skeptical. Adam was a proud man, a protector.

He nodded. “I will still have moments, just like you, but letting that go tells me I completely trust you.”

“I trust you too.”

The smile he gave her sent her heart soaring. She didn’t deserve this man, but she would hold onto him as tight as possible.

“And now I’m famished. How about we order something to eat in bed?” he asked.

It sounded decadent and the perfect ending to the day.

“That sounds wonderful.”

She grabbed her phone, and they snuggled in together to decide about dinner. It was simple, easy, and perfect. This man would always be there for her, and she could now say she would be there for him. Together, they complimented each other, and she knew that he would wait until she was ready for more. He had been waiting for years.

A woman couldn’t ask for more than that.

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Epilogue

A month later, Adam was still kind of pissy about things. He knew paperwork and being behind the desk were essential parts of the job—especially as he prepared to take over Team Alpha. There was only so much Adam could take, though. To add insult to injury, his doctor said he couldn't drive. He told Adam he could drive, but he might not be covered by insurance if he were in a wreck. Jin had jumped in and offered to drive him back and forth to work. At least there was a good chance he would get cleared on Monday.

"I don't understand why I can't drive."

"You go in on Monday. I'm sure you'll get the all clear."

He grumbled but said nothing.

"You act like you don't like spending all this time with me."

"And you act like you have nothing else better to do."

"I don't," she said, amusement dancing through her words.

He frowned and looked out the window. Jin had just taken the exit off H-1, heading toward her house. It was Friday, so fighting their way through traffic had taken forever. He had tried to get someone else to take him home to give Jin a break, but everyone had been busy.

"You're going to have to get used to letting someone help you."

He frowned harder and said nothing. Jin said nothing as she navigated through the neighborhood. He realized just how whiney he sounded. On top of everything, Adam had practically moved in with Jin. So, Adam guessed that was at least worth all the coddling he'd dealt with.

"Sorry."

She laughed. “No, you aren’t, but that’s okay. You have a right to be in a bad mood. But just…be nice to everyone.”

“What do you mean?”

As she turned onto her street, he realized there were more cars than usual.

“Is someone having a party tonight?”

“Yeah, someone is.”

That’s when he saw his mother’s car.

“What did you do?”

“I did nothing,” she said with a smile as she pulled her car into the driveway next to his mother’s sedan.

“Then…”

She turned her car off. “Listen, these people wanted to celebrate you being alive, and believe me, it’s better than the community center.”

“What?”

“Yes. I saved you from a massive celebration with all your mother’s neighbors.”

“All?”

She nodded. “And, of course, all your Aunties.”

“Thank you.”

She smiled. “Now, be nice to your mother. She has allowed me to be the caregiver, and I have a feeling it was tough for her to do.”

“Okay, but part of this is for you.”

She shook her head, and he didn’t argue, but he knew it was true. She planned on outing herself next month on her podcast. There were already so many stories surrounding the podcast since the news had broken about who killed Alana Kim, so she’d decided to be proactive. He slipped out of the car, and they walked around the side of her house. He could hear the party before they stepped into the backyard.

Hand in hand, they walked through the crowd. Everyone from TFH was there, including the new Team Bravo. They intermingled with his mother and sisters and a few aunties. He could just imagine there would be a lot of complaints about who was and wasn’t invited, but he’d let his mother deal with that.

“I have to double-check on the drinks. I’ll be right back,” Jin said, kissing his cheek.

“I can do that.”

She smiled and shook her head. “It’s your party. This is the first time I’ve had so many people at my house. Let me play hostess, and next time, you can be the main host.”

Adam liked the sound of that. She gave him another kiss, then hurried off to check things. He watched her until she disappeared into the house.

“You look happy,” Tamilya said, stepping up beside him.

“Yeah, it looks good on you,” Cat said, sliding in on the opposite side.

“Are you two ganging up on me?”

Tamilya smiled and shook her head.

“No. We’re just here to tell you that although you’re our boss, we pick her if you screw this up,” Cat said, a lethal smile curving her lips.

Adam cocked his head. “No love for *o’hana*?”

“She’s *o’hana* now, and if something goes wrong, we have to assume it’s you. Seriously, you have been a whiny bitch,” Tamilya said.

“Are we talking about the CIA again?” Autumn said, sipping a beer. Jesus, they were ganging up on him.

“No, Adam,” Cat said.

“Oh, yeah, ever since you got back in the office. I mean, seriously, I never expected you to be a big baby about being injured?” She glanced around. “Do we know how much longer before we eat?”

“Didn’t you pop over to L and L Drive-In on the way here?” Tamilya asked.

“That was my afternoon snack. Anyway, I’m with the girls. We’ll take you down if you hurt Jin.”

“Adam,” Del called out. Thankful for the save, he smiled at the women.

“When the boss calls…”

“Wimp,” Cat called out with a laugh, but he didn’t take a chance. He hurried over to where Del was standing.

“Thanks,” he said.

“Yeah, I thought you might need an assist. I saw my wife doing a sneak attack from behind. You would have never survived that.”

“Are you allowed to drink yet?” TJ asked. Adam nodded and accepted the beer.

“I can’t believe I didn’t know this was happening.”

“Well, you have been kind of all up in your feels,” Graeme said with a chuckle.

“Get bent,” Adam said with little heat. He took a long sip of his Longboard Ale, enjoying the malty taste of it. It had been a long few weeks. He was just glad that everything seemed to be on an even keel. They had a lot of paperwork for this case, and while not everyone was satisfied with the ending, the public was. The murderer of Alana Kim wasn’t alive anymore. Granted, her family had wanted a trial, but they all seemed to feel as if they had closure. Or at least as much closure as possible.

“Everything is about done,” Del said. “You better do something nice for Jin. She worked her tail end off to get this done for you.”

“There’s my boy!” His mother wound her arms around him like she hadn’t seen him in years. He had said hello when he arrived, and they had been at his mother’s house for dinner last night.

“I can’t believe you didn’t tell me,” he said.

She smiled up at him. “Don’t mess this up. I think your sisters might throw you over for your woman.”

He laughed because he wasn’t so sure his mother was wrong. Soon, they were all munching down. He sat between his mother and Jin as children ran through the yard, and Dumfries, Graeme and Elle’s dog, chased them. It was one of those nights that seemed almost too magical.

“What are you thinking?”

He turned to look at Jin. He should have known from the moment he met her, and maybe he did, that she was the one for him. There had never been a woman who would be perfectly put together. Her heart, body, soul… every bit of her resonated with him.

“What?” This time, her tone had turned worried.

“I love you.”

Her eyes softened. “I love you too.”

The words never failed to make his heart explode with happiness. This was the perfect night, and he wouldn’t let anything disturb it.

“Hey, Adam Jin, thanks for the invite, but I have to get going,” Autumn said. He glanced behind him. He was surprised she was even still there. She always showed up to their gatherings, but she tended to disappear once they were done eating.

“Thanks for coming, Autumn. Call me when you’re ready to chat.”

“Will do.”

She slipped away, almost as if she had never been there.

“She stayed longer than I thought she would,” Jin said.

“Yeah, she doesn’t like big crowds of people.”

“Understandable. Not to change the subject, but I have more news.”

“You do?”

She smiled and pulled a key out of her pants pocket. “I thought you should have your own key.”

He looked down at the golden key in the center of her hand, and a lump rose in his throat. In the years following her abduction, he had thought he would never get her back, that she would never find her way back to him.

“I thought you should have it since you might start driving next week.”

He looked up at her.

“Never mind. I guess you’ll—”

He wrapped his hand around hers. “Are you asking me to move in with you?”

She drew in a deep breath. “I have no idea why I decided to do it in front of all these people.”

“Yes, with a caveat.”

She frowned. “What caveat?”

He laughed at her suspicious tone. “That you will consider marriage.”

“Right now?” He didn’t miss the panic in her voice.

“No. When you’re ready.”

She drew in a deep breath and nodded.

“Because I want a few of those,” he said, nodding toward the kids. “And I want forever with you.”

Tears filled her eyes. “Same.”

“Thank god, he’s moving out,” Nanii said.

“You’re rude,” he said.

She shrugged. “You needed to get out, and since she took pity on you, I’m okay with that.”

Since he agreed, he gave up the fight. He pulled Jin closer to him and sighed with happiness. This was all he needed. The woman, the family…all the love. That was what was most important to him and always would be.

Autumn was almost to her car when she heard the steps behind her. Ah, the SEAL was getting rusty.

“Did anyone ever tell you it’s not smart to follow a woman out to her car in the dark?” she asked without turning around.

“Where are you going?”

She stopped in her tracks and turned to face him. If he wasn’t a TFH member, she would definitely think about taking him to bed. He was built like she liked her men, all lean muscle, and he was a former SEAL. He could hold his breath for a really long time. But she never made the mistake of sleeping with a team member.

“I’m in my thirties. I haven’t answered to anyone since I turned eighteen, so maybe back off.”

“You’re acting weird.”

She cocked her head. “I’m always weird.”

“True, but this is weird even for you.”

Autumn wanted to laugh, but she didn’t. She’d learned at a young age not to trust a man who could get inside your head. Joseph had been a master manipulator, and she’d watched him destroy people, including her mother. She didn’t need some nosy SEAL figuring out what was going on with her. Especially since she was so close to getting her revenge.

“I have a thing with my friend Ian.”

Crossing his arms over his chest, he stared her down. It took every bit of her control not to fidget. It was a new feeling for her. Or at least as an adult. She had learned early on at Joyous Wave that showing emotions could be deadly. She didn’t want to give away anything. She felt this man could make her do that in a heartbeat. She was convinced it had more to do with him than his SEAL training.

“Do you?”

“I do. Since Ian doesn’t like crowds because, you know, that’s how spies feel all the time.” That was a lie. Ian loved a reason to dress up and mingle. It was one of the many things she didn’t understand about him. “So, see ya Monday, hopefully.”

“What does that mean?”

“That means I would like to have one weekend without a major incident so we can enjoy living in Hawai’i.”

He drew in a deep breath, and she knew he was trying to come up with something else, but she had to get out of there. She had kept her agenda hidden in all the time she had worked for TFH. Autumn wasn’t about to let some hot SEAL with bluish-green eyes convince her to tell her secrets.

Jesus, he was hot.

She pushed that thought aside. “Have a good weekend, SEAL.”

Before he could say anything, she walked away. It was a cowardly thing to do, but retreat was sometimes the smartest thing to do. With measured steps, she walked to her car. The whole time, she felt his eyes on her.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket just as she reached her car. Ian was always impatient, and her apartment scared him. He would never admit it, but the former spy freaked out. The apartment wasn’t in the best part of town. And yes, he was considered a master spy and now a first-rate security expert, but she understood. She didn’t like it. But when you were hunting a monster, you had to live among them.

She pulled her phone out of her pocket because it wouldn’t stop buzzing with texts. Most of them were cussing her out for being late. But the last one had her heart almost stopping, the ratchet up to a rhythm that would surely kill her. Cold dread shivered down her spine, seeping into her soul.

Ian: *He’s back. Watch your six.*

Thank you for reading Jin and Adam’s story! I hope you loved it as much as I did and if you could rate or review the book at your favorite online retailer, I would appreciate it.

Are you worried about what is coming for the team now that Team Bravo is about to start working with them? Well, you will get to find out this coming October in Justified Secrets, which is on preorder now at a discounted price.

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Everyone has secrets, but hers could get them both killed.

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Task Force Hawaii

The Harmless World is celebrating 20 years! There is something for everyone from sexy contemporary romance to military romance to romantic suspense. All books can be read as stand alone, but there is a handy dandy reading order at the bottom of this page!

- The Original Harmless Five
- Rough ’n Ready
- Harmless Trouble
- The Wulf Family
- A Little Harmless Military Romance
- Task Force Hawaii
- TFH Team Bravo

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Acknowledgments

This has been a long time coming and I am so grateful for everyone who helped along the way.

Big thanks to Scott Carpenter for the beautiful cover, and to Noel Varner for editing. I truly appreciate all your hard work. Thank you to my Westie Bestie Brandy Walker. You always know how to keep my spirits going when I want to throw in the towel.

Thanks to all the TFH fans who have stuck with me through the years. Your support means so much to me.

And finally, to my family. I can be super private about what is going on behind the scenes, but this book was one of the hardest things I have worked on in years. I didn't know if I would ever be able to finish it. My cancer treatment has left me with issues that can make some days a struggle. Les and my girls have been there to encourage me, to help me find a way to be productive. Thank you all for your help and love.

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About the Author

From an early age, USA Today Bestselling author Melissa loved to read. When she discovered the romance genre, she started to listen to the voices in her head. After years of following her AF Major husband around, she is happy to be settled in Northern Virginia surrounded by horses, wineries, and many, many Wegmans.

Keep up with Mel, her releases, and her appearances by subscribing to her NEWSLETTER. If you want to keep up with cover reveals, new behind the scene info on her writing, and when new excerpts are posted, follow her MelissaSchroeder.net News News. Or you can do both! They are low traffic, so you will not get tons of emails.

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